The Editorial Page: Net Zero transition brings opportunity to build, not just import, technology 8

MONDAY, NOVEMBER 9, 2026

The Indian EXPRESS

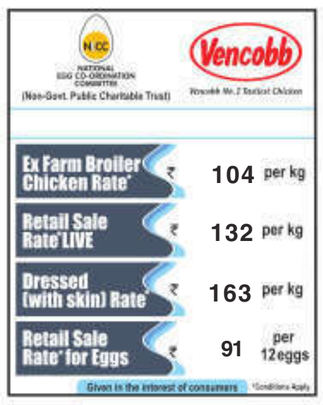
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Happening today

● **CLIMATE ACTION** will be in focus as world leaders, policy-makers and experts gather in Turkey for the 31st United Nations Climate Change Conference, or COP31.

● **SIGNIFICANT REDUCTION** in the prices of 137 anti-cancer drugs from various brands will take effect following the government's decision to cap trade margins.

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MODI CELEBRATES DIWALI WITH CRPF PERSONNEL IN BASTAR

Armed Naxals wiped out, must identify, defeat *dimagi* Naxals: PM

Says '*dimagi* Naxals' have infiltrated political parties, organisations, instigating people against Constitution, democracy

Express News Service
New Delhi, November 8

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Sunday said that while the country has won its decades-long battle against "Maoist terror", the "danger has not completely disappeared" as "intellectual (*dimagi*) Naxalites" have "infiltrated" several political parties and organisations and are instigating people against the Constitution and democracy.

Addressing security personnel while celebrating Diwali at a Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) camp in Karanpur in Chhattisgarh's Bastar district, Modi said: "Armed Naxalites have vanished from the forests, but intellectual (*dimagi*) Naxalites have captured many organisations. Even today, they are provoking people against the Constitution and democracy of the country. These intellectual Naxalites have also infiltrated several political parties and various organisations. We must identify them, defeat them, and secure the nation."

Modi said this was the first Diwali "when every district of the country is free from Naxalism". He said previous governments had "accepted Naxalism as an incurable disease and simply left it unattended". The political will to defeat Maoists

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Prime Minister Narendra Modi celebrates Diwali with the security forces in Bastar on Sunday. ANI

AFTER INDECISIVE POLLS LAST MONTH

Blow to Netanyahu as rival Eisenkot gets chance to form new govt in Israel

Will do everything I can to ensure we are worthy, says ex-Army chief

Melanie Lidman
Tel Aviv, November 8

ISRAEL'S PRESIDENT has designated Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's main rival, Gadi Eisenkot, as his choice to form the next government. President Isaac Herzog announced his decision late Saturday after days of consultations with the parties elected to parliament on October 27.

Herzog's decision is another blow to Netanyahu, who lost his parliamentary majority in the election. But it does not guarantee that Eisenkot will be the next Prime Minister. After an official ceremony Sunday, Eisenkot will launch complicated negotiations with potential coalition partners. He will have up to six weeks to form a government.

(***ENS adds:*** In a post on X, Eisenkot said: "Now is the time to form a national emergency government. I will do everything I can to ensure we are worthy.")

At the same time, Netanyahu will try to prevent Eisenkot from succeeding.



Gadi Eisenkot

e EXPLAINED

What next?

Gadi Eisenkot will have up to six weeks to form a government. If he fails, the President can select another candidate, who will have four weeks to do so. Then the parliament could back a third lawmaker, who would have 14 days to make a last-ditch attempt. If nothing succeeds, a new election will be called within 90 days, with Netanyahu staying on as a caretaker PM.

In Israel, people vote for parties, which form alliances. A coalition needs a majority of at least 61 seats in the 120-member assembly, known as the Knesset, to form a government.

Neither Netanyahu nor Eisenkot secured a majority in the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis at the house of drought-affected farmer Rambhau Balpande. DGIPR

CM spends Diwali with drought-hit farmer, announces relief for borewells

Ankita Deshkar
Nagpur, November 8

CHIEF MINISTER Devendra Fadnavis spent the Diwali night at the home of a small farmer in drought-hit Lohari Sawanga village in Nagpur district, sharing a traditional meal with his family and hearing first-hand accounts of crop losses, water shortages and the difficulties faced by farmers. Maharashtra has officially declared 305 of its 358 talukas as drought-hit.

The CM also announced temporary relief for farmers dependent on horticulture. Fadnavis said the state government would relax restrictions on digging agricultural borewells in select areas where fruit crops are the main source of livelihood. The relaxation will remain in force until December 15

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

PM praises Fadnavis

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Sunday praised Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis for spending Diwali with farmers in drought-hit Lohari Sawanga village in Nagpur district. PM Modi posted on X, "The gesture of Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis ji of spending Diwali with farmers in Lohari Sawanga village in Narkhed in Nagpur and stay at the residence of Arunabai and Rambhau Balpande is very touching. It underlines the spirit of compassion with which NDA government is working for the farmers and serving their well-being." ENS



During the muharat trading session at the NSE in Mumbai Sunday. SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

First since 2017, Sensex & Nifty end in red on Diwali; snap 7-day winning run

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, November 8

THE INDIAN stock market closed lower on Diwali, ending its seven-session winning run as investors booked some profit after the steep rally. Despite the run ending, the benchmark indices ended 8-9% higher for the week.

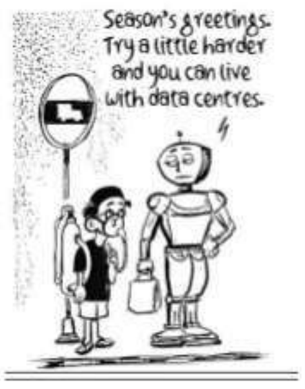
The Sensex shed 28.62 points to close broadly flat at 80,999.40 on Sunday, while the Nifty closed 0.2% lower at 24,986.40. This is the first time since 2017 that the benchmark indices have ended lower on Diwali. They have typically moved in a 1% range during these special sessions where trading lasts for just over an hour.

Investors remain positive

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



IDEA eXCHANGE



'The centralised governance model BJP implemented in Delhi is what AAP adopted in Punjab. We must demolish it'

PARGAT SINGH
PUNJAB CONGRESS CHIEF

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A vessel that the US Central Command said was hit as it tried to break the US blockade of Iran, in the Gulf of Oman, Saturday. X/@CENTCOM

Saudi Aramco building in Riyadh damaged after Houthi attack

Timour Azhari & Jana Choukeir
Riyadh, November 8

AN ADMINISTRATIVE building belonging to state oil giant Saudi Aramco in Riyadh was damaged by falling debris following an attempted attack on Sunday, with no injuries or fatalities reported, the kingdom's Energy Ministry said.

A *Reuters* witness saw blown-out windows across several floors of the Aramco Tower, one of the tallest buildings in the capital's King Abdullah Financial District.

The incident, which the ministry said caused limited damage, came after the Saudi-led coalition said it had intercepted two missiles fired by Yemen's Iran-aligned Houthis towards Riyadh. Aramco was not immediately available for comment, and there was no immediate statement from the Houthis.

Multiple loud booms were heard in Riyadh earlier on Sunday, a Reuters witness said, shortly after Saudi Civil Defense issued an early-warning alert of a potential threat in the region. Authorities later announced that the danger had passed.

The Saudi-led coalition that has been fighting the Houthis

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Out on drug bust, Bihar constable cornered and assaulted; body found in river 2 days later: Police

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, November 8

AROUND 7.45 pm on November 5, Bihar Police constable Dhaneshwar Kumar called up his colleagues in Jehanabad to inform them about a tip-off on a man allegedly involved in the purchase and sale of illegal arms and narcotics near the town's SS College. Dhaneshwar was associated with Tiger Mobile — a bike patrolling unit of the state's police force.

When two of his colleagues arrived, Dhaneshwar proceeded towards the college with them to verify the information and take action. What followed was a run-in with a group of 10-15 people, an alleged assault on the police personnel, and the disappearance of Dhaneshwar.

After his two colleagues filed a police complaint a day later, a search was launched for Dhaneshwar. The constable's body was recovered from the Dardha river on Saturday — two days after his colleagues saw him last.

Four people have been arrested in the case and police are now investigating the circumstances surrounding Dhaneshwar's death and why his two

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Constable Dhaneshwar Kumar was part of a bike patrol unit

● DARSHAN MAGDUM PERFORMED WITH THE BAND — BOY THROB — IN OCTOBER, NOW ON 'THE GREAT AMERICAN ROAD TRIP'

From Kolhapur village to American boy band: A 22-year-old's incredible journey

Sunanda Mehta
Kolhapur, November 8

"RANDOM" SEEMS to be Darshan Magdum's favourite word. The 22-year-old says he "randomly decided to sing in English" while growing up in a village in Maharashtra's Kolhapur, "randomly" began uploading his songs on social media, and got a "random call" last year from an all-American boy band Boy Throb in Los Angeles to join them. Now, he is in the US, even getting a chance to chat with New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani within weeks of arriving.

PAGE 1 anchor

As Darshan would say, all those random dots have started to connect.

Darshan grew up in Dundage village and pursued a Bachelor of Computer Applications degree in Belagavi, Karnataka. His parents are both teachers in the village: his father, B M Magdum, at a high school, and his mother, Rajeshree, for Classes 1 to 4. His elder brother, Omkar (27), works for a private firm.

No one in the family pursued music professionally, Darshan says, but singing was a shared hobby. "Everyone loves singing, and I also loved listening to songs, music from my childhood. So my parents enrolled me for classical singing for four years when I was about 10, after which I continued practising myself," says Darshan, speaking to *The Indian Express* from Los Angeles.

Around 2018-19, he began posting samples of his singing on Instagram. "It wasn't something I thought would be a career. It was just a hobby," he says. While most young singers around him covered Hindi songs, "I thought let's just start with English songs", he says.

After a few years, one video went viral, and others followed. Today, he has more than 200 videos on Instagram. Most people now know him, though, for his cover of "Blinding Lights", originally sung by the Canadian singer-songwriter Abel Tesfaye, popularly known by his stage name The Weeknd.



Darshan Magdum, 22, (centre) with members of the band Boy Throb in New Jersey.

Back in the village, all the attention was baffling. "They had no idea what I was doing. It was very new for them," he says. His father admits the family took time to understand it. "We come from a very simple background, so it took us some time to understand the kind of opportunities that content creation could offer. Even when Darshan started earning through his content, we weren't particularly impressed by the income. We would still encourage him to pursue his master's degree and find a stable job," says his father.

Around September last year came the message from the founders of Boy Throb, who were thinking of starting a boy band. "I was like, 'okay, man, is this real or are these just random texts from someone'? So I said, 'let's get on a call and check if it's real or just fun'."

On the call, the band members, Anthony Key, Evan Papier, Zachary Sobania and Darshan, discussed how it would work. An obstacle came up almost immediately: Darshan had never been to the US and had no visa. "They said, 'we got you'. We will do something for you," he says. So he signed up, jamming with the others over video calls. They never left him out, he says — at performances, they carried a cutout of him or put him on a screen.

Why did they choose him? "It's the love I get from the people. I think the band members saw the fun people had listening to me and they thought they needed to take my singing global. When we posted our first video saying I'm a member, we got amazing love on that," he says.

Finally, an O-1 visa application — a temporary non-immigration work visa for those with "extraordinary abilities" — was submitted around December, with the US authorities asking for further evidence of his eligibility. The band performed more and gathered media coverage. As their campaign for the visa went viral, they rewrote lyrics and retitled covers to "Darshan is the man we need" or "Darshan coming to America".

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

On candidate's plea, HC asks Gujarat govt to produce teacher recruitment timeline

Hospitalisation, missed verification cost aspirant teaching assistant job, says petition

Aditi Raja
Vadodara, November 8

THE GUJARAT High Court has directed the state government to produce the entire timeline of recruitment for a category of teachers, from April 2025, to ascertain if a vacant post was available to accommodate a candidate who had missed the process because of emergency hospitalisation.

Justice Aniruddha P Mayee was hearing a petition last month filed by Sushila Maheriya, through advocate Swapneshwar Goutam, stating that she missed the document verification process, between April 19 and April 25, 2025, in the recruitment drive for around 1,500 posts of Shikshan Sahayak (teaching assistant) because she was hospitalised following a seizure.

The plea, filed in June this year, stated that Maheriya "had suffered severe seizure on account of past history of brain stroke" and was admitted to hospital on April 17, 2025. She was discharged on April 19, 2025, the day the verification window for the recruitment opened.

The petitioner submitted that, owing to ongoing treatment, she could not approach the authorities during this window. She later made a representation to the state's Commissioner of Schools, a respondent in the petition, to consider her case for document verification "since the recruitment process was not completed," citing her medical reason for absence. That representation "has been rejected," the advocate said.

In the plea, the petitioner stated that she wrote to the authorities on June 16, June 18 and July 12, 2025, about her hospitalisation and missed verification. On July 16, 2025, the plea said, she was told that verification was over and her application could not be considered because the selection procedure was complete.

According to the plea, the government's letter reached the petitioner on July 29, 2025, after the final merit list for the post was published on July 17. The government subsequently issued a waiting list on September 19, 2025, the plea stated.

Issuing notice to the state government, the court in an oral order dated October 14 directed the Assistant Government Pleader to take instructions and file a reply before the next hearing on November 30. The reply, the court said, "shall enumerate the timeline of the process (from April 19, 2025) till the appointments were made to the various posts" and also state whether any post is vacant "as on date or not".

The petitioner submitted that she had withdrawn an earlier petition in the High Court in May 2025 to be able to make a representation to the state government's Education department. The submission stated that she was called for a personal hearing before the office of the Commissioner of Schools on December 4, 2025. The petition says the Joint Education Director referred the matter to the Staff Selection Committee. On December 24, 2025, her application was rejected on the ground that she "could have deputed" an officer or person for document verification. Further representations were rejected in January and May 2026, the plea stated.

HC directs Ahmedabad Collector to pay Rs 1 lakh for 'defying court order'

Aditi Raja
Vadodara, November 8

"FLAGRANT VIOLATION of the court's order" undermines the authority of the judiciary, the Gujarat High Court observed while directing the Ahmedabad Collector to pay Rs 1 lakh in litigation costs from his own salary after he rejected a woman's application for non-agricultural land use citing the same grounds which were previously set aside by the court.

Justice M K Thakker, while allowing a petition filed by Bhumika Rao, took serious exception to the Collector's decision to repeat the grounds on which his earlier rejection of the plea had been quashed. The court noted that despite being directed to reconsider the application within the statutory period, the Collector had again rejected it on substantially the same grounds. "Every person is required to respect and obey the orders of the court with due dignity for the institution. The government departments are no exception to it," the court observed.

It further noted that government departments and their functionaries must comply with judicial directions within the stipulated time. If they encounter difficulties in implementing an order, they are expected to approach the court promptly through appropriate legal remedies. "Where the government departments neither obeys the order nor approach the court in time, then only possible inference in law is that such party disobeys the order of the court. In other words, intentionally not carrying out the order of the court," it said.

It noted "flagrant violation of the court's order would reflect the attitude of the officer concerned to undermine the authority of the courts, its dignity and the administration of justice".

The case arose from Rao's application for permission to use agricultural land for non-agricultural purposes under Section 65 of the Gujarat Land Revenue Code, 1879. Rao challenged the decision before the HC in 2025. On March 2, the court quashed the rejection and directed her to submit a fresh application. It also directed the Collector to decide the application based on a 2019 precedent of the HC. However, the collector rejected the application again on August 6. Quashing the Collector's order, the court restored Rao's application to its original file and directed the Collector to decide it in accordance with the earlier judgment of 2025 within the statutory period.

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Armed Naxals wiped out, must identify, defeat dimagi Naxals: PM in Bastar

was "restored in 2014", he said.

"There was a time when more than 230 districts across nearly 20 states of the country were affected by Naxalism. After sunset, life would come to a standstill in these areas. It became impossible to step outside one's home. These Naxalites had even snatched away the people's right to vote. Bihar, Maharashtra, Odisha, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh, a very large part of the country was affected by Left-Wing Extremism. Thousands of villages and crores of people were trapped by it," he said.

"There were as many as two thousand Naxalite attacks in a single year. In 2010, nearby in Dantewada, 76 CRPF personnel were martyred in an encounter with Naxalites. In the same year, another incident in Dantewada claimed the lives of 44 innocent civilians... But not a single cry of grief was heard from those privileged leaders living in their palaces. Not even a single tear emerged from their eyes. Such attacks occurred repeatedly. This cycle continued for decades," he said.

"After 2014, we saw both the situation and the statistics begin to change. For years, discussions revolved around the number of security personnel being killed, compared to the number of Naxalites. But after 47 years, for the first time, not a single CRPF jawan lost his life during duty over the past year. This is the victory of the country's correct policies and firm resolve. This is the victory of your bravery, your courage, and your restraint," he said.

Modi said his government had taken many "tough decisions" in the interest of national security. "Previous governments had also tied the hands of the security forces fighting on the ground. Naxalite attacks kept taking place, but the security forces did not have the freedom to retaliate decisively. We gave the security forces the freedom to take every necessary decision. We also worked to stop the support that Left-Wing Extremism used to receive from certain people sitting within the government and the system," he said.

Apart from the security response, he cited other government policies that were rolled out in the LWE-affected areas, including construction of roads, installation of mobile towers, opening of Eklavya schools and industrial training institutes.

In March, Home Minister Amit Shah had announced in Lok Sabha that the country had become "Naxal-free". "We had set a target of March 31 for becoming Naxal-free. I will inform the nation after the final arrangements have been made, but I can say, without hesitation, that we have become Naxal-free," Shah had said on March 30.

According to government data earlier this year, LWE-related incidents and resultant deaths had fallen by over four-fifths since 2010. The number of LWE-affected districts had shrunk from nearly 200 in the early 2000s to just 38 by the end of 2025. A February 2026 review by the Ministry of Home Affairs showed that only seven districts -- five in Chhattisgarh, one in Jharkhand and one in Odisha -- were categorised as "LWE affected".

Muhurat trading: First time since 2017, Sensex and Nifty end in red on Diwali

on the outlook for Indian markets.

"From a market perspective, we believe the outlook for the coming Samvat (Hindu new business year) remains constructive, albeit with expectations of moderate and more selective returns," said Avinash Agarwal, Senior Vice-President and head of equity at Bandhan Life. Earnings growth, rather than valuation expansion, is likely to be the primary driver of market performance going forward, he added.

Sectoral indices ended mixed on Sunday, with pharmaceuticals and healthcare adding as much as 2%. Meanwhile, IT and financial services weighed, with heavyweights such as ICICI Bank and HDFC Bank ending lower. Broader market indices, which had sat out of the rally on Friday, saw robust gains.

Ramdeo Agrawal, Chairman and co-founder of Motilal Oswal Financial Services, said: "After two years of stagnation, market has the potential to give investors bumper returns by next Diwali, because of the confluence of low valuation and high earnings growth."

Benchmark indices

Date	Nifty % change	Sensex % change
8-Nov-26	-0.18	-0.04
21-Oct-25	0.10	0.07
1-Nov-24	0.41	0.42
12-Nov-23	0.52	0.55
24-Oct-22	0.88	0.88
4-Nov-21	0.49	0.49
14-Nov-20	0.47	0.45
27-Oct-19	0.37	0.49
7-Nov-18	0.65	0.70
19-Oct-17	-0.63	-0.60
30-Oct-16	-0.14	-0.04

SOURCE: BSE, NSE

Having fallen as much as 15% in 2026, Indian markets have got a significant boost in recent days as foreign investors have returned in droves following a drop in artificial intelligence (AI) driven markets such as US, Taiwan, and South Korea, with the latter two having fallen as much as 45% from their peaks. Foreign portfolio investors bought shares worth over $4 billion this week until Friday. This marks a big departure from what has prevailed for the better part of three years: from January 2024 to October this year, foreign investors have dumped $50 billion worth of Indian shares.

Fueling the fears about an AI investment reversal is the Democrats' resounding win in the US midterm elections, with investors concerned whether new lawmakers will slow down the construction of data centres. However, after a 5.5% fall on Thursday, the tech-heavy Nasdaq Composite rose 1.1% on Friday.

India, which was largely bypassed by the AI investment boom of the last year due to its low exposure to the new technology, has emerged as an 'anti-AI' play. Indian IT firms, which were decimated as their business came under pressure from the automation of several services from newer and newer AI models, have recovered some investor favour.

With the rupee stabilising after the Reserve Bank of India took measures on October 10 to make it more expensive to buy protection from a weaker rupee and removing oil marketing companies' demand for dollars from the open market, and companies reporting robust second quarter earnings, foreign investors have found reasons to buy Indian shares.

If the Democrats' midterms victory has hit AI firms, it has also raised hopes of the end of the war in West Asia, which should bring down global energy prices.

Experts consider crude oil prices as the biggest factor deciding the direction of the Indian market going ahead. The current winning run has coincided with fuel prices declining sharply to closer to $90 a barrel.

Meanwhile, in Israel, Gadi Eisenkot, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's strongest rival, has been tapped by President Isaac Herzog to form the new government following a deadlocked election in which neither was able to secure a majority.

In a sign that uncertainty remains, the India VIX — a pressure gauge of the market — gained for the third straight session on Sunday, ending 5% higher. This shows that uneasiness remains in the Indian market despite the strong rally over the past few sessions.

Fresh blow to Bibi

election. Netanyahu's coalition plunged from a peak of 68 seats to just 53. The opposition bloc, led by Eisenkot, won 48 seats, and Arab-led parties secured the other 19.

But after his consultations last week, Herzog decided that Eisenkot has the best chance of cobbling together a coalition. That is because the Arab-led parties said they were ready to support him.

It remains unclear, however, whether Eisenkot is willing or able to bring them into a future coalition. After three years of wars in Gaza and across the Middle East, cooperating with Arab-led parties is politically difficult.

Eisenkot faces significant challenges on the road to becoming Prime Minister. He has three options: a power-sharing agreement with Netanyahu, support from Arab-led parties — something several members of his bloc do not support — or an agreement with the ultra-Orthodox parties, which demand military exemptions for their community.

Eisenkot, a former army chief, and his partners made equal military service a central part of their campaign. Specifically, they are seeking an end to the long-standing draft exemptions enjoyed by the ultra-Orthodox.

After Herzog announced Saturday that he would tap Eisenkot, the candidate vowed to form a government as quickly as possible. But doing so will almost certainly require compromises or broken promises.

Netanyahu has repeatedly claimed the election was "stolen" by Arab parties, which rallied their supporters to vote in large numbers. But he has offered little evidence to support the claims. He is expected to continue his pressure tactics against Eisenkot, saying any alliance with the Arab parties would be an act of betrayal.

Israel's Shin Bet security agency has launched an investigation into possible foreign interference in the vote, but the country's Central Elections Commission — and Herzog — say the vote was valid and even if wrongdoing is found, it did not have a significant impact on the result.

Netanyahu called for a "national unity" government with Eisenkot on Saturday night. But it remains unclear whether the two rivals could agree on a power-sharing agreement, and these coalitions are fragile and often collapse.

Eisenkot has the option of forming a coalition with the support of the two Arab-led parties, which won an unprecedented 19 seats in the highest Arab election turnout. Only one Arab party, Ra'am, has ever joined a governing coalition, in 2021. Ra'am has said it will support Eisenkot, but the party does not have enough seats on its own to push Eisenkot into the majority.

Breaking with decades of precedent, the second Arab-led party, the Joint List, said it will support Eisenkot from outside the coalition to end Netanyahu's grip on power.

That cooperation is fraught for both sides. For the Joint List, it would mean backing a government unlikely to end Israel's wars or curb settlement expansion in the occupied West Bank. For Eisenkot and other opposition parties, it would mean aligning with parties that not only criticize Israel's policies but reject its identity as a Jewish state.

Eisenkot has laid out a series of conditions for any Arab party to join his coalition, including recognition of Israel as a Jewish state and declaring the Palestinian militant group Hamas a terrorist organization.

One of Eisenkot's partners, the more conservative Yisrael Beytenu party, already has said it will not join a coalition with Arab-led parties.

Eisenkot also says that any party that joins him must support mandatory military service or civil service. It remains unclear whether the ultra-Orthodox religious parties are prepared to compromise.

These religious parties, which were part of Netanyahu's outgoing coalition, want to preserve their military exemptions, which they say are needed to preserve their devout lifestyle. But the exemptions have grown especially controversial among the broader public during the past three years of war.

Anticipating its position as a swing vote, the ultra-Orthodox party United Torah Judaism has left the door open to cooperating with Eisenkot.

Israel's new members of Knesset will be sworn in on Tuesday evening. Netanyahu and his Cabinet will remain in office in a caretaker capacity, with limited powers, until a coalition is formed. – AP

American boy band

"We also collaborated with Kesha (the American singer and rapper), which really helped us," says Darshan. A lawyer advised that a million followers would do the trick, and it did. When the visa was announced on social media in August, the Internet erupted in joy.

Darshan arrived in the US in October for the band's first full performance together at New Jersey's American Dream mall. The band celebrated the day they all stood together in the same room as "Darshan Day".

Soon came the moment that lit up social media back home: a meeting with New York Mayor Mamdani, who took the band, dressed in their trademark pink and yellow, around City Hall. Darshan introduced himself, in Hindi, as being from Kolhapur.

"I just felt a connection with him. He's just so amazing. I got a positive energy from him, so I felt I should talk with him in Hindi, like he's my friend," says Darshan. "I will never forget that." Back home, the clip was circulated widely with a footnote on Darshan, saying, "He belongs to our village!"

Since then, the band has been on what they call the Great American Road Trip, from New Jersey and New York to Los Angeles, stopping at Chicago, Denver and other cities. Darshan, who had earlier visited only Thailand, lives with the group in LA and has taken dance classes for the first time to keep up.

For now, Darshan has a three-year visa but he doesn't plan to settle in the US. He will work "as long as there is work", and travel. The village is on board, and his parents couldn't be happier. "Everyone is so proud of me and watching me doing amazing things here and there," says Darshan. His plan is simple: "We want to make more music, give people joy. We see ourselves on a bigger stage."

Aramco building in Riyadh damaged after Houthi attack

subsequently said it had intercepted and destroyed two cruise missiles in Riyadh and the kingdom's southern region.

The Houthis have stepped up missile and drone attacks on Saudi airports, ports and oil facilities since fighting resumed in July and became another front in the wider Middle East war reignited following the US and Israeli attacks on Iran in February.

Saudi Arabia has carried out airstrikes against Houthi targets in Yemen.

Earlier on Sunday, Saudi Civil Defense issued and ☒later lifted warnings in several areas of the oil-rich Eastern Province, including Dhahran, home to the headquarters of state oil giant Saudi Aramco. The Eastern Province holds most of the kingdom's oil and gas reserves. Saudi Aramco's headquarters suffered extensive damage in an attack in October.

An attack on Riyadh's King Khalid International Airport on October 10 killed 13 people and wounded more than 300, according to Saudi authorities.

The renewed hostilities have shattered a 2022 UN-brokered truce that had largely halted fighting between the two sides. Saudi Arabia led a coalition of Arab states into Yemen in 2015 to restore the internationally recognised government after the Houthis seized the capital Sanaa. The latest escalation comes a day after Yemen's Houthi-run health ministry said Saudi airstrikes killed at least 33 people near Sanaa. Saudi authorities said they were investigating. REUTERS

Bihar constable assaulted, body found

colleagues did not inform the department about the case earlier.

Jehanabad Superintendent of Police (SP) Kota Kiran Kumar said the department received information about the disappearance of the constable deployed in the Mobile unit on November 6, following which an FIR was registered and an investigation initiated at the Town police station.

"On questioning suspects, police learnt that some local people had surrounded Dhaneshwar, assaulted him, and thrown him into the Dardha river," the SP said.

Police then searched the river and, on Saturday morning, recovered the body floating in the water near a ghat.

"Four people have been arrested in this case so far. We are investigating exactly how many more people were involved and how the entire incident unfolded. As evidence emerges, appropriate legal action will be taken against those found responsible for the death," the SP said.

According to a police official, who spoke on the condition of anonymity, when Dhaneshwar and the other two personnel reached near SS College, they noticed a man attempting to flee. They chased and apprehended him; the man identified himself as Vicky Kumar.

"During interrogation about the alleged arms and narcotics trade, the man reportedly told them about some weapons and contraband that had been concealed in the bushes some distance ahead," the official told The Indian Express.

"As Dhaneshwar moved towards the bushes, the apprehended man suddenly began shouting, 'Thief! Thief!' Within moments, around 10-15 people arrived at the spot, started abusing the policemen, and engaged in a scuffle with them," the source said.

The group then managed to free Vicky and continued attacking the police personnel with sticks and other weapons.

"Outnumbered by the attackers, the other two constables began retreating. They managed to reach their motorcycle, started it and moved some distance ahead, expecting their colleague to join them. However, Dhaneshwar did not turn up," the official said.

"When they subsequently tried contacting him over his mobile phone, it was found switched off," the official said, adding that it was only the following evening that the two constables approached Jehanabad Town police station.

On November 6, they submitted a written complaint against Vicky and 10-15 unidentified persons under rioting, wrongful restraint, voluntarily causing hurt, attempt to murder, assault on public servant, kidnapping, criminal intimidation, and other sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

Apart from Vicky, the other arrested persons were identified as Vikas, Pralhad and Gaurav. All of them are between 23 and 28 in age.

On Saturday morning, police recovered the body of the missing constable from the Dardha river near Nadiyawan village under Kako police station area. Preliminary investigation pointed towards the possible involvement of people associated with the illegal drug trade.

The deceased constable was a native of Ara district and had been working in Jehanabad since around 2022-23, according to the police.

CM spends Diwali with drought-hit farmer, announces relief

subject to permission from the administration and monitoring of groundwater extraction.

The restrictions had been imposed amid drought conditions across Maharashtra.

Fadnavis reached Lohari Sawanga in Narkhed taluka on Saturday evening and stayed at the residence of Rambhau and Arunatai Balpande.He attended a prayer meeting organised by the Gurudev Seva Mandal, interacted with villagers and had dinner with the family. The following morning, he visited agricultural fields and met farmers and local representatives.

The Balpande family prepared a traditional meal comprising varan-bhaat, zunka-bhakri, thecha, panchamrut, brinjal preparations, basundi and rava laddoos.

"We are very happy. It feels as if Pandurang himself has blessed us," Arunatai said, adding that Fadnavis sat on the floor and shared a meal with the family.

Rambhau, a farmer who grows oranges, sweet lime, soybean and cotton, told the CM about the losses suffered due to inadequate rainfall. Soybean crops had been affected, cotton plants had withered and farmers were also struggling with damage caused by wild animals. Explaining the decision to relax borewell restrictions, Fadnavis said the government was particularly concerned about the survival of fruit-bearing trees. "Farmers are facing a severe drought and several challenges. One major concern is the survival of horticulture crops due to the shortage of water. If fruit-bearing trees die, it can take 10-12 years for new trees to become productive. To protect these trees, we have decided to temporarily relax the ban on borewells in specific areas until December 15, with necessary permissions," he said.

He clarified that the relaxation would not be unconditional and that the administration would monitor groundwater extraction to prevent excessive depletion.

The CM also announced that 10 farmers in Lohari Sawanga would receive benefits under the irrigation well scheme. A storage reservoir estimated to cost Rs 2.43 crore would be constructed in the village to support irrigation, improve groundwater levels in nearby wells and strengthen drinking water availability.

Fadnavis said the government would undertake large-scale water conservation works, including farm ponds and cement bunds. He also referred to river-linking projects, including the Nalganga-Wainganga project, which he said would bring irrigation to 10 lakh hectares, and said the Marathwada Water Grid project would be expedited.

"Last night, I interacted with farmers and today I held discussions with sarpanches from across the taluka. Several different issues have been brought to our attention, many of which can be resolved. We will take action on the representations received. Some useful suggestions have also been made, and we will work towards implementing them. We have not turned anyone away and will extend whatever assistance is possible," he said.

He added that the government had made Rs 15,000 crore available through borrowings for irrigation projects that were at an advanced stage of completion. Over the past five years, nearly 97 projects had been completed and funding arranged for the remaining ones, he said.

The Chief Minister also said around 1.5 crore farmers had been provided Rs 5,000 to help them celebrate Diwali, with the transfer process underway.

During the interaction, villagers raised the issue of women sarpanches allegedly being harassed by people posing as journalists and demanding money. Fadnavis directed the police to take immediate action. "Those who are extorting money through blackmail will be jailed," he said.

Doctor gets 6 yrs in jail in ISIS case

Express News Service
Mumbai, November 8

A SPECIAL court designated under the National Investigation Agency (NIA) Act on Saturday sentenced a Pune-based doctor to six years' imprisonment after he pleaded guilty in an ISIS terror module case registered in July 2023. The court said there should be a "deterrent message" to ensure that such acts concerning national security "do not crop up within society in any form". Before his arrest, Adnananali Sarkar, a resident of Pune's Kondhwa area and a consulting anaesthetist at a leading private hospital, had allegedly supported the banned terrorist group ISIS along with his co-accused.

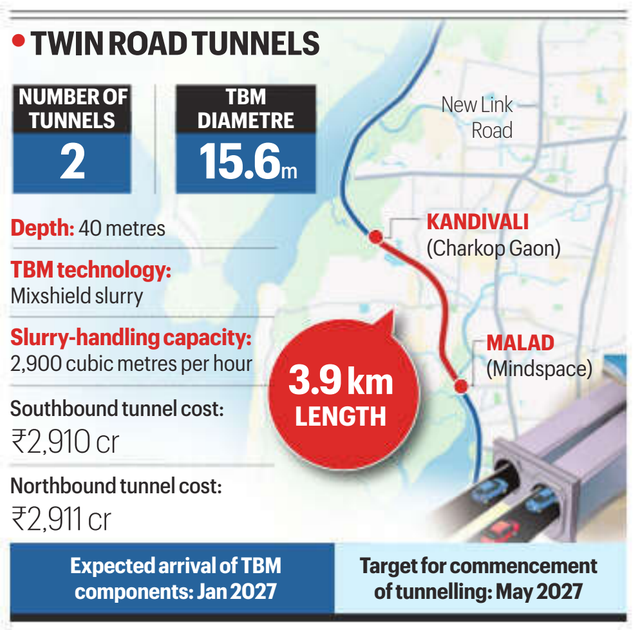
The NIA alleged that Sarkar had created a WhatsApp group to conduct lectures on "Jihad, khilafat etc." under the pretext of "religious preaching", with the aim of recruiting more members to promote ISIS ideology. The group was also allegedly used to share do-it-yourself (DIY) kits to train members in manufacturing improvised explosive devices (IEDs).

"Considering the gravity of the offence, undoubtedly, the applicant/accused is incarcerated since July 27, 2023, yet considering the circumstances and the role...there should be a deterrent qua a message to the society, wherein such an act should not crop up within the society in any form, more especially when it concerns national security being put at stake by such elements," special judge Abhay Y Joglekar held. The judge noted that while this was Sarkar's "first offence", the charges against him were "quite serious in nature".

Sarkar had pleaded not guilty when the court framed charges in the case on June 25 this year. However, on October 28, he moved an application before the special court seeking to record his voluntary plea of guilt. He sought the minimum sentence permissible under the law on humanitarian and mitigating grounds, or requested that the period he had spent in jail be treated as his sentence. Sarkar submitted that he had no criminal antecedents and that his wife, four children and aged parents were dependent on him.

Mumbai to get India's biggest tunnel boring machines for key road project

Express News Service
Mumbai, November 8



MUMBAI'S NEXT major underground road link is moving closer to construction, with components of two of India's largest tunnel boring machines (TBMs), which will dig the 3.9-km twin tunnels between Malad and Kandivali, expected to arrive in the city by January 2027. The Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) has completed the factory acceptance test of the machines in Chennai, with tunnelling scheduled to begin by May 2027.

The tunnels, which will run around 40 metres below ground, will connect Mindspace in Malad with Charkop in Kandivali and form a key part of the 22.93-km Mumbai Coastal Road North project. The project is being developed as an alternative high-speed north-south corridor between Versova and Dahisar. The BMC has appointed Megha Engineering and Infrastructures Ltd (MEIL) to execute the tunnel works, while the machines are being manufactured by Germany-based Herrenknecht. Each TBM will have a diameter of 15.6 metres, making them among the largest machines of their kind to be deployed in India.

The completion of the Factory Acceptance Test (FAT) marks an important step towards dispatching the machinery. The test checks the functioning of the machines' key systems before they are dismantled and transported to the construction site.

"After the consignments arrive, the machinery will be assembled at the Charkop site. We are aiming to commence tunnelling with the first TBM by May 2027," a senior BMC official said. Unlike several other road tunnels being constructed in Mumbai, the Mindspace-Charkop stretch passes close to creeks and mangrove areas, where soil conditions are more complex and groundwater ingress is a concern. The BMC has therefore opted for mixshield slurry TBMs, which are designed to operate in unstable, water-bearing ground conditions.

A slurry TBM excavates the soil while maintaining pressure at the tunnel face to prevent the surrounding ground from collapsing or groundwater from entering the excavation. The excavated material is mixed with water to form slurry, which is transported through a pumping system to a treatment plant. The machines being deployed for the project will have a slurry-handling capacity of 2,900 cubic metres per hour, an official said.

"While other road tunnel projects in Mumbai have largely used earth pressure balance machines in hard-rock conditions, this stretch runs close to creeks. A slurry TBM is better suited to the unstable ground and water-bearing conditions here," the official said.

Ahead of the machines' arrival, the BMC is carrying out piling work and constructing the launching shaft at Charkop, from where tunnelling will begin. Estimated to cost Rs 16,621 crore, the Coastal Road North project is planned as a 22.93-km corridor between Versova and Dahisar. It comprises multiple packages involving elevated roads, bridges and underground tunnels. The 3.9-km Mindspace-Charkop twin tunnels are among its key components. The northbound tunnel is estimated to cost Rs 2,911 crore and the southbound tunnel Rs 2,910 crore.

JJ School of Art opens PhD admissions for first time in 169 years, with 16 seats available

Pallavi Smart
Mumbai, November 8

IN A first in its 169-year history, the Sir J J School of Art, Architecture and Design has opened admissions to a PhD programme. The programme will cover three disciplines: art, architecture and design. The institute plans to hold its entrance test in December and begin classes by the second week of January.

The move follows the institute's elevation to a Deemed-to-be University under the De Novo category in October 2023. This category is reserved for institutions focused on innovation in teaching and research in highly specialised areas of knowledge that are not widely offered elsewhere. The elevation brought three sister institutions, Sir J J School of Art, Sir J J Institute of Applied Art and Sir J J College of Architecture, under a single university structure.

It also gave the institution greater autonomy to introduce new academic programmes, with the doctoral course being its latest addition.

Speaking to The Indian Express, Vice-Chancellor Professor Him Chatterjee said the university's executive council approved the PhD admission rules and regulations at its meeting on October 29. The institute has adopted University Grants Commission (UGC) norms for admissions and research supervision.

Although the university has a larger sanctioned intake, it has decided to fill only half the available seats in the first year to ensure adequate faculty and research supervision.

"We do not want to rush into filling all the seats in the first year. This will give us the space to conduct the programme effectively and open admissions for more seats next year. Once candidates are admitted, the seats remain occupied for at least three years, which is the duration of the PhD programme. We also need to develop more faculty members who are eligible to serve as research guides," Chatterjee said.

The School of Art has received 43 applications for six seats, while the School of Design has received nearly 37 applications for six seats. The School of Architecture has received eight applications for four seats.

NEW JAIL TO HOUSE 5,000 INMATES

Thane jail relocation: MSIDC asked to plan new site in Bhiwandi

Shifting existing prison could take up to a decade

Sadaf Modak
Mumbai, November 8



Thane Central Jail has an authorised capacity of 1,111 inmates but currently houses more than 3,500. FILE

THE PROPOSED relocation of Thane Central Jail has moved a step closer, with the Maharashtra State Infrastructure Development Corporation (MSIDC) asked to prepare a proposal for a new prison with a capacity of 5,000 inmates at a 50-acre site in Bhiwandi.

In a letter issued in October, the state Home Department directed the MSIDC to initiate the process, including inspecting the proposed site in Pise, Amane and Vashere localities of Bhiwandi taluka, which fall within the Thane Municipal Corporation's jurisdiction.

The department said the Cabinet proposal for relocating the jail was under consideration and called for immediate action to facilitate its approval. The MSIDC has also been asked to prepare maps, construction layouts and cost estimates for administrative approval through the Prison Department, an official said.

The relocation, however, is unlikely to happen soon. The new prison will have to be constructed and obtain the necessary approvals to function as a jail under the prison manual. Officials said the process could take up to a decade.

In 2025, the state Cabinet had given in-principle approval to relocate Thane Central Jail and Nagpur Central Jail. The proposal has since raised concerns over the distance of the proposed Bhiwandi site from courts and hospitals, as well as the future use of the existing jail land. Thane Central Jail has an authorised capacity of 1,111 inmates but currently houses more than 3,500. Spread over 43 acres, it is among the city's oldest prisons. The site was once a fort under Portuguese rule before being captured in 1737 by Chimaji Appa, a military commander of the Maratha Empire. The British took control in 1774 and converted it into a jail in 1838. It became a Central Prison in 1972.

The Thane Municipal Corporation's general body had sought its relocation in 2018, proposing that the historic structure be preserved and developed as a heritage and tourist precinct. The civic body has said a museum could come up on part of the land after the existing barracks are demolished.

Concerns over new site

BJP MLA Sanjay Kelkar has repeatedly raised concerns over the move in the Assembly, questioning whether the relocation was being driven by the area's real estate potential. In August 2025, after the in-principle approval, the Prison Department was reportedly directed to stop new construction at the existing jail, except for minor works.

Kelkar subsequently urged the Home Department to allow already-approved works to continue, pointing out that the new prison could take years to build. The proposed location, around 30 km from the existing jail, has prompted concerns among prison officials about access to courts and hospitals. Thane jail houses undertrials whose cases are pending before courts in South Mumbai, Dindoshi, Thane and Raigad.

While inmates are taken to Chhatrapati Shivaji Hospital in Kalwa for emergency care, those requiring specialised treatment are referred to state-run J J Hospital, which would be around 60 km from the proposed site. Officials have suggested that video-conferencing facilities could be used to produce undertrials before courts. The Samruddhi Mahamarg could also help reduce travel time for physical court appearances and hospital visits.

BLOOM SIMPLY STRAIGHT

BLOOM DEKOR LIMITED

CIN: L20210GJ1992PLC017341

Regd. Office: Survey No. 275, At & Post: Dhanap, N. H. No. 8, Opp. Ambemata Temple, Gandhinagar – 382355, Gujarat, India.
Corporate Office: 2/F, Sumel, S. G. Highway Road, Thaltej, Ahmedabad–380 059, Gujarat.
Tel. Phone: +91 – 79 – 2684 1916 / 17; **Fax:** + 91 – 79 – 2684 1914; **E-mail:** redressal@bloomdekor.com; **Website:** www.bloomdekor.com

UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULT FOR THE QUARTER ENDED ON SEPTEMBER 30, 2026

(₹ in Lakh except EPS)

Particulars	Quarter ended on			Half Year ended on		Year ended on 31/03/2026
	30/09/2026	30/06/2026	30/09/2025	30/09/2026	30/09/2025	
	Unaudited	Unaudited	Unaudited	Unaudited	Unaudited	Audited
Total Income From Operations	84.42	88.63	112.93	173.06	320.48	522.78
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(59.32)	(47.62)	(24.33)	(106.94)	(25.15)	(117.60)
Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(59.32)	(47.62)	(24.33)	(106.94)	(25.15)	(117.60)
Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(43.33)	(35.38)	(18.16)	(78.71)	(14.24)	(87.57)
Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	(43.23)	(35.28)	(18.16)	(78.51)	(14.24)	(87.17)
Equity Share Capital	118.22	685.00	685.00	93.50	685.00	685.00
Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve as per the audited Balance Sheet of the previous year)	–	–	–	–	–	(1,429.73)
Earnings Per Share (for continuing and discontinued operations)-						
Basic: (not annualzed for the quarter ended)	(0.37)	(0.52)	(0.27)	(0.84)	(0.21)	(1.27)
Diluted: (not annualzed for the quarter ended)	(0.37)	(0.52)	(0.27)	(0.84)	(0.21)	(1.27)

Note:- The above financial is an extract of the detailed format of quarterly Financial Results filed with the BSE Limited under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligation and Disclosure Requirements) Regulation, 2015. The full format of the quarterly Financial Results are available on the Website of BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and Company's website at www.bloomdekor.com.

For, Bloom Dekor Limited
Sd/-
Hardik Satishbhai Shah
Executive Director & CFO
(DIN: 09176711)

Date: 07/11/2026
Place: Ahmedabad

RADHIKA JEWELTECH LIMITED CIN : L27205GJ2016PLC093050

Registered Office : Kalawad Road, Opp. Swaminarayan Temple, Near Mahila College, Rajkot, Gujarat - 360 001

Statement of Financial Results for the Quarter and Half-Year Ended on September 30, 2026

(Rs. in lakhs except per share data)

Sr. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended			Half-Year Ended		Year Ended
		30.09.2026	30.06.2026	30.09.2025	30.09.2026	30.09.2025	31.03.2026
1	Total Income from Operations	14,869.28	15,258.85	13,343.45	30,128.12	23,266.69	64,008.29
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional items)	3,029.62	3,065.24	2,489.54	6,094.85	4,928.99	10,055.64
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional items)	3,029.62	3,065.24	2,489.54	6,094.85	4,928.99	10,055.64
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional items)	2,216.34	2,285.35	1,841.29	4,501.69	3,661.84	7,479.01
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	2,217.09	2,286.10	1,841.01	4,503.18	3,661.28	7,483.16
6	Equity Share Capital of Face Value Rs. 2/- Each	1,180.00	1,180.00	1,180.00	1,180.00	1,180.00	1,180.00
7	Earnings Per Share (of Rs.2/- Each) (for continuing & discounted operations) :						
	A: Basic	1.88	1.94	1.56	3.81	3.10	6.34
	B: Diluted	1.88	1.94	1.56	3.81	3.10	6.34

Notes : i. The above Results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at their meeting held on 03.11.2026.
ii. The above Financial Results have been prepared in accordance with Indian Accounting Standards (IND-AS) which are mandatorily applicable to the Company from April 1, 2021.
iii. The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarter & Year Ended Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The Full Format of the Quarter end Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchanges websites i.e. www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com as well as on the website of the Company i.e. www.radhikajeweltech.com.

For RADHIKA JEWELTECH LIMITED
Sd/-
Ashokkumar M. Zinzuwadia
(Managing Director) DIN: 07505964

Place: Rajkot
Date : 03.11.2026



Ajit Pawar had told me date of merger of NCPs: Sunil Tatkare

Manoj More
Pune, November 8

NCP STATE president Sunil Tatkare Sunday said there was no proposal or discussion about the party's possible merger with Sharad Pawar-led NCP (SP).

However, he also said that former deputy chief minister Ajit Pawar had told him the date of merger of the two parties. "There is neither any proposal nor any discussion on merger," Tatkare told The Indian Express.

"The issue of merger ended with the death of Ajit Pawar. After that, the situation changed. Sunetra Pawar became our national president. On the other hand, Supriya Sule also ruled out the possibility merger." Tatkare said that, earlier this week, he had responded to the question from the media regarding the possibility of merger of the two parties after November 10.

"Our leader Praful Patel had met Sharad Pawar in the hospital to enquire about his health. During their meeting, something was said about a meeting on November 10. When reporters asked me whether there was a chance of a merger after November 10, I said no, the chapter is closed...But I added that had Ajit Pawar been alive the merger would have happened on February 12. This is because Ajit Pawar had told me the date of merger," he said.

NCP denies merger talks as Parth visits Sharad Pawar again

Party clarifies Parth attended a family lunch of the Pawar family on first day of Diwali

Alok Deshpande
Mumbai, November 8

AMID SPECULATION about a merger between the two Nationalist Congress Parties, ruling NCP leader and Rajya Sabha MP Parth Pawar on Sunday made a second visit to his granduncle and opposition NCP (SP) supremo Sharad Pawar. The NCP clarified that since the Pawar family would not be celebrating Diwali this year, owing to the drought and the death of Parth's father, Ajit Pawar, a family lunch was held on the first day of Diwali, which Parth attended.

"There is no talk of merger within the NCP. It is not even discussed. It is insensitive to even discuss such political moves while Sharad Pawar ji is recovering," said NCP chief spokesperson Umesh Patil.

Patil said that all reports about a merger between the two parties were being spread without any authority and were nothing but hearsay.

"Those with vested interests are spreading these news. How and why should two parties be merged? There has been no discussion whatsoever about it," he said.

Parth had also visited Sharad Pawar's residence, Silver Oak, on Saturday, where he spent nearly two hours. On Sunday, he was there for over two hours. Earlier, sources within the NCP had claimed that merger talks were entering the final stage and that a secret meeting involving Parth, Deputy Chief Minister and his mother Sunetra Pawar, and his aunt and NCP (SP) working president Supriya Sule was held at Breach Candy Hospital two days ago. However, none of the alleged participants has confirmed this.

Despite the merger speculation, NCP (SP) MLA Rohit Pawar has opposed the move, saying not only that there were no talks about it but also that the matter had not even been discussed within his party.

EXPRESS special

Eyeing 2029 polls, state Congress plans 'connect centres' across all parliamentary constituencies

Alok Deshpande
Mumbai, November 8

LOOKING TO strengthen its organisation ahead of the 2029 Lok Sabha elections, the Maharashtra Congress plans to set up a network of connect centres covering all 48 parliamentary constituencies in the state.

The centres will establish direct communication between booth-level workers and the state leadership, monitor grassroots activities and provide feedback on the party's organisational performance.

The proposed centres will each have at least 16 desks, with every desk covering three parliamentary constituencies or 18 Assembly segments.

The aim is to establish a system of regular, two-way communication between the party leadership and grassroots workers. "The idea is to transform the Congress from a party that merely has an organisational presence into a dynamic, organisationally active and communicatively vibrant force," Dr Sirivella Prasad, All India Congress Committee (AICC) in-charge of Maharashtra, told The Indian Express. Prasad said establishing systems for the smooth functioning of the state unit would be among his priorities following his appointment as the Maharashtra Congress in-charge, particularly with an eye on the 2029 elections. The centres will go beyond collecting feedback and coordinating organisational communication. They will also monitor grassroots political activities undertaken in coordination with the state committee, including voter list verification, protests, formation of local committees and targeted campaigns.



Sirivella Prasad, AICC in-charge of Maharashtra, said the centres gather feedback from the organisation. @SIRIVELLAPRASAD/X

Another focus will be reviving inactive party workers through digital platforms and personal outreach, using membership records and data from the Congress party's Shakti programme, which sought to strengthen the party's grassroots organisation by connecting workers directly with leaders.

The centres will also track the functioning of mandals and blocks, with observers and AICC-appointed coordinators providing support to local units.Prasad said the centres would not function as conventional call centres or back offices of the state committee, but as an important channel for gathering and analysing feedback from the organisation. "This will be one of the most important feedback channels for the state unit. It will be a communication channel reaching the last party worker and provide qualitative and quantitative inputs for informed decision-making," he said. The centres will also maintain records of activities undertaken by party leaders at the district and mandal levels and assess their political impact.

These records could be taken into account while deciding organisational positions and appointments, Prasad said.

Maharashtra Industrial Township Limited
(A Government Undertaking)
Regd. Off.- Udyog Sarathi, MIDC Office, Marol Industrial Area, Andheri East, Mumbai-93
Tel. No. 022-26879956 website: www.auric.city CIN: U74999MH2014SGC260132

EXPRESSION OF INTEREST

Selection of City Manager for Operation and Maintenance of, Roads, Drains, Culverts, Minor and Major Bridges, Water Supply, Sewerage, Sewage Treatment Plants, Common Effluent Treatment Plants, ICT Infrastructure and Associated City Infrastructure at AURIC Shendra Bidkin Industrial Area, Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, Maharashtra on Public Private Partnership (PPP) Basis.

(Tender No.: MITL/SBIA/EOI/2026-27/01)

The tender details are available at **https://aitl.eproc.in, www.auric.city.** Interested applicants are requested to submit their document responses online by 1500 hrs on or before 26th Nov 2026. A non-refundable processing fees of INR 25,000/- + GST shall be paid along with the submission through MITL's online e-procurement portal.

Sd/-
Managing Director, MITL

BANGALORE WATER SUPPLY AND SEWERAGE BOARD
Office of The Chief Engineer (Kaveri), 5th Floor, Cauvery Bhavan, KG Road, Bangalore-560009.

No: BWSSB/CEKTE/TA/15/2026/368/2026-27 Date: 05.11.2026

INVITATION FOR TENDER
(Through KPP portal only)

BWSSB, invites tenders in two stage tender system from eligible contractors for the work of **Construction of Roads and Side Drains inside Chokkanahalli (65ML) GLR premises.**

Amount put to tender: **Rs.125.093 Lakhs.** EMD: **Rs.2.00 Lakhs.** Last date and time for Receipt of tenders will be on **24.11.2026 upto 15.00 hours.** The bids will be opened on **25.11.2026 after 16.00 hours.** The details regarding the tender and participation in the kpp portal process can be obtained by logging on to **https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in** For further details contact the signed office during working hours.

Sd/-
DIPR/CP/AAPL/RO3611/26-27 Chief Engineer (Kaveri).





Welcoming Diwali at Dawn

Youngsters from various parts of Thane gathered in the Masunda Lake area during Diwali Pahat celebrations on Sunday. DEEPAK JOSHI

Man throws acid on friend, four injured in attack

Pune: A man was arrested for allegedly throwing acid on his friend following a dispute in Yerawada area of Pune, injuring him, his mother and two other persons, including a six-year-old girl, a police official said on Sunday. The incident took place near Ramnagar Masjid on November 6.

"Nitin Sundar Jadhav used to have frequent arguments with his friend Ashish Indrapal Dingya. After one such argument, Jadhav purchased acid from a hardware shop and threw it on Dingya's face," Lakshmi Nagar senior inspector Yuvraj Nandre said. **PTI**

TENDER NOTICE
GOVERNMENT OF MAHARASHTRA
WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT
Konkan Irrigation Development Corporation, Thane, Office of the Executive Engineer
Hetwane Medium Project Division, Kamarli, Tal.Pen, Dist. Raigad - 402107
Email id:-eehmpd@rediffmail.com Telephone No.02143-278011
E-Tender Notice No. 12 For 2026-2027

Online E-Tenders in the B-1 form are invited by the Executive Engineer, Hetawane Medium Project Division, Kamarli, Tal:-Pen, Dist-Raigad, Water Resources Department, Government of Maharashtra for the following work for the experienced and eligible Contractors qualifying criteria. The tender Document can be downloaded from the Government of Maharashtra's Web Site-https://www.mahatenders.gov.in. Superintending Engineer, North Konkan Irrigation Project Circle, Kalwa, Thane reserves the right to reject any or all tenders without assigning any reason thereof. Conditional tenders will be summarily REJECTED.

Sr. No.	Name of Work	Estimated Cost Put to Tender	EMD	Work completion period	Tender cost	Class of contractor
1	Internal Cleaning of inspection gallery of Hetawane Dam.	Rs. 1,51,06,800/-	Rs. 1,50,000/-	06 Months (including Monsoon.)	Rs. 2,000/- + 360 (18% GST) Total Rs. 2,360	Eligible Bidders Qualifying Criteria.

Shedule of E-Tender

Sr. No.		Beginning		End	
		Date	Time	Date	Time
1	Period of availability of E-Tender Document	09.11.2026	11.00	16.11.2026	18.00
2	Date of Bid Submission	09.11.2026	11.00	16.11.2026	18.00
3	Date of Techniqual Envelope opening	17.11.2026	18.00	Executive Engineer Hetwane Medium Project Division, Kamarli Tal:- Pen, Dist- Raigad.	

The information regarding E-tender will be available at the following places
1. On the Website http://www.mahatenders.gov.in
(If there is any change in this tender notice it will be informed on the above website)
2. Onthe Notice Board of Executive Engineer, Hetawane Medium Project Division, Kamarli, Tal : Pen, Dist Raigad.
3. If the Bidder have any Queries they shall contact through Seek Clarification option provided in the portal The last date to submit any Queries is 13.11.2026 till 6.00 PM

Note - The Right to revise or amend this notice and or the Bid Documents fully or Partly, prior to the last date notified for submission of offers or on any subsequent date is reserved by the Competent Authority.

Out No. :-
HMPD/AB-1/E-Tender/2451/2026.
Hetwane Medium Project
Div, Kamarli Tal, Pen, Raigad
Date:- 04 /11/2026
DGIPR-2026-27/3710

Sd/-
(D. K. Rajbhoj)
Executive Engineer
Hetwane Medium Project Division, Kamarli
Tal:- Pen, Dist- Raigad

IHCL, Ambuja Neotia plan Rs 2,700 cr hotel expansion in Bengal

Purnima Sah
Kurseong, November 8

INDIAN HOTELS Company Limited (IHCL) and Ambuja Neotia Group have announced plans to invest Rs 2,700 crore in hospitality projects across West Bengal, with several new properties planned in North Bengal, including in Siliguri, Ghum, Kalimpong and Lataguri.

The proposed expansion comes as hotel operators look beyond established destinations such as Darjeeling and Siliguri. On November 1, the partnership unveiled an expanded Taj Chia Kutir Resort & Spa at Makaibari tea estate near Darjeeling. The property, which opened in 2020, has added 28 rooms and 15,000 sq ft of banqueting space at an investment of Rs 100 crore. IHCL Managing Director Puneet Chhatwal said tourism was gradually extending beyond traditional circuits, aided by improved highways, air connectivity and changing travel habits.

"From here till Darjeeling, there is nothing that comes on the way, practically nothing, so there is a lot to be done," he told The Indian Express, pointing to opportunities in destinations such as Ghum and Kalimpong.

He said the Covid-19 pandemic had changed domestic travel patterns, with more people opting for self-drive holidays, extended weekends and more frequent trips. Developing tourism markets in eastern and northeastern India, he said, would be a "10-to-20-year journey", with travellers from cities such as Mumbai, Delhi and Bengaluru emerging as potential customers. The North Bengal pipeline includes the 57-room Taj Himya Kutir and 10 branded villas in Ghum, the 140-room Taj Terai Kutir in Siliguri and the 30-room Taj Vanya Kutir in Lataguri. Other planned properties include AltAir House hotels in Kalimpong and Lataguri and a Tree of Life property in Siliguri. Ambuja Neotia chairman Harshavardhan Neotia said a change in West Bengal government policy after the pandemic had allowed tourism-related development on tea-estate land.

"The state allowed 15 per cent of tea-estate land to be used for tourism-related activities," he said.

Development in the hills, he said, would need proper environmental impact assessments and construction planning.

The reporter was at Taj Chia Kutir Resort & Spa, Darjeeling on the invitation of Ambuja Neotia and IHCL

MUMBAI CONFIDENTIAL

A dozen accused, dressed alike

When the 12 accused, all aged between 18 and 25, were brought before a special court on Friday for a remand hearing in connection with the alleged attack on actor Tiger Shroff, they appeared to have arrived in uniform of sorts. All 10 men and two women were wearing similar, if not identical, white T-shirts bearing the logo of an American clothing brand. The matching outfits caught attention, prompting questions about whether the group had coordinated their attire. Police personnel accompanying them had a more practical explanation. The accused have been in custody for nearly 20 days, and the investigating team appears to have arranged a bulk supply of the T-shirts, either from a street near the Mumbai Crime Branch office known for its fast-fashion stores or through an online order.

Gokul row on WhatsApp statuses

In Kolhapur, supporters of Congress leader Satej Patil have found a way to make their opposition to the Mahayuti government's decision on Gokul heard, quite literally, through their mobile phone screens. Thousands have reportedly put up a common Marathi message as their WhatsApp status under the banner of 'Maha Politics'.
The message alleges that the government's move to appoint four non-elected members to Gokul after the elections is an attempt to take control of the cooperative body, rather than promote development. It also carries a warning for CM Devendra Fadnavis: meddling with the natural course of things will have consequences, and "destiny does not spare anybody".

Agencies charging farmers for MSP registration face blacklisting by state govt

Vallabh Ozarkar
Mumbai, November 8

TAKING NOTE of complaints that farmers were being charged to register for government procurement of paddy and coarse grains at Minimum Support Prices (MSP), the Maharashtra government has directed all procurement agencies to make registration free of cost. Agencies found demanding money could face blacklisting, including permanent blacklisting.

In a circular issued on November 5, the Food, Civil Supplies and Consumer Protection Department said there was no provision for collecting any fee for registering farmers under the MSP scheme. Despite repeated instructions, the department had received complaints that procurement agencies were demanding money from farmers during registration.

The government has directed procurement centres not to charge any registration fee, commission or additional amount under any circumstances. District Collectors have been authorised to blacklist or permanently blacklist agencies found violating these directions.

भिवंडी निजामपूर शहर महानगरपालिका, भिवंडी
बांधकाम विभाग
ई-निविदा सुचना क्र. ६७ सन २०२६-२७

खालील काम करण्यासाठी सक्षम व अनुभवी ठेकेदारांकडून ई–निविदा मागविण्यात येत आहे.

अ. क्र	अंदाजित खर्च/निविदा फॉर्म फी/ कामाचे स्वरुप	अंदाजपत्रकीय रक्कम	निविदा विक्री व स्विकारण्याची अंतिम दिनांक
१	प्रभाग समिती क्र.४ च्या कार्यक्षेत्रातील सभापती व सहाय्यक आयुक्त यांचे कार्यालय दुरुस्त करणे.	२४,९५,५४४/–	दिनांक :– ०९/११/२०२६ दिनांक :– १६/११/२०२६
२	वॉर्ड क्र.७ मधील इदगाह झोपडपट्टी येथे गुड्डू यांचे घर व अशफाक पानपट्टी जवळ १६ सिट शौचालय बांधणे.	२१,२५,०००/–	

सदर निविदा बाबतची माहिती **mahatenders.gov.in** या संकेतस्थळावर **दि.०९/११/२०२६ ते दि.१६/११/२०२६** रोजी पर्यंत उपलब्ध आहेत. ऑनलाईन निविदा संकेतस्थळावर **दि. १६/११/२०२६ रोजी दु.** ४.०० वाजे पर्यंत स्विकारण्यात येतील.

सही/–
शहर अभियंता
भिवंडी निजामपूर शहर महानगरपालिका

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EDUCATION

EDUCATIONAL

Dowsing & Vastudosh Global Standard Workshop, organized by School of Indian Dowsers and Geomancy on Online Zoom, Batch 218, on 15th and 22nd November, two Sundays, Practical Workshop, morning 9:30 AM to 2 PM. Complete registration call and bank payment via mobile. Kit delivered to your doorstep. Lecher Antenna Cosmic Energy 2-day global standard training, 28th batch, 12th and 13th December, full day in Dadar, Mumbai, including a site visit. Syllabus covered in both workshops : Vastu Energy, Land Testing and Defects, Health and Healing,Geopathic Stress, Harmful Water, Detailed advanced curriculum. More Information & Contact on Website : Hundreds of photos and reviews/ feedback are available on https://www.indiandowsers.org Watch four videos on YouTube Channel : Dowser's Diary. Contact : Prof. Ravi Vaidya Sir, Principal Dowser, Mobile : 9821349038/ 9821380289.
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Train runs over three in Bikaner, one injured

Jaipur: Two men who reportedly went onto a railway track to rescue a quarrelling couple were hit by a train, killing three people and seriously injuring another in Bikaner district on Sunday, police said.

The incident occurred on the Gharsisar railway track in the JN Vyas Colony police station area of Rajasthan.

According to preliminary information, a couple reached the railway track while arguing. Two men reportedly went onto the track in an attempt to rescue them when a train approached, resulting in the accident.

The train stopped at the spot following the incident. Government Railway Police (GRP) and local police teams reached the site, and the injured man was taken to hospital.

SHO Devendra Singh said one of the deceased was identified as Sanjeet Mochi, a resident of Darbhanga in Bihar. The identities of the other two deceased have not been established. PTI

Karnataka widens ethanol probe to distribution network, CM slams Centre

Express News Service
Bengaluru, November 8



Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar and his wife Usha offer prayers at Sri Hassanaamba Temple in Hassan on Sunday. ANI

KARNATAKA'S PROBE into alleged excessive ethanol blending in petrol has extended beyond retail outlets to fuel distribution and blending agencies. Chief Minister D K Shivakumar said Sunday that officials were collecting samples, records and documents from multiple stages of the fuel supply chain as part of an ongoing probe by the Food, Civil Supplies and Legal Metrology Department.

Addressing reporters, CM Shivakumar said the government had taken serious note of complaints from motorists that higher ethanol content in petrol was affecting vehicle performance and fuel efficiency.

"Inspections were carried out not only at petrol pumps but also at various stages where ethanol is being blended and distributed. Documents detailing where and how the blending is being done have also been collected," he said. Food and Civil Supplies Minister Rizwan Arshad is scheduled to release a detailed report on Monday.

Shivakumar said petrol samples were collected and tested at 67 locations across Karnataka following complaints that ethanol blending levels had exceeded prescribed limits. "In light of complaints that engine performance in vehicles is being adversely affected due to the increased proportion of ethanol in vehicle fuel, petrol samples were collected and tested at 67 locations across the state. The minister concerned will provide details regarding the inspection report and the next course of action," he said.

The government, he said, has taken serious note of complaints regarding 31.5 per cent ethanol being blended into petrol. Hitting out at the Central government, Shivakumar said that fuel quality, vehicle performance and public safety should not be compromised.

"The Central government cannot shirk responsibility on this matter. It is not right to increase the blending ratio simply to profit from ethanol being available at a lower cost. Causing inconvenience to the public is not acceptable," he said. He attacked the state BJP and Janata Dal (Secular) leaders for being silent on the issue.

Arshad released details of an inspection on Friday, claiming that laboratory tests on petrol samples collected across Karnataka found ethanol content significantly above the prescribed E20 limit.

According to Arshad, samples collected from multiple districts and tested at NABL-accredited laboratories showed ethanol content of up to 31.2 per cent in an Indian Oil sample and 30.5 per cent in a Hindustan Petroleum sample, with most tested samples allegedly exceeding the 20 per cent threshold.

Arshad said the state had initially sought ethanol-content data from oil companies but turned to independent laboratories after the information was allegedly not provided.

He has urged the Union Government to take action against companies found violating blending norms, make ethanol-content disclosure mandatory at fuel stations, and establish a compensation mechanism for consumers affected by vehicle damage linked to over-blending.

Kanpur: Woman fatally rams Thar into scooter rider, flees in another car

Manish Sahu
Kanpur, November 8

A SPEEDING Mahindra Thar allegedly driven by a woman killed a scooter rider in Kanpur's Kalyanpur area on Saturday evening after ramming into and dragging his two-wheeler for several metres before it crashed into a roadside railing, the police said.

According to the police, Santosh Singh Chauhan, 55, was returning home from a market when the accident occurred. After hitting the scooter, the SUV went out of control and crashed into the garden of a nearby house. Two women who were travelling in the vehicle abandoned it and fled as people began gathering at the spot.

Police sources said a 24-year-old woman, belonging to a business family, who was suspected of driving the SUV at the time of the accident had been detained for questioning.

After receiving information about the accident, a police team rushed to the spot in Awas Vikas Colony and shifted Chauhan to a hospital, where doctors declared him dead.

S M Qasim Abidi, Deputy Commissioner of Police, Kanpur, said an FIR has been registered at the Kalyanpur police station and the SUV seized.

"We have traced the vehicle's registered owner, and an inquiry is underway to establish who was driving it at the time of the accident," said Keshav Kumar Tiwari, station house officer in Kalyanpur.

Chauhan resided in Kanpur's Panki area. His son Rahul Singh reportedly reached the accident site shortly afterwards using the GPS tracker installed on his father's scooter.

The police will send the SUV for a technical examination to ascertain the collision's circumstances. As people gathered at the spot following the crash, the two women allegedly got out of the SUV and left in another car driven by a man. He reportedly arrived there after the women called him to the spot.

SHO Tiwari said the police were verifying the circumstances under which the two women left the accident site and identifying the vehicle they used to flee. The police sent the body for a postmortem examination.

EXPRESS special

Raipur man who went to Russia for job lands in jail, now family seeks CM, police's help

The family has alleged that he was pushed behind bars on fake charges

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, November 8

IN SEPTEMBER, 38-year-old Tikeshwar Sahu from Raipur left home for Russia. He had received a job offer through Telegram and had hoped to secure a better future for his wife, two children and parents. He also had plans to bring them over to Russia in the future.

Days later, he informed his family that he was in jail over trumped up charges and was being forced into joining the Russian Army in its war against Ukraine.

On November 4, Sahu's wife Manorama wrote to Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai and Raipur Commissioner of Police, Sanjeev Shukla, seeking a probe, diplomatic intervention, legal assistance, medical care, and his safe return to India.

The Sahus' case bears a striking resemblance to the plight of another family in Chhattisgarh. Last month, *The Indian Express* had reported about 21-year-old Vineet Kumar Dubey from Bilaspur who had left for Russia on September 29. Like Sahu, he had also travelled on a tourist visa after receiving a job offer through Telegram. Families of both the men said neither had been adequately informed about the nature of the work before leaving India.

A senior official from the Raipur Police Commissionerate, requesting anonymity, told The Indian Express, "We have received the complaint (in Sahu's case). As per procedure, we shall send it to the state home department, which, in turn, will send it to the Ministry of External Affairs for further action."

Sahu's family said they last shared a normal call with him on September 16 before his phone was switched off. For the first few days, they thought he was facing network problems amid the war.

But a few days later, they received a picture of a hand-written letter on their phone. It was a Russian number but the handwriting was unmistakably Sahu's. In the letter, he claimed that he was being falsely implicated in a case involving illegal substances and was being forced to join the Russian Army, said a family member.



Tikeshwar Sahu

After they made repeated requests to the number, Sahu was allowed to make a five-minute video call to his family.

"He was crying a lot on the phone. He told us that he was in jail. He said he was being pressured to join the Russian Army," the family member said.

Sahu, who worked as a store manager in Raipur, was promised a lucrative job as a delivery agent in Russia and was told that his tourist visa would be converted into a work visa once the job was confirmed, said his family members. Sahu left Raipur for Delhi on September 7 and travelled to Russia the following day, reaching Moscow before flying to Volgograd. On arrival, he was given 5,000 Russian rubles by the person who promised him a job.

His relatives alleged that he was being pressured into signing documents declaring his consent to join the Russian military.

The family said it was worried about Sahu's health, particularly because he has a thyroid condition for which he takes medication. They alleged that he had not received his medicines after being detained and had also been assaulted.

To secure his release, the family hired a lawyer in Russia. They have spent Rs 1.5 lakh on his fees. On October 22, the lawyer informed them that Sahu had been hospitalised after his blood pressure rose, they said. The family has not received a clear update on his condition or when he might be released.

His relatives alleged that Sahu was being pressured into admitting that he was supplying an illegal substance, and feared the accusation was being used to prolong his detention and force him into military service.

Sahu's relatives said they had emailed the Indian and Russian embassies. While the Russian embassy had not responded, the Indian embassy, in an email reply, told them it was trying to ascertain the details and would provide an update, they said. The family also approached the DGP headquarters in Naya Raipur in September. They subsequently approached political leaders and the state secretariat, and filed an application through the Prime Minister's grievance portal.

The family's financial state has worsened as they struggle to pay the Russian lawyer before each hearing. But right now, their only concern is to get Sahu home, safe and sound.

"We want the government to intervene and bring him back. We do not know what is happening to him, and we are extremely worried about his health," a relative said.

Newborn among three of a family killed in Kanpur roof collapse

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, November 8

THREE MEMBERS of a family, including a 21-day-old newborn, were killed after the roof of two rooms in their house collapsed while they were asleep, trapping them under the debris in Kanpur early Sunday morning.

The police said the roof was in dilapidated condition and that wooden beams had been placed at several points to support the structure, suggesting it had weakened over time. The sudden collapse left the occupants with little time to escape, burying them under the rubble.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Kanpur West) S M Qasim Abidi said the mishap took place at around 8 am in the Panki Padav area.

Several people rushed to the house and informed the police. Residents and police personnel launched a rescue operation. After clearing the debris, rescuers pulled out all four family members trapped underneath and rushed them to a nearby hospital. Doctors declared three of them dead, while the fourth victim, who sustained serious injuries, remains critical and is undergoing treatment.

The dead were identified as Vinodini Shukla, 60; her daughter-in-law Anshika Shukla, 28; and Anshika's newborn son Aarav Shukla. Vinodini's son Harsh Shukla, 32, sustained serious injuries and is currently undergoing treatment.

Woman held for assaulting minor over Instagram messages in Kochi

Press Trust of India
Kochi, November 8

A 40-YEAR-OLD woman was arrested on Sunday for allegedly joining her son and his friends in assaulting a 17-year-old boy over to Instagram messages in Edappally, police said.

The assault took place on Saturday in Changampuzha Road, Edappally North, leaving the boy injured, they said.

According to police, the boy and the woman's son had studied together until Class 10 and were now doing Plus Two in different schools. The boy and some of his friends had created a common Instagram account. He found that his friends had sent obscene messages to several women through the account.

On Saturday, he was taken to the woman's rented house, where the woman and seven juveniles allegedly assaulted him and recorded the incident on video, police said. Based on his complaint, Elamakkara police registered a case on Sunday and arrested the woman.

Wanted gangster Afridi deported from Ethiopia, arrested

Press Trust of India
Chandigarh, November 8

PUNJAB POLICE, with the support of central agencies, has secured the deportation of wanted gangster Gurwinder Singh alias Afridi from Ethiopia following a 10-month international manhunt.

He was taken into custody by Punjab Police at Delhi airport and is being brought to Punjab to face the law, police said on Sunday.

Punjab DGP Gaurav Yadav said this marks the first-ever deportation of a fugitive secured by the state police from an African country.

The Anti-Gangster Task Force (AGTF) of the Punjab Police, in close coordination with the Overseas Fugitive Tracking and Extradition Cell (OFTEC) of Counter Intelligence, and with the support of central agencies, secured the deportation of the fugitive gangster from Ethiopia, he said.

The Punjab government had announced a reward of Rs 5 lakh on information leading to the arrest of Afridi, an alleged key member of the Doni Bal-Prabh Dassuwal gang. He is accused of directing targeted killings, extortion-related firing incidents and organised criminal networks in Punjab while operating from abroad. He is wanted in more than 30 heinous criminal cases, including five murder cases, attempt to murder, extortion, and Arms Act offences, according to police. The cases include the murder of sarpanch Rajwinder alias Raj Talwandi (October 2024) and Congress block president Gurmel Singh (September 2025), police said.

DGP Yadav, who was accompanied by Special DGP AGTF Promod Ban and Special DGP Counter Intelligence Amit Prasad, told reporters, "The operation marks the successful culmination of 'Operation SHAHID', a 10-month-long intelligence-led international manhunt involving sustained surveillance, strategic intelligence gathering, and tracking across multiple countries in Asia, South America and Africa, executed in close coordination with national and international agencies."

The operation was executed under the close supervision of IGP OFTEC of Counter Intelligence wing Ashish Chaudhary, who oversaw international coordination and follow-up efforts, and was led by SP (AGTF/OFTEC OPs) Bikramjit Singh Brar, according to officials.

DGP Yadav said Afridi had fled from Mumbai to the UAE on March 31, 2025, using a fake passport obtained under the particulars of a Gorakhpur resident and issued from Lucknow on February 12, 2025.

PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that Mr. Bhupendra Sitaram Gupta and Mrs. Beena Bhupendra Gupta are the Owners of the premises being Showroom No. C, on the Ground Floor admeasuring 312 sq.ft. (28.97 sq.mtrs.) built up area along with 2.67% (Two point Six Seven percent) undivided share in the common areas and facilities, in the building known as "Darshan Apartment", situated at land bearing C.T.S. No. 1/D (part) i.e. 1/D/1, (Corresponding Revised Survey No. 31), B. J. Road (property located on main B.J. Road), Village Ghorpadi, within the limits of Pune Municipal Corporation, Taluka Haveli, District Pune.

The said Owners have agreed to sell/transfer the said premises to my client and have assured my client that the same is free from all encumbrances and/or defects in title.

Any person/s having any claims by way of sale, mortgage, pre-emption, lease, lien, gift, easement, exchange, possession, inheritance, succession or otherwise howsoever in respect of the same are required to intimate the same in writing to the undersigned together with proof thereof within 7 days of publication of this notice failing which my clients shall complete the sale/transaction and all such claims, if any, shall be deemed to have been waived and/or abandoned.

This Notice dated this 6th day of November, 2026.

BHARAT M. PARWANI, Advocate.
G11, Ashoka Pavillion, Ground Floor,
Dr. Ambedkar Road, Pune 411 001 Ph.: 26114567/8

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SALE INTIMATION AND NOTICE FOR SALE OF SECURITIES PLEDGED TO HDFC BANK LTD.

The below mentioned Borrowers of HDFC Bank Ltd. (the "Bank") are hereby notified regarding the sale of securities pledged to the Bank, for availing credit facilities in the nature of Loans/Overdraft Against Securities.

Due to persistent default by the Borrowers in making repayment of the outstanding dues as per agreed loans / facilities terms, the below loan / facilities accounts are in delinquent status or classified as NPA (Non-Performing Asset). The Bank has issued multiple notices / loan recall notice to these Borrowers, including the final sale notice on the below-mentioned date whereby, Bank had invoked the pledge and provided 7 days' time to the Borrower to repay the entire outstanding dues in the below accounts, failing which, Bank would be at liberty to sell the pledged securities without issuing further notice in this regard.

The Borrowers have neglected and failed to make due repayments, therefore, Bank in exercise of its rights under the loan agreement as a pledgee has decided to sell / dispose off the Securities on or after **17th November 2026** for recovering the dues owed by the Borrowers to the Bank. The Borrowers are hereby notified to treat this as a notice of sale in compliance of section 176 of the Indian Contract Act, 1872. The Borrowers are, also, notified that, if at any time, the value of the pledged securities falls further due to volatility in the stock market to create further deficiency in the margin requirement then Bank shall at its discretion sell the pledged security within one (1) calendar day, without any further notice in this regard. The Borrower(s) shall remain liable to the Bank for repayment of any remaining outstanding amount, post adjustment of the proceeds from sale of pledged securities.

Sr. No.	Loan Account Number	Borrower's Name	Outstanding Amount as on 06th Nov 2026	Date of Sale Notice
1	XXXXXXXXX9632	TRUPTI JAYESH VASHI	7,29,990.20	07-11-2026
2	XXXXXXXXX2981	BHARATBHAI LALABHAI PATEL	9,88,974.82	07-11-2026
3	XXXXXXXXX6132	MEENABEN MANISHBHAI VADHER	5,40,165.72	07-11-2026
4	XXXXXXXXX8672	SRIKANTH S G	77,016.56	07-11-2026
5	XXXXXXXXX7801	ROHIT SHAILENDRA KUMAR	28,653.00	07-11-2026
6	XXXXXXXXX0759	PATEL HEMAL ISHWAR	1,351.71	07-11-2026
7	XXXXXXXXX1192	RAHIMA BIBI	34,396.89	07-11-2026
8	XXXXXXXXX5942	RAJUBHAI THAKORBHAI TANDEL	9,42,949.38	07-11-2026
9	XXXXXXXXX7371	KALPANA PARSOTTAM	3,50,493.82	07-11-2026

DATE : 09.11.2026 **Sd/-**
PLACE : DADRA AND NAGAR HAVELI **HDFC BANK LTD.**

POSSESSION NOTICE

Whereas, the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Limited acting in its capacity as Trustee of Arcil **"Arcil - 2024C - 003-Trust** under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002) ("said Act") and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13 (12) of the said Act read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 ("said Rules") issued a demand notice (as detailed in table below), calling upon the borrower viz. (as detailed in table below), the guarantors and the mortgagors to repay the amount under **Loan No –** (as detailed in table below) details of which are mentioned in the table below:

The borrower/guarantor(s)/mortgagor(s) having failed to repay the said amounts, notice is hereby given to the borrower/guarantor(s)/mortgagor(s) in particular and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the underlying Immovable Property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under Sub-Section (4) of Section 13 of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said Rules on "AS IS WHERE IS & WHATEVER THERE IS BASIS" on the date mentioned below.

SL. No	Borrower Name & Guarantors / Trust Name / Bank Name	Demand Notice Details	Possession Date
1	**Mr. Paresh Rajeshbhai Rathod / Mr. Ajay Rajesh Rathod / Hansaben Rajesh Rathod / Mr. Jitendra Lalaji Ahire TRUST: "Arcil - 2024C - 003-Trust Selling Bank: - Bandhan Bank**	**Loan No. 20004070002737. Section 13(2) Dated 16/01/2025 Demanding Mr. Paresh Rajeshbhai Rathod / Mr. Ajay Rajesh Rathod / Hansaben Rajesh Rathod / Mr. Jitendra Lalaji Ahire Along With Future Interest At The Contractual Rate On The Aforesaid Amount With Effect 16/01/2025 Together With Incidental Expenses, Cost, Charges Etc.**	**Physical Possession On 05/11/2026**

Property Description: Property Owned By Mr. Paresh Rajeshbhai Rathod / Mr. Ajay Rajesh Rathod / Hansaben Rajesh Rathod / Mr. At Road, West : 20 Fts. Internal Road, South : Remaing Portion Out Of Plot No. 20. All That Piece & Parcel Of Row House Admeasuring The Land Area As 55.34 S.mtr. & Super Builtup Area As 74.61 Sq.mtr. Situated At Final Plot No. 284 To 291, Survey No- 71/1,row House No 10, Building/society Name- Surekha Residency, Strwwtno / Name - Shefali Park Dhule Road, Area-Mangaldas Park Navapur, City- Navapur(N), Mh, Pincode: 425418, & Same As **Bounded As : North:** Row House No.09, **East :** S. Row House No.07, **West :** Road, **South :** Row House No.11.

The borrower/guarantor(s)/mortgagor(s) in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned that Arcil is in lawful possession of the Immovable Property mentioned above and under Section 13(13) of the SARFAESI Act, 2002, the borrower/ guarantor(s)/mortgagor(s) or any person whatsoever, shall after receipt of this notice not transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise deal with/ alienate the Immovable Property, without prior written consent of Arcil and any dealings with the Immovable Property will be subject to the charge of Arcil for the amount as mentioned above along with future interest at the contractual rate on the aforesaid amount together with incidental expenses, cost, charges etc.

The borrowers'/guarantors'/mortgagors' attention is invited to the provisions of the Sub-Section (8) of Section 13 of the said Act, in respect of time available to redeem the above-mentioned Immovable Property.

Place : Nandurbar **Sd/-**
Date : 09.11.2026 **Authorized Officer**
Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Limited

Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Ltd.,
CIN - L65999MH2002PLC134884, Website : www.arcil.co.in
Registered Office : The Ruby, 10th Floor, 29 Senapati Bapat Marg, Dadar (West), Mumbai – 400 028. Tel: +91 2266581300
Branch Office : Unit # 211, 121, Zenith Complex, Plot # 28/2, K.M.Gandhi Path, Shivaji Nagar, Pune-411038. Ph: 7066009350, 8600743333.

PUBLISHED IN THE GAZETTE OF INDIA
EXTRAORDINARY PART - II SECTION 3,
SUB SECTION (ii)
GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
MINISTRY OF ROAD TRANSPORT AND HIGHWAYS

NOTIFICATION

New Delhi, the 27th October, 2026

S.O. 5824(E). - Whereas by the notification of the Government of India in the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways, **S.O. 4408 (E) dated, 07th August, 2026**, published in the Gazette of India, Extraordinary, Part II, Section 3, Sub-section (ii) issued under sub-section (1) of section 3A of the National Highways Act, 1956 (48 of 1956) (hereinafter referred to as the said Act), the Central Government declared its intention to acquire the land specified in the Schedule annexed to the said notification for building (widening/Six/Eight laning, etc.), maintenance, management and operation of Mumbai-Vadodara Expressway Spur to NH-NE4 in the stretch of land from Km. 45.400 to Km. 58.820 (Maharashtra Section) in the district of Thane in the state of Maharashtra

And whereas the substance of the said notification has been published in **"Lokmat" (Marathi)** and **"The Indian Express" (English)** both dated **21st August 2026;** under sub-section (3) of section 3A of the said Act;

And whereas the Competent Authority has received objections filed under Section 3-C, considered and settled the same appropriately;

And whereas, in pursuance of sub-section (1) of section 3D of the said Act, the competent authority has submitted its report to the Central Government;

Now, therefore, upon receipt of the said report of the competent authority and in exercise of the powers conferred by the sub-section (1) of section 3D of the said Act, the Central Government hereby declares that the land specified in the said Schedule should be acquired for the aforesaid purpose;

And further, in pursuance of sub-section (2) of section 3D of the said Act, the Central Government hereby declares that on publication of this notification in the Official Gazette, the land specified in the said Schedule shall vest absolutely in the Central Government, free from all encumbrances.

And, whereas, Competent Authority by using the powers given by the act is starting the process of determining the compensation of land to the land owners. And hence, hereby notice under Section 3(G) of National Highway Act, 1956 given to beneficiaries of the persons where the land is under acquisition of giving statement in respect of the claim & compensation of the lands of the beneficiaries at following place in front of Competent Authority either in person or through authorised persons/advocates as per the schedule given below.

Place: Competent Authority & Sub Divisional Officer, Mohan Pride Culture Walfare Centre, 2nd Floor, Near Poddar International School, Khadakpada, Kalyan (W) - 421301.

Sr.No.	Name of Village	Date	Time
1	Balyani	20/11/2026	Office Time

Also it is declared that, if no statement is received from the concerned beneficiaries of the land which is under acquisition on the above date, time and place and front of Competent Authority, along with the nature of claim on land compensation along with concerned documents and legal evidence, then it will assumed that the concerned beneficiaries has nothing to say and the amount of compensation will be decided as per rules. The land maps and the details of the land in respect of the lands included in the above notification are available in officer of Competent Authority.

Date: 03.11.2026 **Competent Authority & Sub Divisional, Officer,**
Place: Kalyan **Kalyan Division, Kalyan, Dist.- Thane**

SCHEDULE

Brief description of the land to be acquired, with or without structure, falling within the stretch of land from Km. 45.400 to Km. 58.820 (Maharashtra Section) Mumbai – Vadodara Expressway Spur to NH-NE 4 in the district of Thane in the state of Maharashtra.

District:- Thane [F. No. NHAI/PIU/Surat (Expressway)/L12/275/3D1]
https://egazette.gov.in/(Search by Gazette Id: CG-DL-E-28102026-277459) SHAIKH AMINKHAN, Director
Publication Date: 27.10.2026



The four-time MLA died in a Jaipur hospital on Sunday

Jaswant Singh Yadav, veteran Rajasthan BJP MLA, dies at 73

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, November 8

RAJASTHAN BJP MLA and former minister Jaswant Singh Yadav died on Sunday morning while undergoing treatment at a Jaipur hospital. He was 73.

In a social media post, Mohit Yadav said his father and a four-time MLA died at 8.15 am on Sunday. His last rites will be conducted at his native Silpata village in Alwar at 3 pm on Monday.

Extending condolences, former Congress chief minister Ashok Gehlot said, "The news of the passing of former minister and Behror MLA Dr Jaswant Yadav is deeply saddening. He was an experienced leader with a long public life."

A zila pramukh in Alwar in the mid-1990s, Jaswant Singh was elected as a BJP MLA from Alwar's Mundawar in 1998 on a BJP ticket. However, he was elected to the Lok Sabha from Alwar a few months later in 1999, his only term, and resigned as an MLA. He then shifted to Alwar's Behror and won the seat on a BJP ticket in 2008, a seat he retained in 2013. Under the Vasundhara Raje government (2013-18), he held multiple portfolios as a Cabinet minister.

In 2023, Jaswant Singh had the last laugh as he defeated Baljeet, with whom the family has shared a bitter equation. In 2018, fielded in a Lok Sabha bypoll for Alwar, and ahead of the Assembly polls later that year, Jaswant Singh changed tack and made news for his controversial and communal remarks. While Jaswant Yadav lost the Lok Sabha bypoll, his son Mohit lost the Assembly poll later that year. Jaswant was re-elected from Behror on a BJP ticket in 2023.

'Your service won't be forgotten': Rajnath pays tribute to war heroes

Press Trust of India
Gangtok, November 8

DEFENCE MINISTER Rajnath Singh visited Sherathang near Nathu La in Sikkim on Sunday and paid homage to fallen soldiers at the war memorial.

Addressing Army personnel stationed at the India-China border, Singh said such memorials served as a lasting tribute to war heroes who made the supreme sacrifice for the nation and would continue to inspire generations of young Indians.

Lauding the courage and dedication of security personnel deployed along the frontiers under difficult and challenging conditions, he said the country could celebrate Diwali peacefully because of the armed forces.

The defence minister also paid tribute to the families of armed forces personnel who lost their loved ones while serving the nation, acknowledging their contribution and sacrifice.

"India stands with you for the contribution you have made," Singh said, assuring the bereaved families that the country would always remember the sacrifices of their loved ones.



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh with soldiers at Sherathang War Memorial in Sikkim on Sunday. PTI

Describing Diwali, the festival of lights, as an occasion for families to come together, he said soldiers often set aside their personal emotions and remain away from their loved ones to fulfil their duties towards the country.

Singh interacted with Army personnel stationed at the high-altitude location and distributed sweets and gifts among them.

"Your service to the nation will never be forgotten. Every generation of Indians will remember your sacrifice," he told the soldiers, adding that the country would remain indebted to them.

Senior Army officers on Sunday accompanied the Defence Minister during the visit.

Singh later visited the Baba Harbhajan Singh Mandir — a shrine dedicated to Indian Army soldier Harbhajan Singh in the eastern sector of Sikkim.

Navy chief meets forward-deployed units in Gujarat

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, November 8

NAVY CHIEF Admiral Krishna Swaminathan visited a forward operating base of the Navy in Gujarat and celebrated Diwali with naval personnel, officials said on Sunday.

During the visit, he reviewed the operational readiness, infrastructure development plans and capabilities of units located in the state. "Adm Krishna Swaminathan, #CNS, visited a forward operating base and outlying units of the #IndianNavy in Gujarat, sharing the festive spirit of Diwali with naval personnel deployed at these locations," the Navy posted on X.

The occasion also provided the Chief of Naval Staff an opportunity to celebrate Diwali together with forward-deployed units, acknowledge the dedication of personnel serving away from their families, and share the warmth and camaraderie that define the Navy, the officials said.



West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari celebrates Kali Puja and Diwali with police officers at Kolkata Airport on Sunday. PTI

Seema Mitra award for BSF, SSB, cops from '27: Suvendu

Press Trust of India
Hingalganj, November 8

WEST BENGAL Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Sunday announced that his government would institute the 'Seema Mitra' award from 2027 to recognise exceptional contributions by Border Security Force, Sashastra Seema Bal and state police personnel in securing the country's borders.

A selection panel would be constituted to decide the awardees, he said while addressing BSF personnel at a border outpost in Hingalganj in North 24 Parganas district, which shares a boundary with Bangladesh.

"We will give the 'Seema Mitra' award from next year for BSF, SSB and West Bengal police personnel," Adhikari said. He visited the border outpost to greet security personnel on the occasion of Diwali and Kali Puja.

The BSF guards the India-Bangladesh border, while SSB is deployed along India's frontiers with Nepal and Bhutan.

West Bengal shares a border of over 2,200 km with Bangladesh, Suvendu said, adding that the state government would facilitate the setting up of more police stations in frontier areas and provide the necessary infrastructure, logistics and manpower.

Naveen returns to flood-hit Ganjam as BJD looks to reclaim lost ground

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, November 8

SEEKING TO regain lost ground in its traditional stronghold of Ganjam, the Biju Janata Dal (BJD) on Saturday sought to project party president and former Odisha chief minister Naveen Patnaik's visit to the flood-hit district as a show of strength and a reaffirmation of his connect with the region.

The visit came amid criticism from the ruling BJP over Patnaik's absence from his home constituency, Hinjili, in the aftermath of the floods. Patnaik visited the flood-affected Sheragada, Hinjilicut, Aska and Sorada blocks, taking stock of the damage and reviewing the relief, rehabilitation and restoration measures undertaken by the administration. He also interacted with affected families, farmers and local residents.

"The people, particularly farmers, are in great distress. Their demands have not been addressed yet. I strongly demand that the state government come to their relief immediately," Patnaik said after meeting those affected. He said he would take grievances of the affected people to the state government and press for immediate action.

Thousands of people, including women and elderly, gathered at the helipad and lined the roads along his route to catch a glimpse of the former CM and raise their grievances.



Former Odisha CM Naveen Patnaik in Ganjam on Saturday. EXPRESS

Ganjam, along with neighbouring Gajapati and Kandhamal districts, has witnessed one of its worst floods in 36 years, reviving memories of the 1990 floods in the Rushikulya river basin. The floods washed away major roads, damaged public infrastructure and homes, and destroyed standing paddy crops and vegetable fields, leaving extensive damage in the region.

The scale of destruction and allegations of inadequate preparedness and a delayed response have put the BJP-led government on the defensive. However, Patnaik, too, faced criticism over his absence from Hinjili. Posters describing the BJD chief as "missing" had surfaced in the constituency, giving the BJP an opportunity to question his response to the disaster.

Patnaik's visit assumes political significance as Ganjam has traditionally been a BJD stronghold and the district where he began his electoral journey. In 1997, he contested a Lok Sabha by-election from the Aska parliamentary constituency following the death of his father, former Odisha chief minister Biju Patnaik.

The visit also comes ahead of the local body elections scheduled for January-February 2027, with the BJD seeking to revive its political fortunes in the district.

Ganjam played a significant role in the BJD's five consecutive electoral victories in Odisha. However, the party suffered a major setback in the 2024 Assembly and Lok Sabha elections, when the BJP made significant gains across the district.

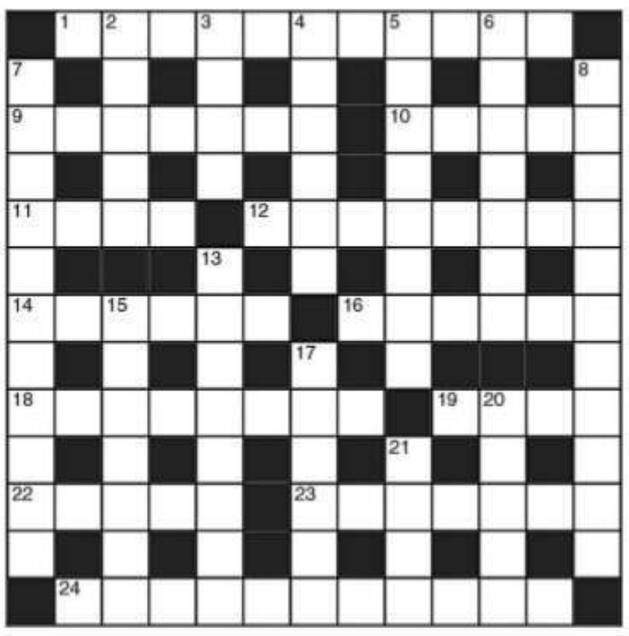
The BJP won 11 of Ganjam's 13 Assembly seats and both Lok Sabha constituencies. The BJD managed to retain Hinjili, Patnaik's constituency, while the Congress won the remaining Assembly seat.

Claiming that Patnaik's visit demonstrated his continued popularity, senior BJD leader Debi Prasad Mishra said the large turnout reflected the people's faith in the former chief minister and their growing dissatisfaction with the BJP government.

The BJP, however, maintained that Patnaik had failed to stand by his constituents when they needed him most.

Defending the state government's handling of the floods, Odisha Cabinet minister Gokulananda Mallick said people had questioned the former chief minister's absence during the crisis. "I have seen reports of people raising 'go back Naveen' slogans in some parts of the district," Mallick said.

• CROSSWORD 6141



ACROSS
1 One who gives shock treatment? (11)
9 Comprehensive cover (7)
10 The elegance of a short prayer (5)
11 Hoaxes children (4)
12 An apartment indeed needs air (8)
14 Ex-star replaced in crowd scenes (6)
16 Like a seabird following a ship (6)
18 Goes for profits (8)
19 State welcome to king (4)
22 Wash out some underwear in secret (5)
23 Great joy as news excludes revolution (7)
24 Does he count support for drivers or just abstain? (11)

DOWN
2 Winning article on school principal (5)
3 Empty sheep range (4)
4 Rang the bell as audibly instructed (6)
5 Age still troubled a strict advocate (8)
6 Surprise opening by the French (7)
7 Librarians perhaps may fine them (11)
8 A reminder of marriage bells? (7,4)
13 It is often covered by flags (8)
15 Defeat in counter-revolution (7)
17 The coming of the Christian faith (6)
20 Without it one is utterly incompetent (5)
21 Man paid at Peter's expense? (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6140 ACROSS: 1 Intent, 4 All right, 9 Tipcat, 10 Emigrate, 12 Rise, 13 Quits, 14 Gear, 17 Strict orders, 20 Brother-in-law, 23 Enid, 24 Veins, 25 Stye, 28 Man-of-war, 29 Remiss, 30 Reassert, 31 Stir up
DOWN: 1 Interest, 2 Tapestry, 3 Neat, 5 Limited means, 6 Rage, 7 Graded, 8 Theory, 11 Fun of the fair, 15 Score, 16 Frail, 18 Clothier, 19 Sweeps up, 21 Reamer, 22 Vienna, 26 Efts, 27 Meet

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Illness is the doctor to whom we pay most heed; to kindness, to knowledge, we ___ ___ only; pain we obey. - Marcel Proust (4,7)

LEASE
AASIMM
EIORS
CEITKP

SOLUTIONS: Easel, Osier, Miasma, Picket
ANSWER: Illness is the doctor to whom we pay most heed; to kindness, to knowledge, we **make promise** only; pain we obey. - Marcel Proust

• OVER THE HEDGE

BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS



• CALVIN & HOBBES

BY BILL WATTERSON



• MARVIN

BY TOM ARMSTRONG



SUDOKU 6497

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 1s
INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy;
3s = Medium; 4s = Hard;
5s = Very Hard;
6s = Genius

8	5				4			6
		3	8		7		2	
4					1	9	5	
		2		6		3	1	
5			2		9			7
	4	9		7		2		
	1	4	7					2
	6		5		3	4		
9			1				8	3

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6496

5	2	8	9	6	4	1	7	3
9	4	7	3	2	1	5	6	8
6	1	3	5	7	8	4	9	2
8	3	2	4	9	5	7	1	6
7	6	9	8	1	2	3	4	5
4	5	1	7	3	6	8	2	9
3	9	6	1	5	7	2	8	4
1	8	5	2	4	9	6	3	7
2	7	4	6	8	3	9	5	1

• ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Today's New Moon urges you to inject more excitement into your life. What can you do to make your world more interesting? It is the best time of the year to focus on red-tape details and debt. Tonight: Check banking details.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Because today's New Moon is taking place opposite your sign, it's the best day of the year to think about how you can improve your partnerships and closest relationships. Tonight: Listen and cooperate.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Each New Moon is an opportunity to set intentions. Today's New Moon urges you to think about how you can work more efficiently and be more productive. Tonight: Get better organised.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): What can you do to add a little more sizzle and fun playfulness to your life? In part, this is what today's New Moon is all about. Romance also might offer exciting possibilities. Focus on activities with kids, sports and socialising. Tonight: Play.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Today is the best day all year to think about how to improve family relationships and make your home a happier place for you. You don't have to do a big makeover. Just think of one or two things that would be a step in a positive direction. Tonight: Relax at home.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): You're a clever mimic, and you have a fantastic memory for details, especially trivia. Today the New Moon is taking place in your House of Communications. What can you do to improve your daily conversations with others? Think about this. Tonight: Discussions.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): You're private about your money. It so happens that today's New Moon is occurring in your Money House, giving you a chance to think about how you handle your money. Tonight: Check your belongings.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Today the only New Moon in your sign all year is taking place, which is the perfect time for you to take a realistic look in the mirror and ask yourself what you can do to improve the image you project on your world. Tonight: You're in charge.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Today's New Moon is your opportunity to honestly assess where you are your most self-defeating. Where do you undermine yourself with the very things that you're trying to accomplish? Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): This is the best day of the year to think about how you can improve your friendships, as well as how to improve your relations with people. You function well in groups. What might you do to improve this talent? Tonight: Be friendly.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): You're noticed today. In fact, some know personal details about your private life. Because the New Moon is taking place high in your chart, it's a good day to think about how you deal with authority figures. Tonight: You're admired.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Today is a good day to think about what further education or travel you could get that will enrich your life. After all, why not have the most fulfilling life that you can have? What is one thing you might like to do? Tonight: Learn something.

@ieExplained
#ExpressExplained
If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to
explained@indianexpress.com

• LEGAL

2-child norm for panchayat polls: Why SC says it's time for a rethink

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, November 8

THE SUPREME Court has referred its 2003 ruling, which upheld the disqualification of people with more than two children from contesting panchayat elections, to a larger Bench for reconsideration. A Bench of Justices P S Narasimha and Alok Aradhe, which was hearing a plea from a Maharashtra woman who was elected sarpanch, said the fear of overpopulation on which these laws rest "has crumbled due to demographic changes in the past few decades". "It is high time we recall *Javed*," the Bench said, referring to the 2003 case: *Javed v. State of Haryana*.

The legal framework

Maharashtra is among the many states that disqualify people from contesting or continuing in local body offices if they have more than two children. The provision was first introduced through a 1995 amendment to the Maharashtra Village Panchayats Act, 1959, as part of a legislative approach to population control.

The Act states that a person is disqualified from being elected as a member of a Gram Panchayat if they have more than two children. Children born in a single delivery within one year of the amendment commencement are excluded. If a couple has one child and later has twins or more children in one delivery, they are counted as one for this law. Adopted children are excluded from the definition.

Similar two-child rules apply to local body elections in Haryana, Rajasthan, Odisha, Andhra Pradesh, and Madhya Pradesh.

What SC said in Javed v. State of Haryana

The Supreme Court first upheld a two-child disqualification law in *Javed v. State of Haryana* (2003). The case concerned Section 175(1)(q) of the Haryana Panchayati Raj Act, 1994, which disqualified a person with more than two living children from holding the office of sarpanch, panch, or member of a panchayat samiti or zila parishad.

A three-judge Bench held that disqualifying people with more than two living children from panchayat offices was a valid way of encouraging family planning. It said that the restriction did not prevent anyone from having more children but attached an electoral consequence to that choice.

On a challenge under Article 21, the Bench rejected the claim that personal liberty included a right to procreate without consequence for holding office. The Bench also held that the right to contest an election was a statutory right and not a fundamental right and could thus be subjected to legislative conditions.

What SC has said now

The Supreme Court said that the demographic circumstances on which *Javed* was decided had changed. India's total fertility rate (TFR) had fallen from 3.0 in 2003 to 1.9, which is below the replacement level of 2.1. A replacement level is the TFR at which each generation exactly replaces itself, about 2.1 children per woman. Below it, a population shrinks over time and over it, a population grows.

The court said that ignoring this shift simply because India still has a large population "would be dangerously complacent...the stakes are too high," adding that "the need of the hour is to have policies in tune with the present realities". The Bench also questioned why such restrictions were only applied to elected representatives at the panchayat level but not those who are contesting elections to Parliament or state legislatures.

In *Javed*, the top court had said that the disqualification affected men and women equally. The Bench disagreed, noting that the two-child norm in a patriarchal society had "tended to weaken the position of women rather than empowering them".

FALLING FERTILITY

- Total fertility rate, or TFR, is the average number of children a woman is expected to bear in her lifetime.
- A replacement rate of 2.1 (an average of two children per woman to replace the mother and father) is considered ideal to ensure population stability.
- India's TFR fell from 5.9 in the early 1960s to 2 in 2024 — just under the replacement rate.

• POLICY

The Centre-state divide in food safety regulation

A Maharashtra govt plea says national regulator FSSAI is overstepping its authority. How are food safety powers split between the Centre and states?



ANONNA DUTT

THE MAHARASHTRA government, through its Food Safety Commissioner Tukaram Mundhe, recently went to the Bombay High Court against the national regulator, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI), alleging that it had created a parallel regulatory mechanism and encroached on the state's powers.

The petition has put the spotlight on how food safety is regulated in India at both central and state levels.

What is the current division of responsibilities?

Section 31(3) of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006, states: "Any person desirous to commence or carry on any food business shall make an application for grant of a licence to the Designated Officer in such manner containing such particulars and fees as may be specified by regulations." A Designated Officer is responsible for food safety administration of a specified area (usually a district). They are appointed by the Commissioner of Food Safety, who, in turn, is responsible for the entire state.

The Act also empowers the Commissioner to appoint Food Safety Officers (FSOs) for specified local jurisdictions to carry out inspections and seizures in case of complaints or contraventions. These FSOs report to the district-level Designated Officer.

In an order dated March 13, 2026, the FSSAI said that food businesses with annual turnover of up to Rs 1.5 crore need a registration, those with turnover up to Rs 50 crore need a state licence, and those above Rs 50 crore need a central licence. Before this, companies with annual turnover of Rs 12 lakh needed a registration, those with Rs 12 lakh to Rs 20 crore needed a state licence, and those with turnover of more than Rs 20 crore needed a central licence. This included food businesses with large footprints, those operating across state lines, those dealing with large quantities of high-risk foods such as milk and meat products, and those manufacturing food products for export.

MONITORING FOOD SAFETY

UNDER THE Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006, anyone operating a food business in India must get either an FSSAI registration or an FSSAI licence, depending on their business size, turnover, and nature of operations.

FOR SMALL food business operators, small vendors, or home kitchens with an annual turnover of up to Rs 1.5 crore, an FSSAI registration is required.

FOR MEDIUM and large-sized food businesses or manufacturers that operate within a single state and have a turnover of over Rs 1.5 crore and up to Rs 50 crore, a state licence is needed.

FOOD BUSINESSES with large footprints, those operating across state lines, those dealing with large quantities of high-risk foods such as milk and meat products, and those manufacturing food products for export with an annual turnover above Rs 50 crore need a central licence.



AMIT CHAKRAVARTY/FILE

BEFORE THE order dated March 13, 2026, companies with annual turnover of Rs 12 lakh needed a registration, those with Rs 12 lakh to Rs 20 crore needed a state licence, and those with turnover of more than Rs 20 crore needed a Central licence.

The FSSAI, in an earlier order dated May 12, 2023, had said that all centrally licensed food businesses have to be inspected by Central FSOs. The state officers are allowed to carry out inspection only in certain cases:

- When there is an incident or emergency where immediate action is necessary
- When the state authority is carrying out special drives, only with permission of the state Commissioner and intimation to the Regional Director of FSSAI
- In case of VIP duty where time is of the essence.

Even in cases where inspection is carried out and samples collected by the state food officers, the reports have to be submitted to the central licensing authority, with the consequent proceedings and appeals undertaken by the central authority.

In cases of launching legal adjudication or prosecution, however, the state mechanism will be used. The case will be filed before the adjudicating officer notified by the state and then the appellate tribunal established by the state.

What issues has Maharashtra raised in its petition against FSSAI?

The Maharashtra government's petition raises several important issues in the implementation of the 2006 Act.

- **Creating a parallel enforcement structure:** The petition says while the enforcement of the Act should have rested with the state Commissioners, FSSAI created a parallel mechanism through its May 2023 order. The order, which was meant to clarify the procedure for enforcement on centrally licensed food businesses, said that inspections of such facilities will be carried out by "central food safety officers".

A senior officer from a state food safety authority, on condition of anonymity, said: "If you look at the Food Safety Act, there is no provision for the appointment of Central FSOs. It says that a FSO has to be appointed by a Commissioner of Food Safety, and the Commissioner of Food Safety is an officer appointed by the state government."

The officer added: "The FSSAI CEO is not a commissioner and therefore cannot appoint FSOs. Yet, the central body carved out an enforcement space for itself."

- **Usurping the powers of the state authority:** The petition says that the May 2023 order put restrictions on enforcement by the state officers. The order says enforcement for centrally licensed premises can be carried out only by central FSOs even if the state authority receives the complaint.
- **Bringing in more food businesses under central authority:** The Maharashtra government petition also challenged the mandatory rollout of the Food Safety Compliance System, claiming that it was designed to bring in more food businesses under the purview of the Central licensing authority (FSSAI), taking them outside the inspection remit of local officers.

"While the initial regulations did carve out some exceptions for businesses that required Central licenses — mainly businesses operating across state lines and those dealing with say high risk perishable products in large quantities — FSSAI has since expanded this domain," the officer said, adding that businesses such as five-star hotels and restaurants, all e-commerce platforms and their stores, neutraceuticals, and something called "proprietary foods" have been brought under its purview.

According to the officer, as "proprietary foods" refers to foods for which the parameters and standards had not been defined by the rules and regulations, their inclusion had initially caused confusion since they would've included small food businesses manufacturing snacks such as *samosas* and mixtures. The FSSAI later added an exception for Indian snacks "to ensure businesses making proprietary foods remained under its purview", the officer added.

- **Changes without public consultation:** The petition also contested FSSAI's March 13, 2026 order which changed the "turnover threshold" — this time pushing more businesses towards state enforcement, with the threshold being raised for Central license from Rs 20 crore to Rs 50 crore. The petition said that the changes were finalised without any public consultation, which is a violation of the General Clauses Act.

Turf Tussle

The petition says that the May 2023 order put restrictions on enforcement by state officers.

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The order says enforcement for centrally licensed premises can be carried out only by central officials even if the state authority receives the complaint.

What are the challenges?

This division of responsibilities, according to the officer, creates a lot of friction. The officer said that there have been instances where inspections have been carried out in the premises of the state licensees by the central authority.

On the other hand, a senior official from the central authority said: "Right now, the Maharashtra FDA is performing very well because of the leadership of Tukaram Mundhe, but can it be guaranteed that such action will continue after he moves away from the department? There have been challenges with inconsistent enforcement across states and within states from time to time. The Central mechanism can help in ensuring that at least bigger businesses always remain under the scanner."

• TECH

AI and cybersecurity: Can it find flaws without creating new risks?



EXPERT EXPLAINS

VAISHNAVI SUNDARARAJAN

ASSISTANT PROFESSOR AT IIT DELHI

EXPLAINED

A weekly column decoding AI's new frontiers, how they shape the world and our place in it

OCTOBER MARKED a watershed in the information security space. Major incidents occurred within a few days of each other, leading cybersecurity practitioners to dub the month "Black October".

On October 17, a researcher reported weak private keys used for eMudhra certificates, which could allow hackers to impersonate legitimate websites. On October 21, the PHP Foundation announced two critical vulnerabilities dubbed PHP2Shell. These exploited memory safety, and could allow a remote user to control any PHP server. The same day, a version of LiteLLM, an open-source repository of LLM providers, was hacked and quarantined, all within a few hours. Separately, GitLab released fixes for a severe flaw which could allow hackers to remotely control systems.

The intriguing aspect of these incidents is not only their close frequency, but the role artificial intelligence (AI) played in them.

AI-assisted discovery

If you log in to a website or make a purchase, chances are you are using PHP. Around 70% of all websites reportedly run some version of PHP, and so PHP2Shell could affect innumerable websites.

PHP is a language that, informally, allows browsers to interact with web servers. Two cybersecurity groups discovered PHP2Shell and alerted the PHP Foundation. AI firm Calif used frontier OpenAI models while Google's Wiz used in-house models.

The possibility of such exploits had been raised as long ago as 2004. However, researchers could not reproduce a working attack. The precise attacks were only discovered now using AI-assisted techniques.

Unfortunately, implementation details of the exploit were leaked well before a patch was issued. The same day, OpenAI posted that it had found critical flaws in PHP, broadcasting the incident far beyond the cybersecurity community. This triggered a race against time: the PHP Foundation needed to release a fix, developers needed to apply it, and attackers could target several hundreds of millions of vulnerable systems in the meantime. However, much of the patching work was being undertaken by volunteers like Czech programmer Ondřej Surý.

Can AI guarantee security?

AI is clearly making it easier to find flaws, as evidenced by PHP2Shell being brought to light after two decades of dormancy.

On October 22, Anthropic's Frontier Red Team announced having checked "over 100 real-world open-source software libraries". The group said it had used formal verification to discover "bugs that had eluded detection for years, despite trillions of test runs".

In formal verification, systems and their expected requirements are expressed in an abstract mathematical formulation to prove whether the systems satisfy those requirements. Unfortunately, the requirement for mathematical expertise, as well as scaling issues, hindered widespread deployment. If AI can overcome these obstacles thanks to its unparalleled ability to compute, that could help show that systems behave as expected or find flaws.

However, this process is difficult to fully automate because of the "intent capture" problem — how does one test whether something has been correctly formalised, without human developers to assess the translation from code to abstraction? Further, since any abstraction necessarily throws away information, resultant proofs are only as good (or as bad) as the assumptions made for the abstraction. A proof of correctness, therefore, does not mean freedom from all possible security flaws.

AI enthusiasts are going all in, though; Jason D Clinton, an Anthropic engineer, posted on X that "things are going to get a lot worse before they get better".

Question of costs

As GenAI helps uncover vulnerabilities that malicious actors can exploit, the companies developing these tools could also sell protection against such threats.

Many of AI companies are racking up debt. Offering cybersecurity services could therefore open up new avenues of revenue.

GenAI also requires significant data and compute, and data centres which enable this have raised environmental concerns.

These concerns must be addressed before we can envisage a fully AI-enabled cybersecurity landscape.

• SOCIETY

Meet the Siddis: Tribal Gujaratis from Kathiawad, natural athletes of African stock

Ritu Sharma
Ahmedabad, November 8

FIFTEEN-YEAR-OLD Khushbu Rajakbhai Darjada made history this week, becoming the first Siddi athlete — and only the second Indian — to win a Youth Olympics medal in judo. Before Khushbu's silver in the girls' 63-kg category in Dakar, Senegal, her older sister, Shahin, also a judoka, had represented India at the Junior and Senior Asian Championships, Asian Cup, European Cup, Junior World Championships, and the Tashkent Grand Slam. The Darjada sisters are part of an elite club of boys and girls belonging to the Siddi community of Gujarat who have excelled in sports.

The Siddi people

Siddis — also known as Siddi Badshah, apparently because of their "free-bird" attitude towards life — are one of the five primitive tribes of Gujarat who are physically identifiable by their distinct East African features and hair.

Their appearance is literally skin-deep — an identifier of genetic descent, but little else. The Siddis are Kathiawadis who speak Gujarati with a Kathiawadi accent, and eat and dress like other Gujaratis. Members of the community also live in Maharashtra, Goa, Diu, and Daman.

The Siddi population of Gujarat is concentrated in 18 villages of Talala taluka in Gir Somnath district. The Centre told Rajya Sabha in July 2025 that according to a survey carried out among the community, the population of Siddis in Gujarat who are classified as a Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Group (PVTG) is 12,959.

Out of Africa

"There are various views on how the first Siddis came to India, but there is no definitive record of their arrival," said C C Chaudhari, Executive Director of the Gujarat Tribal Research and Training Society (GTRTS) under the state's Tribal Development Department. "There is a view that the first Siddis were brought to India from Africa by Portuguese colonists, who enslaved them. Others believe that the Siddis were purchased as slaves and brought to India by overland routes by the various invaders from Central and West Asia who came to India during the medieval period," Chaudhari told *The Indian Express*.



Indian judoka Khushbu Rajakbhai Darjada. PTI

Migration to India

The GTRTS's note on the Siddis on its website says: "According to Census (1931), the Siddis appear to have been brought to India by the Portuguese towards the end of 17th century, presumably as slaves; while Russel and Hira Lal (1916) state that they have come to India in the middle of 15th century."

Some members of the Siddi community believe their ancestors were invited to Gujarat by the nawabs of Junagadh, who settled them in their kingdom.

"Around 700 years ago, a nawab of Junagadh travelled to Africa and was impressed by the physical strength of the members of the native population. He brought along a few African families to act as his bodyguards. Since the king was Muslim, our ancestors too adopted Islam," Sadikbhai Makwana, a '*patel*' or leader of the Siddi *jamaat* (traditional community council) in Talala told *The Indian Express*.

Gujarat's Siddis are predominantly Muslim whose religious beliefs have strong Sufi influences. However, some elements and rituals of the Hindu community of Saurashtra are also part of the Siddis' belief system.

Researcher Pravin Patel told this newspaper that like many other tribal communities, the Siddis liked to live happy, uncomplicated lives. They are predominantly non-vegetarian, with food that is typically Kathiawadi. "They are considered to be very kindhearted and simple in nature; people who believe in living as free birds, careless about tomorrow's worries and happy to be by themselves. Perhaps that is why Siddis are known as 'Siddi Badshah', or 'carefree kings'. Siddis themselves address each other by this name," Patel said. According to the Oxford Dictionary, the word 'Siddi' probably derives from the Arabic 'Saiyad', loosely meaning a 'prince'.

Changing, slowly

In 1956, the Centre declared Siddis as a Scheduled Tribe (ST). In 1982, the Government of India declared the Siddis and Padhars as "primitive tribal groups".

Today, Gujarati Siddis residing in Saurashtra are included in the list of STs, but members of the community who live outside the Saurashtra region, in places such as Bharuch, are not. Siddis living outside Saurashtra are classified as a Socially and Economically Backward Community (SEBC).

Members of the community live in both rural and urban areas. Most of them are agricultural and transport labourers, or work as sailors, guards, drivers and guides.

Afsana Makwa (46), the first woman from the Siddi community to have cleared the Gujarat Public Service Commission examination, said the community has gradually recognised the value of education. "Several youths are now completing their higher education... However, the number of such families is still small," Makwa said.

Being natural athletes, several young people, Makwa said, are selected for admission in sports camps. However, many drop out and return to their villages, unable to cope with the discipline of serious sport. "They still believe in independence and want to live like free birds," Makwa said.

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WORDLY WISE
An identity would seem to be arrived at by the way in which the person faces and uses his experience.
— James Baldwin

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IN 1932
BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

'Implementation COP' must live up to its name

THE ORGANISERS of COP31, which opens in Antalya, Türkey, have billed the event as the "Implementation COP". The last climate COP in Belém, Brazil, carried the same description. COP30 did, to an extent, live up to that billing by securing outcomes on climate finance, adaptation and the transition away from fossil fuels, even though it fell short of the ambition required to keep global warming within the 1.5°C limit set at Paris. In the year since Belem, the challenge has become considerably more daunting. Catastrophic floods, deadly heat waves, and prolonged droughts have become increasingly common, while the near inevitability of the world overshooting the 1.5°C threshold underscores the inadequacy of existing commitments. The threat of a super El Niño intensifying extreme weather events adds to the crisis. The focus must now be on making climate action deliver tangible results, particularly for nations that lack the resources to undertake it.

Mitigation remains central to this effort. The transition to clean energy is being increasingly bedevilled by unequal access to finance, technology and infrastructure. Solar power, electric vehicles and battery storage are becoming more cost-efficient, but their adoption remains uneven. Emerging and developing economies outside China, which account for nearly two-thirds of the world's population, received just 18 per cent of global clean-energy investment in 2025. Africa, despite its vast renewable energy potential, attracts only a fraction of these, while nearly 600 million people on the continent still lack electricity. Renewable energy projects in developing countries cost several times more to finance than those in wealthier economies. High borrowing costs and mounting public debt limit their capacity to invest in the transition. The principle of a just shift towards green energy must, therefore, acquire greater substance. Developing countries and emerging economies such as India cannot be expected to abandon fossil fuels at the same pace as advanced economies without adequate support. COP31 must address the barriers that prevent countries from deploying clean energy at scale, rather than simply urging them to raise their targets.

Even ambitious mitigation cannot eliminate the need to prepare for climate impacts that are already unfolding. Adaptation finance, early-warning systems, resilient infrastructure and protection for vulnerable communities is indispensable. The issue of loss and damage, too, cannot remain confined to declarations of concern. The Nepal floods should be proof enough that countries that have contributed least to global emissions face the steepest costs of disasters, with inadequate resources to recover and rebuild. The Loss and Damage Fund must be backed by predictable and sufficient financing. COP31 should find ways to narrow the gap between commitments and delivery.

By abandoning players, SAI rings alarm bells

THERE ARE few things more unusual — and more dismal — in Indian sport than an entire contingent being left to fend for itself financially. Yet, that is what happened to the country's badminton players during their four-tournament European swing, when government funding was declined just days before the Arctic Open in Finland. While individual athletes have occasionally struggled to secure financial support, it is rare for an entire team to be left without sanctioned funding for an international tour. The episode is particularly jarring given how India's sporting ecosystem has evolved over the last decade, with government spending growing nearly four times, from Rs 1,156 crore in 2014-15 to Rs 4,479 crore in 2026-27.

Much of the subsequent debate has centred on P V Sindhu, with some questioning why an established athlete needed government assistance at all. But that misses the point. This was never about one player's ability to pay for her own travel. It was about creating a system in which every athlete, irrespective of their financial standing, has access to consistent support. Sindhu underlined this when she pointed to the younger generation — the likes of Ayush Shetty and Tanvi Sharma — needing institutional backing to pursue their ambitions. Modern sport is not simply about paying for flights and hotel rooms. Competing at the highest level requires a team of coaches, physiotherapists and other support personnel who help athletes prepare and perform. The uncertainty this time also extended to the junior circuit, with India's 30-member contingent for the World Junior Championships in Cairo nearly missing the event after funding clearance failed to arrive before departure. The Badminton Association of India (BAI) eventually scrambled to raise the money, but the episode was unseemly.

The SAI's decision, ostensibly because of procedural delays in the submission of proposals by the BAI, appeared arbitrary and ran counter to the interests of athletes. It also exposed the federation's helplessness: An organisation responsible for India's badminton programme could not ensure that its own players had the resources to compete. The episode should serve as an alarm bell for national federations to build financial models that make them less dependent on government largesse. Public funding will remain essential, but federations must find ways to sustain their programmes. There is something deeply unsettling about a country willing to spend an estimated Rs 20 crore on hosting badminton World Championships, yet leaving its players to worry about how they will pay for their next international tournament.

FREEZE FRAME

BY EP UNNY



Net Zero transition brings opportunity to build, not just import, technology



RAMAKRISHNA R SONDE

THERE IS a persistent weakness in India's technological ambitions: The difficulty of taking research from the laboratory to industrial deployment. Why does a country with excellent scientific institutions and a strong industrial base struggle to turn its intellectual capital into technologies of its own? Atmanirbhar Bharat cannot just mean manufacturing equipment in India while importing the underlying process know-how, critical materials, catalysts, membranes, engineering designs and intellectual property. Such manufacturing creates jobs and economic value, but it does not necessarily deliver technological independence.

True *atmanirbharta* must mean progressively moving from know-how — from importing technologies — to know-why in India (generating IPRs — intellectual property rights), show-how in India (design thinking capabilities), develop how in India (integration of many sub systems) and then improve in India (more IPRs for technology protection) — in addition to Make in India. Why have we struggled to achieve this? After nearly five decades spent first in a national research institution, then in large public- and private-sector industries, and now in academia, I see five recurring reasons.

One, technology development takes time. In sectors such as energy, steel, cement, chemicals and fertilisers, laboratory discoveries must progress through pilot plants to industrial demonstration. Laboratories have to become pilot plants. Pilot plants must become demonstration plants. Equipment fails, materials behave differently at scale, and processes must become safe, reliable and cost-competitive. This requires patient capital and a willingness to accept failure.

Two, industry understandably wants proven technology. Companies cannot risk production or commit unlimited resources to untested ideas. This creates a paradox: If everyone wants proven technology, who will prove a new Indian technology for the first time? The answer lies in sharing development risks rather than leaving industry or academia to shoulder them alone.

Three, technology development is a complex process, commonly described through nine technology readiness levels, or TRLs. A scientific idea begins at lower levels and progresses through laboratory validation, pilot demonstration and finally commercial deployment. Much of Indian academia operates effectively up to roughly TRL 3 or 4. Industry, understandably, prefers to enter around TRL 7 or later. What happens in the interregnum? Too often, very little. Efforts to plug the gap between laboratory validation and industrial demonstration remain inadequately funded. The development of coal-gasification technology suited to India's high-ash coal, for instance, requires a completely different scale of resources, engineering and institutional commitment needed to cross it beyond the successful demonstration scale at a R&D pilot plant.

Four, collaboration hasn't been sufficient. Scientists, engineers, equipment manufacturers, plant operators and policymakers must work together throughout technology development, not merely meet periodically as consortium partners. Academia must understand industrial problems; industry must recognise what research can contribute. Universities, too, must break disciplinary silos.

> If everyone wants proven technology, who will prove a new Indian technology for the first time? The answer lies in sharing development risks rather than leaving industry or academia to shoulder them

Five, nobody owns this journey. Government funds research, academia generates knowledge and industry commercialises technology. But who takes responsibility for carrying promising ideas through demonstration? India needs mechanisms that bring all three together from the outset, with shared responsibilities and financial contributions that evolve as technologies mature. Government must shoulder a greater share of early-stage risk, while industry progressively increases its participation as technical uncertainty falls. Deep-technology incubators and demonstration centres can help bridge the gap.

The transition to Net Zero emissions offers India an extraordinary opportunity. Green hydrogen, carbon capture and utilisation, energy storage, sustainable fuels, new materials and circular manufacturing are not merely environmental necessities. They represent perhaps the largest industrial technology transition since the Industrial Revolution, which will reshape steel, cement, chemicals, fertilisers, transport and power over the coming decades. We should use this transition to create Indian technology. Perhaps India has the highest incentive to develop new technologies as we grow our economy fourfold and build new assets, not as a repeat of what was built earlier on imported technologies. India can build new fertiliser plants, cement plants, steel plants and pharmaceutical plants using entirely new processes and technologies. India must not settle for becoming merely a large market for technologies developed elsewhere. Industry must challenge academia with its most difficult problems, while research institutions must accept greater responsibility for taking their discoveries towards deployment.

AI can accelerate materials discovery, process modelling and equipment design. But it cannot eliminate the need to demonstrate and operate real industrial hardware. We should use this transition to create Indian technology.

India's atomic energy programme offers important lessons. Faced with restrictions on access to advanced technologies, the country developed capabilities of its own. In hindsight, perhaps technology denial brought out the best in us. Something else was equally important: Scientific leadership. Our leaders created a sense of national mission, freedom for scientists and engineers, trust in young people and acceptance of failure as part of technological progress.

That spirit needs to be renewed, not by isolating India from global technology, but by building domestic capabilities alongside it. India has the scientists, industries, entrepreneurs, capital and the target market. It lacks a reliable bridge between scientific discovery and industrial application. Deep-tech incubators and demonstration centres bridge the gap between academia and industry.

Atmanirbhar Bharat must be measured not just by how much equipment India manufactures, but by how much technology it develops, owns, improves and confidently deploys. Building that bridge holds the key to the ambition of becoming Viksit Bharat.

The author is professor emeritus, BITS Pilani & Goa

AI policy must take into account democratic bargain



RUCHI GUPTA

THE SHARE of jobs directly exposed to artificial intelligence is considerably smaller in India than in advanced economies. Yet, its development model is more vulnerable for three reasons.

First, IT services and entry-level cognitive work have been central to India's post-liberalisation development model and the creation of its middle class. More importantly, these upwardly-mobile professionals constitute India's consuming class and support employment in other sectors. The consequences of disruption would, therefore, extend beyond those directly employed in IT and professional services.

Second, unlike advanced economies with ageing populations, India has the world's largest youth population and needs to create productive employment. A technology that allows firms to grow with fewer workers has different implications for a country facing labour shortages and one struggling to absorb young people into work.

Third, the redistributive mechanisms being contemplated in advanced economies, such as universal basic income or public equity stakes in frontier AI companies, are not available to India.

The routine tasks that AI can now perform are the same tasks through which inexperienced workers become experienced. If firms retain senior professionals to review AI-generated work while reducing junior recruitment, they may weaken the pipeline that produces tomorrow's professionals.

The second channel is exports. A foreign bank or retailer that once outsourced coding, support or document processing to India may perform that work internally with AI and a smaller team. Equally, Indian firms may find new opportunities without translating into employment growth. Our recent YouthPOWER analysis shows that sectoral growth is already diverging from workers' outcomes. While software exports have continued to grow, employment and real earnings have weakened.

In India, the impact of technology is likely to show up as an increase in lower-quality work. Already, unemployment is substantially higher among young graduates than among young people as a whole. Consequently, a policy that responds only to announced layoffs will miss those who never get hired. At the same time, AI can widen access to scarce expertise, strengthen small firms and improve public services. The task is to shape adoption so that these gains expand productive opportunities.

> Work gives people competence, independence, social standing and a stake in the future. India must, therefore, judge its AI strategy by whether it expands access to productive work and upward mobility

First, we need a national AI and Work Observatory to track the transition through entry-level recruitment, wages, retention and progression.

Second, we must (re)build pathways into work and protect existing workers. Sectoral apprenticeship arrangements should provide paid, supervised experience using AI on real problems. Generic AI certificates cannot substitute for domain knowledge or professional judgement. Existing workers should have meaningful human review for automated decision-making in the workplace. Portable social protection must accompany this transition.

Third, the transition needs democratic representation. Workers and young people must have a voice in deciding the terms of adoption. A dedicated parliamentary committee should examine AI's effects on work and hear regularly from young people, workers, small firms and state governments alongside technology companies.

These measures must sit within a wider employment strategy to create demand for labour itself. Interventions like apprenticeships and skilling improve access to existing work, not create new work. Ninety per cent of young workers (85 per cent of all ages) in India earn less than Rs 20,000 a month. India's depressed wages constrain domestic consumption and limit the ability of firms to grow and hire. It is this that India needs to tackle along with public investments in health, care, education, housing, urban services and labour-intensive enterprise, where unmet needs are substantial, and technology can strengthen workers' capabilities.

Work gives people competence, independence, social standing and a stake in the future. The democratic bargain rests partly on the expectation that effort can improve one's circumstances. India must, therefore, judge its AI strategy by whether it expands access to productive work and upward mobility. Higher productivity will be a limited achievement if the routes through which young people can share in it continue to narrow.

The writer is executive director, Future of India Foundation

The mud kitchen in Kangra breathes with the seasons



VARUN VAGISH

IN MY Kangra village, I found a contradiction. Our concrete rooms trapped summer heat and became damp iceboxes in winter. Yet our traditional kitchen, with thick mud walls, local stone and slate, stayed cool in summer and warm against the Dhauladhar winds. Cooler towns in the higher reaches had air-conditioned hotels; below, homes needed no ACs or heaters. They breathed with the seasons.

In July 2025, rejecting a builder's plea to build a hotel on Shimla's forested slopes, Supreme Court Justices J B Pardiwala and R Mahadevan warned ecology must come before revenue. The Central Empowered Committee (CEC) issued an interim report on concrete replacing traditional homes. CEC figures show registered hotels grew by 90 per cent and homestays by 670 per cent between 2016 and 2025. Multi-storey cement buildings spread across slopes without carrying-capacity studies. Over 1,000 hydroelectric projects are planned, accounting for 31.9 per cent of forest land diverted.

Our ancestors in Himachal developed earthquake-prone methods like *kath-kuni*, with interlocking deodar timber and dry stone, in Kullu and Shimla; *dhajji-dewari*, with timber and mud, in Kangra and Chamba; and Spiti's rammed earth.

Traditional stone foundations drain rainwater; concrete blocks drainage and weighs down slopes. Geological Survey of India (GSI) surveys after the 2023 monsoon disasters linked landslides in Kullu, Mandi and Shimla to blocked drainage, the weight of multi-storey buildings and 90-degree hill cuts.

When I planned a natural-material home in Kangra, I found the system stacked against it. The 1980 Forest Conservation Act and 1996 tree-felling restrictions trapped villagers' *bartandari* timber rights in red tape. Denied two legal Deodar trees for repairs, villagers may find buying 100 cement bags easier.

Colleges teach concrete; the National Building Code, Public Works Department (PWD) price lists and fire bylaws obstruct mud-and-stone plans. Thirty years ago, schoolbooks called brick-and-cement pucca homes dignified and mud-and-slate kutcha homes poor. The Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana favours cement and brick; banks withhold mud-home loans and insurance.

Trying to build naturally, I could not find workers. Traditional master masons and woodcarvers, known as thawis, are disappearing. Younger helpers refused mudwork, calling kneading earth and dressing stone "dirty" and lowly, while cement work seemed clean, modern and respectable. I sought natural-building architects but found most unaffordable. If someone determined to avoid concrete must give up, what chance does an ordinary family have?

> Our ancestors in Himachal developed earthquake-prone methods like kath-kuni, with interlocking deodar timber and dry stone, in Kullu and Shimla; dhajji-dewari, with timber and mud, in Kangra and Chamba; and Spiti's rammed earth

Himachal must update building codes, PWD schedules, bank rules and PMAY to recognise engineered mud, *kath-kuni* and *dhajji-dewari* as pucca, insurable and loan-eligible. ITIs should teach earth-building with mud-block presses and pay thawis to train; the unspent Rs 273 crore should fund village blueprints and community timber forests.

Concrete doesn't bend. When monsoon clouds burst or fault lines shift, the Himalaya shakes off what doesn't belong. Himachal's survival isn't inside a cement bag; it is still breathing inside that quiet mud kitchen in Kangra.

The writer is the host of the YouTube channel Mountain Trekker

40 YEARS AGO

November 9, 1986


INDIAN EXPRESS
Swoop on Tamil militants in TN
Missiles among arms seized
Couple held for Rajghat incident

Swoop on Tamil militants

IN A surprise swoop at dawn, the Tamil Nadu police rounded up hundreds of Sri Lankan militants in the city and in 15 camps all over the state. A large quantity of unlicensed arms was seized. Residences and offices of five militant group leaders in the city, and their camps in the districts were searched by the police. The leaders were arrested.

Held for Rajghat incident

A COUPLE was arrested for its alleged involvement in the October 2 Rajghat incident to kill Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi, while terrorists injured four people, including three women, in separate incidents in Punjab during the past 24 hours. A report from Gurdaspur said the Central Bureau of Investigation picked up Paramjit Singh and his wife from Dhariwal in Gurdaspur district for their alleged involvement in the conspiracy.

No to Sharad Pawar

IN A dramatic move, the executive committee of the Maharashtra Pradesh Congress Committee (I) unanimously adopted a resolution opposing the entry of Sharad Pawar into the ruling party. Former deputy chief minister Ramrao Adik opposed the imminent merger, voicing the fear that Pawar would indulge in groupism and manoeuvring.

Telecom stir called off

THE 23-day-old work-to-rule agitation by the junior engineers and technicians of the telecommunications department has been called off. The decision was preceded by a settlement. The terms of settlement include the setting-up of a high level committee to recommend new pay scales for junior engineers.

THE INDIAN EXPRESS

The Ideas Page

MONDAY, NOVEMBER 9, 2026

WHAT THE OTHERS SAY

"American voters... must hope that elected Democrats will be deft in using their new levers to shape US actions."
— *The Guardian*

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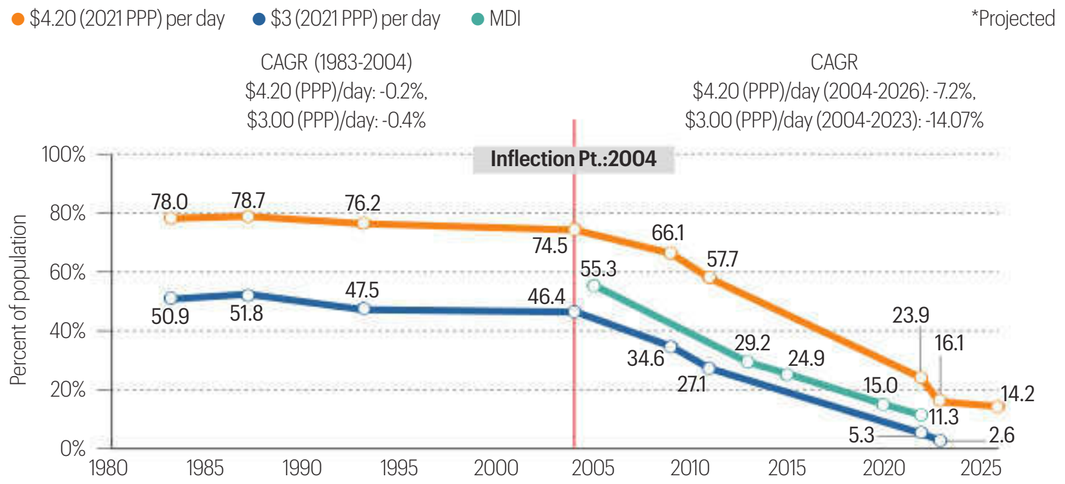
With decline in poverty, shift focus — from free food to nutritional security



FROM PLATE TO PLOUGH

BY ASHOK GULATI, RITIKA JUNEJA AND SULAKSHANA RAO

POVERTY RATE IN INDIA (%)



SOURCE: World Bank Poverty Platform; NITI Aayog

THE WORLD Bank's India Poverty and Equity Brief, released in October 2026, has renewed the debate on poverty in India. It shows extreme poverty, measured at the international line of $3.00 per person per day (2021, Purchasing Power Parity or PPP), falling from 27.1 per cent in 2011 to 2.6 per cent in 2023. At $4.20 a day, poverty fell from 57.7 per cent to 16.1 per cent over the same period, which the Bank calls one of the fastest declines in the world. The estimates draw on three official household consumption and expenditure surveys (HCES): The 2011–12, 2022–23 and 2023–24 HCES. The Bank cautions that part of the latest gain reflects better measurement, not just better lives.

The World Bank's long series on poverty status tells a more interesting story. In 1983, 78 per cent of Indians lived below $4.20 a day (PPP). By 2004, after two decades that included the 1991 economic reforms, the figure was still at 74.5 per cent, a decline of just 0.2 per cent a year. Then the pace of decline in poverty accelerated sharply. Poverty fell to 16.1 per cent in 2023 and an estimated 14.2 per cent in 2026, a decline of about 7.2 per cent per year, more than 30 times the earlier pace. At $3 a day, poverty fell from 46.4 per cent in 2004 to 2.6 per cent in 2023, about 14 per cent a year, against 0.4 per cent during 1983–2004. NITI Aayog's multidimensional poverty index, built from 12 indicators of health, nutrition, education and living standards, also tells a similar story: Poverty fell from 55.3 per cent in 2005 to 11.3 per cent in 2022. Statistically, 2004 is the inflection point in India's poverty drop chart (see the infographics).

What drove this dramatic decline? Part of the answer is growth, and part is a quieter force: Demographics. GDP growth rose from an average of 5.7 per cent a year during 1980-81 to 2004-05 to 6.9 per cent during 2005-06 to 2024-25. But population growth fell from 2.1 per cent to 1.2 per cent a year. As a result, per capita GDP growth jumped from 3.5 per cent to 5.6 per cent: Each rupee of growth was shared among fewer new mouths. The effect is sharper in agriculture. Agricultural GVA growth rose only from 3.4 to 3.9 per cent, but per capita agricultural GVA growth more than doubled, from 1.27 to 2.67 per cent over the two periods. This matters a lot, as the 'World Development Report 2008', covering 42 countries over 1981-2003, found that 1 per cent of GDP growth from agriculture is at least 2.5 times more potent in reducing poverty compared to similar growth from other sectors.

The Labour Bureau's data also show that real farm wages grew at 5.4 per cent between 2004-05 and 2013-14. However, this has slowed down drastically since 2014-15, and yet it has reduced poverty. That seems somewhat paradoxical. An uncomfortable fact is also that employment in agriculture rose from 42.5 per cent in 2018-19 to 46.5 per cent in 2020-21, as lockdowns pushed workers back to villages, before settling at 43 per cent in 2025-26. The World Bank brief confirms that real earnings remain broadly flat, with new jobs concentrated in low-productivity work. When labour cannot move out of farming, farm wages stagnate, and weak farm incomes in turn limit rural demand for manufactured goods. China's economic reforms during 1978-84 showed that farm reforms raised rural incomes, which created demand for manufactured goods. This triggered a manufacturing revolution through town and village enterprises (TVEs). This is an important lesson for India to note if it wants its manufacturing to rev up.

> Nutritional security also demands that our basic staples are biofortified with iron and zinc, as wheat and rice have become deficient in these. This is a result of impoverished soils, starved of soil organic carbon

Welfare measures such as MGNREGA, rolled out in 2006, and the National Food Security Act of 2013 (rechristened as PM-Garib Kalyan Yojana, or PM-GKY) may have also played a role in reducing poverty. This is especially true when food allocations were enhanced to 10 kg/person/month during the Covid period. The Centre has since extended PM-GKY for five years, from 2024 to about 81 crore beneficiaries. However, now with the economy back on track and extreme poverty down at 2.6 per cent, this extensive coverage under PM-GKY is hard to justify. The cost is steep: PM-GKY is budgeted at Rs 2.27 lakh crore in 2026-27. It raises a fundamental question: If extreme poverty is down to 2.6 per cent, why give free food to more than half the population? This needs rationalisation. Late PM Atal Bihari Vajpayee's formula of giving free to *antyodya* (the poorest of the poor) and charging at least half the procurement price to others may be a useful one today. As the adage goes, it is better to teach a person how to catch fish than to hand out a free fish every day.

Reform is a continuous process, and the time has come to rationalise the food subsidy bill and reorient it towards nutritional security. Our malnutrition numbers, especially of children below the age of five, are still very high. India cannot become Viksit Bharat if malnutrition remains high, and PM-GKY, in its current form, by giving wheat and rice, cannot solve this problem. It is better to give options to people to opt for food coupons that can buy other healthier food items like millets, pulses, milk and eggs from designated stores. Nutritional security also demands that our basic staples are biofortified with iron and zinc, as wheat and rice have become deficient in these. This is a result of impoverished soils, starved of soil organic carbon (SOC). India's SOC hovers around 0.3 per cent as against a desirable level of 1.5 to 2.0, according to World Food Laureate, Rattan Lal. Diversifying diets and the production basket can improve nutrition. Can the Modi government bite the bullet and improve the nutrition of soils, crops and people? Only time will tell.

Gulati is Distinguished Professor, Juneja and Rao are Senior Fellows at ICRIER. Views are personal

US voters' message to Democrats: Don't play safe



JONAH BLANK

THE AMERICAN people have sent a clear message: They really, really, really hate Donald Trump. He wasn't technically on the ballot, but also: He definitely was. The Republican candidates were nothing more than Trump's servile minions, and the election was a referendum on their master. Democrats won solid majorities in both the House and the Senate, in the biggest blowout of any midterm election in half a century. The question now: What will it change?

Trump will hold the presidency for the next two years, with power that (thanks in part to a friendly Supreme Court) is nearly imperial. So long as he retains the fealty of 34 senators (and Republicans will hold at least 44 seats), he can block any legislation the Democrats might enact. But the victory matters for at least five reasons.

First, all decisions on raising and spending government funds are, under the US constitution, entirely up to Congress. As a matter of law, the president can't continue his war on Iran, or levy tariffs, or send masked goons to kidnap construction workers without Congressional approval. As a matter of real-world fact, of course, this President will do as he pleases. But he'll be doing so over the express wishes of Congress rather than with its supine consent — and that isn't nothing.

Trump will continue moving money around according to his whim, and mire any attempt at judicial accountability in multi-year lawsuits before judges he himself appointed. If Congress withholds the funds to keep the machinery of government operating, Trump will win any game of chicken over a shutdown: He doesn't care about governance, so he has nothing to lose. But Democrats will start to turn the direction of government spending: They won't be able to claw back the hundreds of billions Trump has allegedly siphoned off to corporations and plutocrats (including himself), but they'll at least stanch the flow.

The second is pausing Trump's subversion of the judiciary. Federal judges must be confirmed by the Senate, and the Democrats will be able to block Trump's stacking of the judiciary with his puppets. This is most important for the Supreme Court, which already has a Trumpist supermajority, but it extends throughout the federal appellate and district courts. Judiciary reform, including expansion of the Supreme Court, must be a priority of the next Democratic administration. Until then, Democrats can (and should) refuse any new confirmations.

The third is investigations. Public hearings, with the power of subpoena, can shine a light on much of the corruption, mismanagement, and illegality that has characterised Trump's rule. This will establish a public record, and set the stage for prosecutions if a future Democratic administration decides it's interested in accountability.

The fourth is creating a legislative agenda. Democrats won't be able to pass laws without Trump's approval, but they can deliver a procession of bills to his desk and make him veto them. What would the Democrats legislate if they had a cooperative president: Halt data centres and block the reckless explosion of AI? Health care for all? Abolish ICE? In the 2028 presidential election, Democrats will need a clear, strong message that is not merely "Stop Trump". They can write the promissory notes for that programme now.

The last is impeachment. Yes, as the Democrats learned during Trump's first term, it's far easier to impeach a president in the House (requires a simple majority) than to convict and remove him from office in the Senate (requires a supermajority). And, yes, many Democrats are too gun-shy to go down this path again. But the threat of impeachment is the only real weapon the Democrats will possess — and the only true check on an utterly lawless President. In his first term, Trump broke the law frequently, and was impeached twice. In his second, on his watch, entire government agencies have been abolished without any act of Congress. In order for Trump to be removed from office, about a dozen Republican senators would have to switch sides. That's highly unlikely, but it's happened before: Richard Nixon was forced to resign by the threat of such action by his own party.

Democratic leaders will be tempted to spend the next two years playing it safe: Don't rock the boat, avoid conflicts with Trump, wait him out and focus the next presidential election on the price of groceries. That would be a mistake. The candidates who won spanned the ideological spectrum, from centrists like Roy Cooper in North Carolina to progressives like Abdul El-Sayed in Michigan. But they had one thing in common: A desire to fight.

If the Democrats listen to the electorate, that's what they'll do with the power they've been given. Stand up to Trump and his cronies. Roll back the corrupt giveaways to billionaires and corporations. Fight for the people who put them in office. Fight for democracy. Fight for us all.

Blank is author of Arrow of the Blue-Skinned God: Retracing the Ramayana Through India *and* Mullahs on the Mainframe: Islam and Modernity Among the Daudi Bohras

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A hasty step

THE SO-CALLED revamping of the Agnipath scheme is a hasty step. It will benefit neither the forces nor the Agniveers. The scheme was introduced without required consultations or consideration of its impact on the forces and those enrolling. The only objective was saving on pension expenses ('Revamped Agnipath casts wider net,' *IE*, November 6). There were provisions for drafting soldiers as reservists after 10 years until 1976. The best solution now is to enhance retention, as recommended by the Air Force and Navy.

Vasant Nalawade, Satara

Beyond the zero FIR

WOMEN'S SAFETY and the legal framework surrounding it involve issues that go far beyond what a zero FIR can address. ('Zero FIR is progressive, but it is not enough', *IE*, November 6) While it may represent a positive step forward, meaningful change cannot be achieved without tackling challenges such as inaccessible legal systems, slow judicial processes, and uncooperative public offices. Expediting these processes will encourage more victims of assault to come forward. This fundamental requirement should be kept in mind when introducing reforms aimed at addressing the issue.

Shreya Shenoy, Mumbai

For clean air

PENALISING FARMERS for stubble burning without affordable alternatives will not bring lasting change. ('A new conversation is needed on farm fires', *IE*, November 6) Small cultivators face narrow sowing windows, labour shortages and machinery costs; these constraints cannot be legislated away. Governments must provide subsidised equipment, local hiring centres and reliable markets for crop residue. Enforcement is important, but it must follow practical support. Only shared responsibility can deliver clean air.

K Sakunthala, Coimbatore

Next on nation's to-do list: More productive jobs



TEJASVI SURYA AND KISHEN SHASTRY

A RECENT popular book, *Breakneck*, made a rather convincing argument that the United States is a lawyerly society and rapidly growing China is an engineering state, and that each has much to learn from the other. Many have since commented on how to characterise India. In the past decade, India has pursued a distinctive path by combining the ambition of an engineering state with the checks and balances of a multiparty democracy. It is hard to unpack a state, but let us consider the evidence we have on the Narendra Modi era that allows us to judge how far this has succeeded.

Modi's path has been much harder than the one faced by celebrated reformers such as Ronald Reagan and Margaret Thatcher, whose reforms were largely subtractive. They inherited a highly capable state and drove reform by removing things: Deregulation, privatisation and lower taxes. However, Prime Minister Modi's reforms had to be both additive and subtractive. His government had to build the state's basic reach, through toilets, bank accounts, identity cards, and infrastructure such as roads and ports while reforming existing institutions and making progress on GST and the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code. India often had to confront 19th- and 21st-century problems at the same time.

The results are validated with the World Bank's latest brief on poverty. Between 2011 and 2023, India's extreme poverty declined from 27.1 per cent to 2.6 per cent. At the same time, close to 50 crore people moved above the lower-middle-income poverty line. A sharp reduction in poverty like this is not a result of business-as-usual thinking. The Bank attributes this to strong consumption growth, rising employment, especially among women, and expanded social transfers, including food subsidies. Consumption inequality also decreased.

A part of how this was achieved is equally interesting. Direct Benefit Transfer had a reluctant start with rollout limited to some districts and was eventually abandoned for cooking gas by the previous government before the 2014 elections. Modi not only revived it but transformed and scaled the architecture of identity, bank accounts and payment rails across hundreds of schemes. This allowed subsidies to be paid directly and reduced leakages. Sustained focus on digital public infrastructure has allowed the state to provide effective social protection to a wide array of vulnerable groups.

> Critical reforms in power, land, urban planning and agricultural markets are in the hands of the state governments. A key risk is their fiscal space, as they now spend over 3 lakh crore on subsidies

India has delivered these results at a time when the rest of the world's economic growth has been relatively subdued and chaotic. From an estimate of Surjit Bhalla and Karan Bhasin, India had an excess growth of 2.2 percentage points above the rest of the world between 2004 and 2013, which increased to around 3 percentage points between 2014 and 2023.

It is natural that people compare the progress on poverty between China and India. China lifted close to 80 crore people out of extreme poverty over four decades, while India moved 50 crore people above the lower-middle-income poverty line in just 12 years. Not much attention is paid to the fact that India has done this in a democratic multiparty system with powerful state governments. Creating more productive employment is the top priority, and much still needs to be done to continue the process of reforms. Reforms in power, land, urban planning and agricultural markets are in the hands of the state governments. A key risk is their fiscal space, as they now spend over 3 lakh crore on subsidies. Karnataka, for instance, has budgeted over 1 lakh crore for subsidies this year, close to a third of its revenue receipts. Combined with salaries, pensions and interest payments, these expenditures are equivalent to over 90 per cent of revenue receipts.

The past decade has shown India's ability to build state capacity at scale, but the next should focus on sustaining reforms across states. Social protection is essential, but it should go hand in hand with investments and reforms that enable more productive employment.

Surya is BJP Member of Parliament representing Bengaluru South and Shastry is at University of Cambridge

Gender struggles must forge solidarities, not exclusion



SWARUPA DEB

A RECENT petition filed by a women's group before the Supreme Court has challenged the legal recognition of transgender women as "females" in official documents. It argued that recognising trans women within the legal categories of cis women potentially affects sex-based reservation, sporting categories, access to women-only spaces and safeguards available to women.

In the aftermath of the Transgender Amendment Act, 2026, trans women being recast as a threat to cis women's rights has serious implications. The suggestion deserves serious scrutiny, particularly when advanced in the language of women's protection. Who gets to claim the political category of woman, and who has the authority to determine its boundaries?

Feminist movements have contested the assumption that reproductive capacity determines women's social position, anatomy exhausts the meaning of sex, or that a singular experience of womanhood can stand as the universal basis of feminist politics. This eventually facilitated the transgender movement and scholarship.

Historian Sam Caslin documents how trans and cis feminists worked together during the 1970s to advance feminist positions on bodily autonomy. Their collaboration showed that transgender interventions were part of the development of feminist critiques of gender, embodiment and medical power and the two cannot be treated as historically distinct political projects.

The Indian feminist movement has its own history of such solidarity. A particularly important solidarity effort came to the fore in November 2019, when a group of Indian women's organisations and feminist groups issued a statement opposing provisions in the then-proposed transgender legislation that made legal recognition dependent upon certification by state authorities and medical documentation. It drew upon feminist struggles to argue that trans persons must be able to determine their own gender identity.

This is not to suggest that trans women and cis women inhabit identical social conditions. However, they cannot be resolved by treating trans recognition as a threat to women. Nor should the structural inequalities experienced by cis women be mobilised to deny the legitimacy of trans lives.

> Debate must be premised on recognising transgender persons as equal rights-bearing subjects, rather than radically positioning their legal recognition as a presumptive threat to women

The petition before the SC raises questions about the relationship between gender identity, sex-based classifications and access to particular legal protections. These require reasoned debate. But such debate must be premised on recognising transgender persons as equal rights-bearing subjects, rather than radically positioning their legal recognition as a presumptive threat to women. The constitutional guarantee of equality cannot be upheld by a politics in which one marginalised group's protection is secured at the expense of another.

When the political category of women is defined through a narrow biological criterion, it risks obscuring the experiences of womanhood that do not neatly fit into the normative classifications of gender roles. Feminist scholarship has long interrogated how legal and institutional categories produce particular understandings of gender, determine whose experiences become legible, and distribute rights and protections accordingly.

The long history of feminist struggles against the regulation and policing of gendered bodies offers a ground to question those politics that seek to secure women's rights by narrowing the category they depend on. The defence of women's rights loses its feminist force when it depends upon the exclusion of other gendered lives.

The writer is a human rights lawyer and sociologist

{ WEEKLY CAPSULE }

This vitamin sharpens human vision



SCIENTISTS AT Johns Hopkins University have uncovered a surprising process that helps humans develop sharp vision before birth, challenging decades of assumptions about how the eye forms. Using miniature human retinas grown in the lab, researchers discovered that a vitamin A derivative and thyroid hormones work together to shape the foveola, the tiny region at the centre of the retina responsible for our sharpest vision. This is the key to advancing research into future treatments for macular degeneration, glaucoma and other conditions that cause vision loss.

Reverse ageing in liver cells



A SURPRISING discovery suggests that rejuvenating the liver could help protect against Alzheimer's disease and heart disease. Researchers at the Keck School of Medicine of the University of South California found that an experimental drug restored aging liver cells in rats, cutting levels of an Alzheimer's-linked protein in half and bringing bad cholesterol down to youthful levels. Levels of LDL, commonly called bad cholesterol, returned to those seen in younger animals. The treatment also revived a previously unknown communication system that helps liver cells remove harmful substances from the blood.

What's the obesity paradox?



IN A surprising discovery, scientists at McGill University found that certain diets associated with obesity can make cancer immunotherapy more effective in mice, challenging assumptions about diet and cancer treatment. The findings suggest that the secret may lie in how food interacts with gut bacteria to strengthen the immune system's response to cancer. The investigation grew out of a long-standing puzzle called the "obesity paradox." Obesity is a cancer risk. Yet several studies have found that cancer patients with a higher body mass index (BMI) sometimes respond more favourably to immune checkpoint inhibitors.

Avocado, mango good for heart



EATING AN avocado and a cup of mango every day may provide surprising benefits for heart health, according to a new study involving adults with prediabetes. After just eight weeks, participants experienced significant improvements in blood vessel function and diastolic blood pressure, particularly among men. These benefits occurred without weight gain or changes in calorie intake, suggesting that the nutrient-rich combination could support cardiovascular health. Researchers at Illinois Institute of Technology found improvement in the ability of blood vessels to expand as blood flows through them.

Excess weight ages the brain



A MAJOR 24-year study at the University of Georgia, involving more than 8,200 adults, suggests that excess body weight may accelerate brain aging, leading to faster declines in memory, concentration and decision-making skills. Each one-point increase in BMI was associated with a faster rate of cognitive decline, suggesting that even relatively small differences in body weight could matter over time. The connection was particularly strong among people over 65, raising concerns about the long-term effects of obesity on brain health.



SUGAR-FREE LIFE

DR V MOHAN
CHAIRMAN, DR MOHAN'S DIABETES SPECIALITIES CENTRE, CHENNAI

Are sweeteners pushing up your sugar cravings?

Sugar substitutes may cut calories but are silently influencing eating behaviour

ARTIFICIAL SWEETENERS are increasingly being used as sugar substitutes, particularly by people with diabetes, obesity and those trying to lose weight. They are commonly promoted as a healthier option because they provide sweetness with fewer or no calories. But are they really as harmless as we have been led to believe?

Emerging research suggests that we need to look beyond calories and consider their possible effects on the brain, metabolism, gut health and eating behaviour. A study published in *Neurology*, the journal of the American Academy of Neurology, followed 12,772 adults in Brazil for approximately eight years. Researchers found that individuals consuming the highest amounts of certain low- and no-calorie sweeteners experienced faster declines in memory and thinking abilities, equivalent to approximately 1.6 additional years of brain ageing. The association appeared particularly concerning among people with diabetes.

The sweeteners examined included aspartame, saccharin, acesulfame-K, erythritol, xylitol, sorbitol and tagatose. Six were associated with faster cognitive decline. There are also emerging concerns about the possible effects of some artificial sweeteners on gut microbiota, the microorganisms that influence digestion, immunity and metabolic health. These findings deserve further investigation.

Artificial sweeteners provide an intensely sweet taste, sometimes much sweeter than ordinary sugar, without necessarily providing the calories that the body would normally associate with that sweetness. Repeated exposure to highly sweetened foods and beverages may reinforce our preference for sweet tastes and make it harder for the brain's pleasure centre to become comfortable with naturally less-sweet foods.



Replacing sugar with artificial sweeteners should not become an excuse to maintain an excessive preference for sweetness

There is also concern that habitual dependence on sweet-tasting products may encourage repeated cravings, snacking and a tendency to seek sweet foods throughout the day. Some research has suggested that non-sugar sweeteners may influence appetite regulation and food preferences, although evidence that they directly cause addiction or consistently increase hunger remains inconclusive.

The important point is that replacing sugar with artificial sweeteners should not become an excuse to maintain an excessive preference for sweetness. We should aim to gradually retrain our taste buds rather than simply substitute one sweet product for another. Not all sugar substitutes are alike. Stevia, derived from a plant, contains purified steviol glycosides that have an established safety profile when consumed within recommended limits. Approved, high-purity stevia products can be considered as an alternative, although plant-derived does not automatically mean risk-free.

Sucralose is another commonly used sweetener. Research from the Madras Diabetes Research Foundation (MDRF), Chennai, provides some useful Indian evidence. In a 12-week randomised controlled study involving 210 adults with Type 2 diabetes, replacing approximately 60 calories of added sugar with sucralose in tea or coffee resulted in modest reductions in body weight (approximately 0.5 kg), BMI and waist circumference. However, there was no significant improvement in HbA1c or blood glucose levels of three months. This suggests that using a small quantity of sucralose to replace added sugar in tea or coffee may be a reasonable practical option. But it should not be interpreted as permission for unrestricted consumption or proof of long-term metabolic benefits.

Given the emerging research, I would advise against developing a routine dependence on aspartame, saccharin, acesulfame-K, erythritol, xylitol, sorbitol and other sugar substitutes without a clear need. The findings regarding cognitive health are concerning enough to justify moderation, although they do not establish that normal dietary consumption causes neurological damage. This is perhaps the most important message for anyone with diabetes, obesity or metabolic syndrome. Using artificial sweeteners does not make a diet healthy, nor does it guarantee weight loss. A person may avoid sugar in tea and coffee but compensate by consuming larger portions, frequent snacks. The best strategy is not to replace every spoonful of sugar with an artificial sweetener. It is to gradually reduce our overall dependence on sweetness.

Despite cancer drug price caps, survival remains a costly battle

Anonna Dutt, Anuradha Mascarenhas, Purnima Sah

Trade margin caps on 137 cancer drugs have brought down some prices but left several patented drugs untouched. Patients are still left in the lurch



GETTYIMAGES

FORTY-FIVE-YEAR-OLD Neeta Kumar*, a resident of Noida, was diagnosed with an aggressive form of breast cancer in September. When her doctors suggested a new drug that had shown considerable promise in treating her condition, the family was hopeful. But there was a catch: the treatment would cost them at least Rs 10 lakh.

The drug, pembrolizumab, marketed as Keytruda by pharmaceutical giant MSD, is an immunotherapy shot used to treat at least 18 types of cancer, including the kind of breast cancer Kumar has. Under the company's patient access programme, patients must pay for the first five infusions, after which they can receive up to 12 additional infusions free in a year. Each infusion is administered every 21 days. This is over and above the expenses on chemotherapy, surgery and other supportive care.

The total treatment estimate given to Kumar's family was around Rs 20 lakh. A homemaker, she has no personal health insurance, while her husband works in the informal sales sector. Her brother, a professor, has health insurance but cannot extend its benefits to her. Faced with a choice between death and debt, they decided to go ahead with what they considered the best available treatment. But even that decision came with complications. The hospital where Kumar is undergoing treatment told the family that although she was eligible for treatment under the economically weaker sections (EWS) category, she would not be able to access immunotherapy under that arrangement. To receive the drug, the family would have to pay in full.

"Even for more affluent families, this cost would be a significant hit. Without any coverage, it feels impossible. Add to that the unfair policies of the hospitals and associated costs," says her brother.

With her first cycle of immunotherapy approaching, the family was relieved to hear that pembrolizumab was among the cancer medicines for which the government had announced a cap on trade margins. They hoped this would bring down the price, even if only marginally. There was, however, no relief. Despite the government capping trade margins at 30%, the price of the patented drug remained unchanged at Rs 2.17 lakh per vial.

Kumar's experience illustrates a larger problem with the Centre's latest intervention to make cancer medicines more affordable. While the government has capped trade margins on 137 cancer medicines, including expensive patented drugs such as pembrolizumab and ribociclib, the move has not necessarily translated into lower prices for patients. An analysis of revised prices submitted by pharmaceutical companies shows that several of the most expensive formulations, particularly patented medicines, have remained untouched. And even where prices have fallen, the reductions are often too small to make a meaningful difference to families facing treatment bills running into lakhs.

The difference between having access to these medicines and being able to afford them is stark.

Prohibitive therapies

Take the case of 59-year-old Paresh Shah, who has been living with lung cancer since 2018. His cancer was detected at an advanced stage, after it had spread to his lymph nodes and backbone. Yet, following immunotherapy, he continues to feel physically fit and has no outward symptoms of the disease.

Immunotherapy works by using the body's own immune system to fight cancer and can cause fewer side effects than conventional chemotherapy and radiotherapy. But access to these newer treatments remains largely restricted to patients who have the financial means or insurance coverage to pay for them. Shah was fortunate to have comprehensive health insurance through his employer. Nearly 80% of his treatment costs, including the immunotherapy drug, were covered. "Just for one year in between I had to pay out-of-pocket, for which I broke into my savings. I was fortunate to have the means to go through the treatment," he says.

For patients without such coverage, the same treatment can be financially prohibitive. Majida MA, 49, a lawyer from Kerala undergoing treatment for breast cancer, had little expectation that the latest trade margin intervention would bring down the cost of her medication. The immunotherapy medicine prescribed to her, ribociclib, marketed as Kyxana by Novartis, has a maximum retail price of just under Rs 1 lakh. Even after discounts, she spends between Rs 65,000 and Rs 80,000 every month.

Majida had earlier approached the Kerala High Court, seeking directions for the government to use interventions under patent law or other mechanisms to make the drug more accessible to patients. Her medicine was included in the government's 2019 pilot on trade margin rationalisation. Yet, its price has continued to rise. "The 2019 move had failed to control the prices and even though the medicine was included in the list again, I knew that there wouldn't really be a change in the prices," she says.

The limits of price control

The Centre announced the latest Trade Margin Rationalisation (TMR) order last month, capping trade margins on 137 cancer medicines at 30% over the price at the first point of sale, whether to a stockist or directly to a hospital. Pharmaceutical companies were asked to calculate revised prices and submit them to the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA), with the new prices coming into effect from November 9. An analysis of revised prices submitted by companies for 643 formulations — covering different strengths, doses and brands of the 137 medicines — shows that the average reduction was less than 40%. Only five formulations saw price cuts of more than 90%.

More significantly, the prices of 159 formulations remained unchanged. These included all the patented drugs in the analysis. The most expensive medicines were disproportionately represented among those whose prices did not fall: 53 of the 159 formulations with unchanged prices cost more than Rs 1 lakh per pack. A reduction of more than Rs 10,000 per pack was recorded in only one in six formulations. The prices of 83 formulations fell by between Rs 5,000 and Rs 10,000, while 173 saw reductions of between Rs 1,000 and Rs 5,000, according to the analysis by the Working Group on Access to Medicines and Treatments.

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For patients, these numbers point to the limitations of an intervention that regulates trade margins but does not necessarily address the underlying price of expensive patented medicines.

Dr Sarika Gupta, who specialises in gynaecological cancers, says that some immunotherapies have proved highly effective, citing pembrolizumab for the treatment of endometrial cancer. But their cost often puts them beyond the reach of most patients. "Even when we give the option, most people do not choose it because the drug alone can cost more than the surgery and chemotherapy sometimes," she says.

The problem is compounded by the fact that immunotherapy is often prescribed only after other treatment options have failed. These medicines are generally used in patients with advanced or recurrent cancers, by which point families may already have exhausted much of their savings. "What this means, however, is that they have already exhausted their funds by the time they reach the immunotherapy stage. So, most patients end up not receiving the treatment," Dr Gupta adds.

For patients who have already fought cancer once, the financial burden can become a recurring ordeal. Seventy-year-old Poonam Nanda, who has battled breast cancer twice, was confronted with the possibility of another round of treatment when her cancer returned. "Lungs are clear, breasts are clear, lesions have shrunk, but there are four new ones," her doctor told her on her last follow-up. Nanda, who had helped her nephew and cricketer Yuvraj Singh through his battle with cancer and later mentored patients through the YouWeCan foundation, called him after hearing the news. But beyond the fear of recurrence, another concern weighed on her: "More importantly, I worried about another round of expense. How long can I go on?"

First diagnosed with breast cancer in 2009, Nanda underwent at least nine sessions of chemotherapy, each costing around Rs 50,000 at the time, followed by radiation and medication. When the cancer returned in 2018, she underwent surgery, radiation and hormonal treatment. In 2024, another lump developed at the base of her neck, with the disease spreading to her bones and liver. Her subsequent treatment included three courses of stereotactic body radiation therapy (SBRT), a highly targeted form of radiation, costing approximately Rs 3 lakh each. The total expenditure came close to Rs 10 lakh.

She was also prescribed Pivikto, a patented drug without a generic alternative, which cost approximately Rs 2,500 a day for two tablets. After nine months, she was shifted to hormonal medication. Her regular medication expenses now amount to around Rs 1 lakh a month, excluding periodic investigations, scans and other procedures. Despite having insurance and financial resources, Nanda could recover only around 50% of these expenses through her policy. The rest had to be paid out of pocket.

The financial burden is particularly severe for patients who have to travel long distances to access specialised cancer care. Lisha Jain, from Nalbari in Assam, has spent an estimated Rs 17-18 lakh on breast cancer treatment so far. This includes Rs 30,000 for a biopsy, Rs 30,000 for genetic testing, Rs 6 lakh for a bilateral mastectomy, Rs 1.2 lakh for 16 sessions of radiotherapy and Rs 1.44 lakh for a year of oral chemotherapy. Without health insurance, her family exhausted its savings and had to seek financial help from friends. The expenses did not end with the treatment itself. Jain spent around one-and-a-half years in Mumbai with her son and mother, paying for accommodation, schooling, local travel and daily living expenses. She continues to travel from Assam to Mumbai every six months for consultations. Flights for three family members cost between Rs 70,000 and Rs 80,000 per trip, while hotel accommodation for five to six days costs around Rs 2,500 a day, apart from consultation fees and investigations.

Patent expiry eases burden

There are, however, examples of how cancer treatment can become substantially more affordable when market competition increases. Dr Sachin Hingmire, senior medical oncologist at Deenanath Mangeshkar Hospital, Pune, cites the example of palbociclib, a drug used to treat hormone receptor-positive breast cancer. Around four years ago, when the drug was protected by an international patent, it cost approximately Rs 1.5 lakh a month. Following the expiry of the patent, more than 40-50 Indian pharmaceutical companies began marketing the drug, bringing its monthly cost down to around Rs 10,000.

For patients such as Nanda, however, the availability of cheaper alternatives depends on the medicine prescribed and whether a generic version exists. Patented drugs without generic competition continue to impose a significant financial burden.

Industry seeks wider measures

The Organisation of Pharmaceutical Producers of India (OPPI) has supported the Centre's Trade Margin Rationalisation order, saying it could improve the affordability and accessibility of cancer medicines. Its director-general, Anil Matai, says effective implementation and monitoring would be important to ensure that patients benefit from the intervention without disrupting the continued availability of medicines.

But sustained improvements in access, argues OPPI, would require stronger reimbursement mechanisms and greater collaboration among the government, insurers, pharmaceutical industry and other stakeholders. The distinction between a drug being available and being affordable is still critical. As well as infrastructure. "Had there been screening facilities back home, I wouldn't have been in a debt trap," says Jain.

*(*Name changed to protect privacy)*

COST OF healthcare

{ NEWSMAKERS IN THE NEWSROOM }

WHY PARGAT SINGH

Pargat Singh's leadership as Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee (PPCC) President is significant as Punjab stands at a crucial juncture ahead of the 2027 Assembly elections. A former Indian hockey captain and Olympian, Singh brings a legacy of discipline, teamwork and international recognition to politics. As a three-time MLA, he understands grassroots politics and Punjab's challenges, including unemployment, farmers' distress, drug abuse and governance. His key responsibility is to unite Congress factions, strengthen the organisation and reconnect with the people of Punjab

'The centralised governance model BJP implemented in Delhi is what AAP adopted in Punjab. We must demolish it'

Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee (PPCC) President Pargat Singh on why Punjab needs a change in governance, the drug menace, the state's mounting debt, and Congress's efforts to overcome factionalism. The conversation was moderated by Manoj CG, Chief of National Bureau, Politics, *The Indian Express*



ILLUSTRATION: SUVAJIT DEY

ON UPCOMING PUNJAB ELECTIONS

Punjab never gives a fractured verdict; it gives a clear mandate. This time, from what I can see, AAP will crumble like a mound of sand. Punjab mein purely *Congress ki sarkaar aane wali hai*

ON DISTRUST IN ELECTION PROCESS

Amendment of Form 6 was neither passed in Parliament nor was it directed by the SC. A theft is a theft. Issuing and amending the form without judicial or parliamentary authority is illegal

Manoj CG: You were one of the greatest hockey defenders of your era. As the Congress enters the Assembly election battle, why do you seem to be on the defensive when you should be aggressively taking on the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP)? It appears factional infighting has pushed you to the forefront.

My strength in sports was that I watched everyone from behind. And whenever I was required to attack, I did. I do not have that feeling of being on the defensive because I know I have to lead this to a conclusion: that we should not only form the government in Punjab, but also successfully run it. That is the fundamental idea behind it.

Manoj CG: Another argument behind your selection as State Congress President is that all the other senior leaders — be it Partap Singh Bajwa, Charanjit Singh Channi or Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa — are in the race for the Chief Minister's post. You are known across Punjab as a leader with a clean image, but without an eye on the CM's post. How do you see this?

It is not about the CM's post; it is about saving Punjab. Punjab does not tolerate politics of *nafrat* (hatred) or looters. The chair is not a big deal to me. The team, Punjab and the Congress as a vehicle to serve Punjab, are paramount. Given Punjab's current condition, that chair is not ordinary. It is not even a bed of thorns but like sitting on spikes from every angle, whether it is law and order, drugs or mismanagement. The model the BJP implemented in Delhi is almost exactly what the Aam Aadmi Party adopted in Punjab. It does not suit Punjab. We must demolish it and establish true democracy. Its beauty lies in its four pillars. If even one turns dictatorial, surrenders or becomes a puppet, democracy ceases to exist and becomes dictatorship. The country is heading towards dictatorship. Every person and institution must perform their duty honestly. That is what democracy means.

Manoj CG: In the 2026 Kerala Assembly elections, Congress barred sitting Lok Sabha MPs from contesting, ultimately selecting elected MLA VD Satheesan as CM over MP KC Venugopal. Given this precedent of prioritising local legislative talent, should Punjab's prominent Lok Sabha MPs contest the upcoming state elections?

That is purely the party's decision, and it differs from time to time and place to place. I am not rigid about anything. When we sit together, if MPs wish to contest and the requirement exists, it may happen; if there is no requirement, it might not. It depends entirely on the party high command.

Manraj Grewal Sharma: CM Bhagwant Mann and AAP rely heavily on free electricity and monthly grants for women to win elections. Wherever he goes, Mann warns, 'If you vote us out, all this will end'. How do you counter this? Secondly, AAP and BJP are foregrounding the 1984 anti-Sikh riots, invoking Rajiv Gandhi's remarks and saying, 'Congress equals 1984. Can you forgive them?' Yesterday, as you held your 'Insaaf rally', they organised a day-long '*Zakhm '84 de*' conclave, where many in the audience broke down. How do you counter these two narratives?

Regarding 1984, everyone agrees it was wrong; no one defends it. Even our former Prime Minister apologised on the floor of Parliament, Rahul Gandhi acknowledged in the US that it was *galat* (wrong). As for AAP, they hand out *khairat* (charity); we will make it a right. Furthermore, they talk about Rs 1,000 or Rs 1,500, but today, talk to our women whose children have fallen victim to drugs and gang violence, pulling our society to its lowest point; ask them what they want. Everyone in Punjab wants security. Even petty shopkeepers receive extortion calls. This is all organised under the patronage of the BJP and AAP. They turned the land of gurus, *pirs*, *fakirs* into *jungle raj* where nobody is heard. Punjab Police is capable, but they need leadership — a political leader with will and whom we can control. Having served as a police officer and Director, Sports, I understand civil and police administration inside out, and thus, I know what needs to be done. People are exhausted with *jumle* (empty slogans) and *chutkule* (jokes). You cannot feed someone's stomach with jokes nor heal their pain. Currently, three dead bodies lie in mortuaries in Punjab because Bhagwant Mann turned Punjab into a police state. I used to tell their MLAs too that you are under so much pressure from the AAP Delhi team. People chose you, people chose Punjabis, you spoke of change... We recently held our rally in Sangrur — their political backyard. If 500 people were inside the hall, double that number stood outside. Punjab never gives a fractured verdict; it gives a clear mandate. This time, from what I can see, AAP will crumble like a mound of sand. Punjab *mein purely Congress ki sarkaar aane wali hai*.

Manraj Grewal Sharma: Leading economists of Punjab say that Punjab's fiscal health is in the ICU and it has been a slide for over a decade. How do you plan to counter that? If you intend to bring free power and grants to women, how do you plan to manage Punjab's finances?

I have consulted numerous experts. I'm very clear: once we form the government, every ministry will have dedicated domain experts. Bureaucrats are not masters of every field, nor do I claim expertise over every subject. Our manifesto committee and experts are designing viable schemes to pull Punjab out of this. Yes, right now the financial position of Punjab is not very good. Punjab's debt was Rs 2.82 lakh crore before this government took over, and now it stands near Rs 4.47 lakh crore. Had the High Court not intervened to scrap their land pooling policy, they would have looted another Rs 10,000 to Rs. 20,000 crore. By managing governance professionally, we can overcome this. Yes, there will be problems because a state which does not have law and order, which has young people but not appropriate education, agriculture sector has issues, where agrarian diversification is needed and debt must be addressed too. I always see the glass as half full, because there is always a solution.

Vikas Pathak: Over the past few days, as pollution spiked in Delhi, the BJP alleged that Punjab's stubble burning is responsible. Do you think that is a justified claim?

When AAP was in Delhi, they blamed Punjab. Now BJP is in Delhi, and they blame Punjab. I had this analysed technically: winds do not blow from Punjab towards Delhi in a way that pollutes Delhi; Delhi produces vast pollution of its own. Pollution is a problem and I do not support it but the technology to manage it exists. Bhagwant Mann constantly claimed they brought technology and set up factories, but on the ground, theirs is merely a "scripted government" that manufactures events, reels, and media trials. You are one of the media houses which isn't affected by them. But the controlled media outlets spread these taglines. If politicians, bureaucrats, and the judiciary share blame for the nation's state, media houses that sold out for money share equal responsibility. Pollution, be it of any type, political or bureaucratic, is causing a loss to our country. We are trying our best to eradicate all types of pollution from Punjab.

SCAN THE QR CODE TO WATCH THE VIDEO

Vikas Pathak: There has been a lot of discussion by the BJP and Congress over the drug menace in Punjab. How serious is the problem on the ground, and if the Congress were to come to power, what would be your roadmap to counter it?

There are two things: administrative and social. Administratively, black sheep within the police will be dealt with just like drug smugglers. Officers who have fallen victim to addiction will be rehabilitated. Socially, our youth lacks education aligned with modern industrial demands and are not placeable there.

There are three types of drugs: costly narcotics like heroin/smack; synthetic drugs involving certain pharmaceutical units; and diverted pharmaceutical drugs. In Baddi (Himachal Pradesh), factories operating under the government's nose manufacture tablets with 300 mg doses where only 75 mg is permitted. AAP's own Health Minister, Balbir Singh, is a doctor by profession, yet on the floor of the house an AAP MLA revealed that procurement of de-addiction pills jumped from four crore tablets in 2022 to almost 12 crore today. They say *humne nasha band karwa diya*, but they run a scripted facade, and they don't have any vision to eradicate it; we do.

Nitin Sharma: Punjab is hosting the Asian Champions Trophy after 17 years. Sporting ties with Pakistan did not participate remain frozen. Cricket teams avoided handshakes, whereas hockey players still stuck to basic sportsmanship during Asian Games. How do you see this?

I think this is being unnecessarily politicised. Ultimately, every conflict is settled across a table. Sports fosters humanity, where merit matters above caste or religion. Those who are good for the team should be brought forward; others should be encouraged to work harder and compete. The BJP government has spread an atmosphere of hatred in recent years, but as a sportsperson, I believe in judging people by their contribution, not their identity.

Sukhbir Siwach: Why is there an impression that Congress leaders will inevitably end up fighting among themselves?

This tagline started 13 years ago. If you repeatedly call a thief a saint, they begin to appear like one. Look at what has happened in this country. On one side is the dictatorship of Modi and Amit Shah, and on the other, that of Kejriwal and Bhagwant Mann. I don't consider either dictatorship a democracy. Internal democracy must exist. I was an MLA during Captain Amarinder Singh's regime. When he did something wrong, I wrote to him and told him personally. When he didn't listen, I went to the public. In a democracy, if I cannot put forward my logical point, it is not democracy. Why call this a democratic country rather than a dictatorship? People chose Punjabis, but they didn't know they were so spineless and would surrender like this. No one becomes Bhagat Singh merely by tying Bhagat Singh's turban. He fought against foreign rulers, against those who were said to be "the empire on which the sun never sets". These are a few brokers who came from Delhi purely to loot. They looted and left, leaving Bhagwant Mann to face the consequences, since his signatures aren't on the documents. But having served in the police, I know how to bring them to account. Manish Sisodia, said in a meeting that "To win the 2027 assembly elections, we will do whatever it takes — *saam, daam, dand, bhed, sach, jhooth*, question, answer, *ladai, jhagda, jo karna padega, karenge*." He said we will show you how it is done, while AAP women and leaders clapped and laughed. Is this democracy?

Sukhbir Siwach: AAP has fielded new faces and candidates from modest backgrounds, like someone who repaired bicycle punctures. As elections approach, will your party try similar experiments?

I myself come from an ordinary household and a small farming family. Working hard and progressing is in everyone's mind. I am not against a puncture repairer, but candidates must be intelligent. Whether they are poor or rich, they should be dedicated to the state and country. Our country of 140–145 crore people faces many problems but they are entangled in caste and religion. Hitler used the same model of religion and media control. This is happening in the country. History shows this cannot be sustained.

Liz Mathew: BJP leaders in Punjab are discussing a potential alliance with SAD (Shiromani Akali Dal). Some leaders are saying that both the parties cannot stand alone and win the election. What impact would this alliance have on Punjab's electoral scene?

Both previously had an alliance and it caused immense damage to Punjab, which the people have not forgotten. Alliances are their prerogative and decisions, but Akali Dal's vote bank is the farming community, which is deeply upset with both the BJP and AAP. Sukhbir (Singh Badal) is pleading for an alliance, while BJP is assessing. I worry that if they become allies, they will sink further down the drain. Good luck to them; we are ready to play against any team.

Liz Mathew: The Congress-led opposition has been protesting regarding the SIR process and the Election Commission? How will these developments affect Punjab elections?

Regarding Form 6 amended by the Election Commission, it was neither passed in Parliament nor was it directed by the Supreme Court. A theft is theft, whether it is big or small. You might remember that they suspended 160 MPs from Parliament to pass a bill protecting the Election Commission from prosecution. It was because they were apprehensive that the EC could not be prosecuted; that is why all this mess happened. All these elections that have happened were pre-planned in their mind. In politics, issuing and amending that form without parliamentary or judicial authority is illegal. In Punjab, bureaucrats issued letters instructing lower officials, but that doesn't make the law right.

Kanchan Vasdev: Are you in the race for CM. If not, who do you think is the best suited for that role in Congress?

I am not in a position to say. Ultimately, we have a democratic setup where elected MLAs and high command observers sit together and discuss after elections.

Kanchan Vasdev: Is Congress missing Captain Amarinder Singh?

I don't think so.

Vandita Mishra: In the 2022 election, voters were fed up with both the Congress and Akali Dal, believing the two colluded behind the scenes while fighting publicly. AAP swept in on the promise of change. Now, you say people are disillusioned with AAP too, but the problems that existed then remain. Meanwhile, Congress has done little to reinvent itself — the same faces, the same rhetoric and persistent infighting. What are the two or three things Congress needs to do to convince people it can be trusted again?

I agree with you. At that time, such an atmosphere was created. But today, there is a credibility crisis across leadership in all parties. So perhaps that is why a person like me has come to this position. There will also be many new faces, many experienced people who are completely clean. I cannot claim that we will achieve 100 per cent perfection — that doesn't happen in politics. But people will see credibility and seriousness. Because I am not someone who makes jokes or throws around empty slogans.

Trump says he wants UFC chief Dana White for White House press secretary

Reuters
Washington, November 8

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump on Saturday said he had asked mixed martial arts promoter Dana White to serve as White House press secretary and called on him to bring some fighters along as assistants "even though some are not from our country."

White, chief executive of the Ultimate Fighting Championship, is a "violent Fighter and Warrior," Trump wrote in a Truth Social post.

Trump also asked for six current or former UFC titleholders to join White, including two athletes from Russia's Dagestan region, Islam Makhachev and Khabib Nurmagomedov; Americans Justin Gaethje, Daniel Cormier and "Kayla Harris," likely a reference to Kayla Harrison; and Amanda Nunes, a Brazilian native who became a US citizen last year. "We need these people to defend us against the Lunatic Left," Trump wrote.

Speaking at a press conference Saturday, White said he would meet with Trump at the White House on Monday.

GROUNDWORK IN PLACE, ANOTHER ROUND OF TRILATERAL NEGOTIATIONS TO TAKE PLACE SOON:PESKOV

Kremlin hopes US election shake-up won't alter Trump's talks on Ukraine

Spokesperson praises Melania Trump's 'successful humanitarian peace-building efforts', 'says hope that it will continue'

Associated Press
Moscow, November 8

THE REPUBLICANS' defeat in the US midterm elections was watched closely in Russia, where some observers are predicting it could herald more support for Ukraine when the Democrats take over Congress in January.

But if the Kremlin is hearing the ticking of a clock on its nearly 5-year-old full-scale invasion of its neighbor, it seemingly remains unperturbed.

Asked if the election's outcome could stymie US attempts to help negotiate a settlement between Moscow and Kyiv, Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov voiced hope that US President Donald Trump will continue to pursue his peace efforts.

"There is groundwork already in place, and another round of trilateral negotiations is set to take place very soon," Peskov said of talks planned for Tuesday and Wednesday involving Russian, Ukrainian and US representatives in Abu Dhabi, United Arab Emirates.

He also praised the "successful humanitarian peace-building efforts" by first lady Melania Trump, adding that "we hope that all of this will continue."

Last week's limited ceasefire around the Russia-occupied city of Oleshky, brokered with her help, allowed for the delivery of humanitarian aid and the evacuation of some residents.

Peskov shrugged off a question from reporters on whether the new Congress would challenge Trump's stance on Russia and Ukraine. He called it an "internal matter" for the US.

In recent months, Trump's actions appeared to favor Moscow. Last month, he struck a diesel fuel import deal with Russia in a stunning reversal of years of US pressure on the Kremlin, to the dismay of Ukraine and its European allies. He also claimed that Kyiv's attacks on Russian oil refineries caused a spike in diesel prices in the US.



President Vladimir Putin interacts with people in Red Square, Moscow, during National Unity Day celebrations. FILE

He urged Kyiv to halt the strikes, even though rising global energy prices were largely driven by the Iran war.

Trump also issued an executive order to put on hold sweeping new sanctions that clamped down on the Russian economy, telling Congress the pause was in the national interest. Lawmakers from both parties blasted Trump's move as benefiting Russian President Vladimir Putin.

At the same time, Ukraine reported a throttling of Starshield, the military-grade version of the Starlink satellite internet service owned by Elon Musk's SpaceX. Trump denied being behind the brief slowing of Starshield, but the move to limit the system that serves as the backbone of Ukraine's drone operations and battlefield communications was widely seen as part of Washington's efforts to pressure Kyiv.

The diesel deal appeared to falter this week after US federal and state officials warned that handling any shipments could bring legal consequences, and two US-bound tankers changed course. The Kremlin sought to play down the development, saying deliveries will continue.

Kyiv desperately needs to replenish its supplies of US-made Patriot interceptors to fend off Russia's ballistic missile attacks. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy has made repeated requests for Washington to speed up delivery of the defensive systems, but US stockpiles have been exhausted by the Iran war, and the US has prioritized replenishing its own arsenals.

On October 30, the Trump administration said it has approved a proposed $2.1 billion sale of Patriot interceptors for Ukraine after Kyiv had accused Pentagon of delaying delivery.



Chairman of Taiwan People's Communist Party Lin Te-wang (centre) during a protest. FILE/AP

Taiwan: Communist Party leader detained over alleged Chinese sponsorship in polls

Taijing Wu and Kanis Leung
Taipei, November 8

AUTHORITIES IN Taiwan detained the leader of the island's Taiwan People's Communist Party, accusing him of running as a candidate for borough chief under the direction and sponsorship of China's Communist Party, local media reported Sunday.

Taiwan is set to hold elections for mayors and local area chiefs on November 28. While the races focus more on livelihood issues, the results could be a good indicator of the popularity of the ruling Democratic Progressive Party under the leadership of Taiwan President Lai Ching-te ahead of the presidential election in 2028.

According to Taiwan's Central News Agency, prosecutors said in a statement Sunday that an initial investigation showed Taiwan People's Communist Party chair Lin Te-wang also had directed another party member to run as a candidate for chief in another borough.

Prosecutors also alleged that Lin sought to buy votes by repeatedly recruiting voters to travel to mainland China, where they received hospitality, the report said.

While Lin's party is not influential on the democratic island, it was not his first legal trouble over his alleged links with China. He and another party leader had faced charges of Chinese infiltration and attempting to influence elections but were found not guilty in 2025, the *Taipei Times* reported.

Taiwan's *Central News Agency* said the prosecutors had received intelligence about foreign interference in the election and summoned 14 people and nine witnesses.

After questioning, the government lawyers strongly suspected that Lin and the other party member had committed a crime and were concerned the pair could flee or destroy evidence, so they filed applications to the local courts to detain them and bar them from being visited by others, it said.

Conservative activists storm Diwali party in Seattle, condemned

Press Trust of India
Washington, November 8



"I am beyond disgusted by this vile and racist display. Diwali is an important holiday and our community should feel safe to celebrate it. This hateful display has no place in our city or this country"
PRAMILA JAYAPAL ,
WASHINGTON CONGRESSWOMAN

CONSERVATIVE ACTIVISTS led by Jake Lang stormed Diwali celebrations in Seattle carrying placards calling for deporting all "dot heads", an act that was swiftly condemned by US lawmakers and community leaders.

Lang and fellow activist Thomas Allen waved the American flag and carried placards with slogans "Deport All Dot Heads" and "Stop Hindu Replacement of Christians" in front of a stage where a dance performance was being held on Saturday.

Videos of the storming of the Diwali celebrations in Seattle went viral on social media.

The activists were soon escorted out of the Diwali celebrations at the Seattle Center Armoury which was part of Seattle Center Festal, a series of 25 free cultural festivals that collectively draw about 400,000 visitors annually.

Lang is associated with an organisation 'White Replacement' and was among the attackers of the US Capitol on January 6, 2021. He served a four-year jail term and was later pardoned by US President Donald Trump on the first day of his second presidency in 2025 Congresswoman Pramila Jayapal said she was "beyond disgusted" at the vile and racist display.

"I am beyond disgusted by this vile and racist display. Diwali is an important holiday and our community should feel safe to celebrate it. This hateful display has no place in our city or this country," Jayapal, the Congresswoman from Washington, said in a post on X.

Former White House advisor Ajay Jain Bhutoria said the actions of Lang and Allen were "absolutely disgusting." "Targeting Hindu Americans and Indian immigrants with racial slurs and conspiracy rhetoric has no place in this country. We stand against this racism and for the right of every American to celebrate their heritage freely," Bhutoria said in a post on X.

"We condemn such actions and advise community members to stay vigilant while celebrating Diwali, as these activists have announced plans to disrupt other celebrations," Coalition of Hindus of North America (CoHNA) said on X.

The disruption by the far-right activists came a day after Trump lit the traditional diya at the Oval Office and Washington Governor Bob Ferguson joined the Diwali celebrations at Indian Consulate General in Seattle.

"Washington state is proud to be home to one of the largest communities of Indian Americans in the country. ... We had the fastest-growing Indian American population in the entire country. And we have seen this community contribute so much to our state," Ferguson said.

Poles mourn rare mass killing in Krakaw, authorities say attacker had far-right views

Associated Press
Krakow, November 8

POLAND BEGAN two days of national mourning on Sunday, after a 24-year-old man with far-right views drove into a busy central square in Krakow and opened fire, killing six people and wounding 15 others before police shot and wounded him.

The attack, which Poland's defense minister described as an "act of terror," happened on Saturday in Main Square, which is in the heart of Krakow's Old Town and is a major tourist hub in country's second-largest city.

By evening, mourners had left candles in memory of the victims. The square remained partially closed on Sunday morning as authorities continued their investigation.

Authorities also found three dead bodies at the man's family home in Ostrowiec Świętokrzyski, a city about 150 kilometers northeast of Krakow. The police said on Sunday they were the bodies of the attacker's sister, mother and father. The family members died from gunshot wounds, police said.



Candles and flowers are placed near the main market square, following a mass shooting, in Krakow on Sunday. REUTERS

Four women and two men were killed in the Main Square shooting. Three of the women and one of the men were Polish, Krzysztof Jan Klęczar, the Malopolska regional governor, said on Sunday. A man from the UK and a woman from an unidentified foreign country were also among the dead.

The two police officers who stopped the attacker, in actions authorities hailed as heroic, remain in hospital. One of them is still in a coma while the other woke up from a coma, Klęczar said. Officials launched an appeal for blood donations for the benefit of the most seriously wounded policeman.

"If it weren't for the efficient and selfless intervention of these two young men, the number of victims could have been significantly higher," Klęczar said.

Five non-Poles are among the wounded. They come from the UK, Portugal, Russia, Germany and Austria.

The attacker is also in critical state, having been operated multiple times. There was confusion on Saturday about the shooter's age, with authorities first saying 24 and later 25. On Sunday they confirmed he is 24.

Interior Minister Marcin Kierwiński said the attacker holds "very radical" and "ultra-nationalistic" views.

• BRIEFLY

VATICAN CITY

Pope Leo heads to Milei's Argentina as tensions loom over austerity, Iran



Pope Leo XIV

POPE LEO heads on Sunday to Argentina on the second leg of a 12-day tour across South America, where the first US-born pope will give a closely watched speech to Argentine President Javier Milei. The address may underscore tensions between the Vatican and Milei, whose austerity agenda has been criticized by the Church for hitting the poorest most and who has strongly supported the Iran war. Leo, on an ambitious three-country tour through November 17, is arriving in Argentina from Uruguay, where he urged South American countries to tackle regional issues together and set an example for value of diplomacy over conflict. REUTERS

Meloni blames pro-Russian hackers for minister's data leak on dark web

Associated Press
Milan, November 8

ITALIAN FOREIGN Minister Antonio Tajani said Saturday that his personal data had been disseminated on the dark web, an encrypted part of the internet, and that he has been exposed to "threats and intimidation." Italian Premier Giorgia Meloni blamed pro-Russian hackers for the leak.

Tajani made the announcement in a social media post following a string of hoax bomb threats across Europe that caused flight diversions, security threats against broadcasters as well as recent attacks on supermarket refrigeration systems and drone incursions.

"For days, cybercriminals have been spreading my personal data on the dark web and seeking other information, in fact exposing me and my family to new threats and intimidation," Tajani said, adding that the criminals "are prepared to pay for other details on me and my loved ones."



Italian Premier Giorgia Meloni

Meloni, is a separate statement, expressed solidarity with Tajani "following revelations about the activities of pro-Russian hackers, and publication on dark web of personal data."

She called attempts to sell confidential information about government officials "a matter of grave concern that must be addressed with the utmost determination."

Tajani, who is also a vice premier in Italy's government, did not specify what kind of information had been shared, but suggested that the cyber-threat was ongoing. "I will not allow myself to be intimidated in any way," Tajani said. "I will continue working to defend my ministry, and Italy, and I will further strengthen the ties and cooperation to protect ourselves together."

2 dead, 20 injured as bus overturns on highway in Croatia

Zagreb: At least two people were killed and several injured when a bus overturned on a highway in Croatia on Sunday, police said.

The bus with Serbian license plates skidded off the road and overturned at 7:25 am while traveling in the direction of the Croatian capital, Zagreb, police said. The reason for the accident was not immediately clear.

The A3 highway in Croatia leads from the Serbian border, by Zagreb and toward Slovenia.

Emergency services said that 33 passengers and two drivers were on the bus when it crashed. Around 20 people have been injured, some seriously, Dario Kezeric, Zagreb county firefighters' commander, told the state *HRT* broadcaster. AP

COLOMBIA

3 soldiers killed in drone strike at military complex

A DRONE attack on a military base in northern Colombia killed three soldiers and injured 16, Colombia's army said in a statement Saturday. **"Those who were behind this attack ... will have nowhere to hide. Every attack against our soldiers strengthens our resolve to defend Colombia," President Abelardo de la Espriella said in a post on X Saturday. AP**

PAKISTAN

Police officer killed in blast in KPK province

A POLICE officer was killed in an explosion in Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province on Sunday, police said. Constable Qayyum Khan, posted at Martung Police Station in the district, was killed when a remote-controlled bomb rigged to a parked motorcycle detonated as he was on his way to the police station, police said in a statement. PTI

• ENVIRONMENTAL GROUPS USE AI TO TRACK FOREST FIRES, COUNT WILDLIFE, SAY AI'S BENEFITS CURRENTLY OUTWEIGH ITS ENVIRONMENTAL COSTS

Environmental groups embrace AI, even as they warn of data centre impacts

Valerie Volcovici
Washington, November 8

ENVIRONMENTAL GROUPS worldwide are using artificial intelligence to analyze climate data, track forest fires and count endangered wildlife – embracing a technology they also warn is driving a surge in electricity demand, water use and greenhouse-gas emissions.

The contradiction is forcing these organizations to justify their AI use in carrying out missions to combat climate change or protect natural resources. "We recognize that AI can come with environmental costs, and we need to be thoughtful about how we use it," said Ali Swanson, AI lead at the US nonprofit Conservation International.

"But at a time when the climate and biodiversity crises are becoming more urgent, AI can help us move faster and make better use of the information we're collecting."

The group recently started using AI to assess hotspots detected by satellites and send real-time alerts to community forest patrols about potential wildfires in remote and environmentally sensitive parts of Cambodia.

Reuters interviewed 15 major environmental, conservation and development organizations about their AI use. All said they used the technology in some form and expressed concern about the environmental impact of the data centres powering it. The centres, filled with servers, can require vast amounts of electricity, along with water for cooling.

It's a global dilemma for individuals, governments and industries balancing AI's benefits with its enormous risks.

The tradeoffs likely will grab attention at the UN's COP31 climate conference this month, when host Turkey will call on governments, businesses and other institutions to sign a pledge outlining principles to ensure AI is developed and deployed sustainably.

UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres wants major AI companies to publicly disclose their systems' environmental impacts.



Kenyan researchers from a Save the Elephants research camp operate a surveillance drone at the Samburu National Reserve in Kenya. REUTERS

Researchers at the United Nations University Institute for Water, Environment and Health estimate the global data-center footprint could more than double by 2030, reaching a size about twice that of Jakarta, the Indonesian megalopolis.

The International Energy Agency estimates global data centers will consume about 945 terawatt-hours of electricity annually by 2030, producing the equivalent of over 300 million metric tons of carbon dioxide.

The agency also projects that global data center water consumption will increase from about 560 billion litres in 2023 to about 1.2 trillion litres annually by 2030.

Technology giants including Microsoft , Amazon and Alphabet's Google have reported rising emissions linked in part to data center expansion, raising questions about their ability to meet own long-term climate goals.

Kenya's Save the Elephants, a partner of the Wildlife Conservation Network, said it is using machine learning to improve population surveys and study elephant communication.

Frank Pope, the group's chief executive, said an aerial survey of Kenya's largest protected area last year generated roughly 200,000 images that took nine people nine months to review manually. AI models trained on Nvidia's GeForce graphics platforms can now complete similar analyses in hours.

"The results have been eye-opening," Pope said. "We found that human surveys were missing about a third of the elephants, roughly half of zebras and giraffes, and three-quarters of oryx populations."

More accurate wildlife data can help secure financing for conservation, he said.

"Ultimately, these tools make nature measurable and therefore investable," he said.

"That's a critical transformation, if we're going to conserve biodiversity at scale."

At the institute founded by the late conservation icon Jane Goodall, researchers are using AI to digitize decades of field notes about chimpanzee behavior in Tanzania's Gombe National Park. REUTERS

INVESTMENTS ROSE 26.36% IN Q3, ACCOUNTING FOR NEARLY HALF OF TAIWAN'S GROWTH OF 14.36%

AI has made Taiwan the world's fastest growing large economy

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, November 8

INDIA, FOR several years, has been flying the flag of the world's fastest growing large economy. But that won't be the case this year. In 2026, it is Taiwan that is posting eye-watering growth numbers.

All thanks to artificial intelligence (AI).

Stock markets driven by AI, including Taiwan's, may have tanked sharply in recent days, but data released October 30 showed Taiwan's real GDP grew by a stunning 14.36% in July-September. This follows 15.43% in January-March and 12.93% in April-June. And as per Taiwan's Directorate General of Budget, Accounting and Statistics, growth in 2026 as a whole is expected to be 11.05% and 6.04% in 2027. In 2025, it had grown by 8.76%. Economists think these are underestimates and growth will be close to 13% in 2026 and north of 6.5% next year.

In comparison, India's GDP growth rate in the first two quarters of 2026 have been 8.6% and 7.8%, respectively.

Is Taiwan even a large economy? India, for instance, is 90 times larger and 60 times more populous. But the difference in their GDP is not as big: almost $4 trillion for India and $1 trillion for Taiwan. In 2025, it was the 22nd largest economy in the world, ahead of the likes of Singapore, Norway, and South Africa. So, it's certainly not small.

The TSMC factor

Key to Taiwan's astonishing growth is perhaps the most important company in the world: Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Company, or TSMC, the world's largest manufacturer of semiconductor chips.

The European Centre for International Political Economy estimated in January that TSMC accounts for nearly a tenth of Taiwan's GDP. But that was then: its net revenue in 2026 is seen at $175 billion, 43% higher than last year.

TSMC is one of the key companies at the centre of the global AI investment boom. And this spending spree is what is fuelling Taiwan's growth. In July-September, Taiwan's investments were up 26.36% year-on-year and responsible for almost half the growth rate of 14.36%.

The other major driver was exports — after all, TSMC's semiconductor chips have to be exported — which were up 21.12%, with net exports explaining a third of the headline GDP growth rate. In September, Taiwan posted a record trade surplus of $23.63 billion after exports jumped 61% to $87.22 billion.

Together, investments and exports were the reason for almost 80% of the growth. "The composition suggests that the AI upcycle is increasingly spilling over from exports into local equipment spending, capacity expansion and broader economic activity," OCBC Bank Economist Herbert Wong noted.

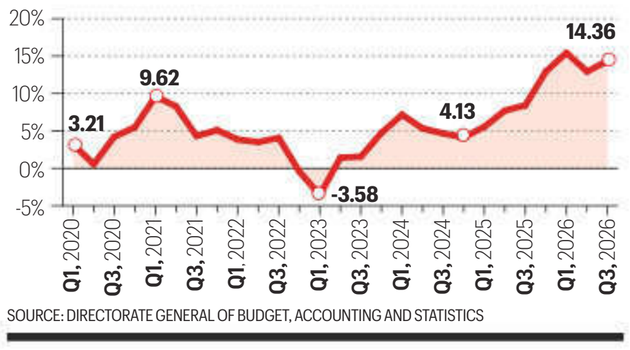
Korea, US sparkle too

Taiwan, of course, is not the only country that is being driven by the AI investment boom.

In South Korea — dominated by tech giants Samsung and SK Hynix — growth in July-September was 3.4%, data released last week showed. This follows 3.8% and 3.7% in the first two quarters. While this doesn't sound as impressive as Taiwan's numbers, two things are worth keeping in mind: one, South Korea's GDP is twice that of Taiwan; two, growth in 2025 was just 1.1%.

Again, the main drivers of growth were investments (up 4.3%) and exports (8.6%). Within investments, money spent on facilities was up a huge 9.4%, thanks to continued expenditure on things like semiconductor manufacturing equipment. Third quarter growth in the other key AI market, US, also came in at 3.4%. This is perhaps even more impressive than South Korea's number considering growth in the same quarter last year was 3.9% — developed economies just don't grow so fast. Until now. FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• TAIWAN'S ECONOMY RIDES THE AI BOOM



SOURCE: DIRECTORATE GENERAL OF BUDGET, ACCOUNTING AND STATISTICS

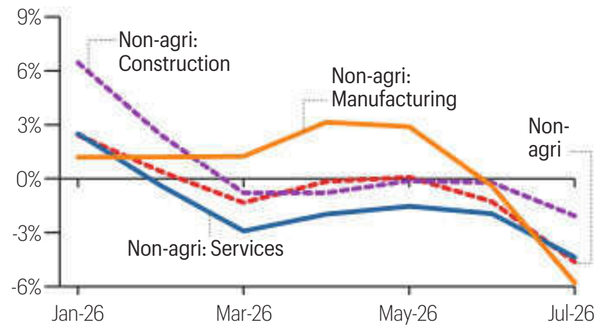
• 'RURAL COUGHS, CAPEX SPARKS, EXPORTS SHINE'

- HSBC economists see signs of some moderation in Indian economic momentum during the second half of the year, with 67% of the 100 indicators they track growing positively in September, down from 78% in August.
- GDP for Jul-Sept will be released later this month. And while growth is seen lower from Q1's 7.8%, it may still print above 7%.



However, the decline in India's real rural wages cannot be ignored

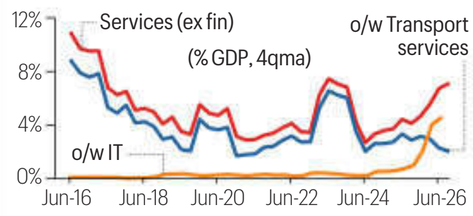
Real rural wages, deflated by rural CPI
q-o-q sa, ann



- On the consumption side, while rural demand has held steady, falling real rural wages "cannot be ignored", HSBC said in the report.

IT/IT enabled services are driving capex, reflecting data centre optimism

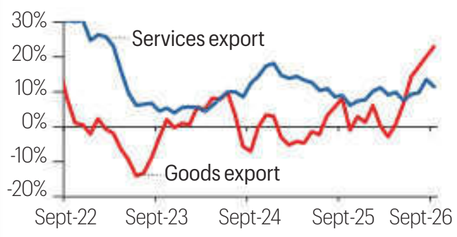
New investment intentions Services (ex financials)



- On the other hand, manufacturing and renewable energy investment intentions have slowed. On the whole, investment intentions are rising only in value terms, but not in volume terms.

Goods exports are outpacing services exports for the first time in many years

% y-o-y Goods and services export



- Although non-oil goods and high-tech exports are doing well, mid-and low-tech exports have remained sluggish for a decade now.

SOURCE: HSBC GLOBAL INVESTMENT RESEARCH. (4QMA: FOUR-QUARTER MOVING AVERAGE). (SA, ANN: SEASONALLY ADJUSTED, ANNUALISED)

Gold, silver outlook hinges on US-Iran tensions, global inflation data next week

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, November 8

BULLION PRICES are likely to remain under pressure next week as investors track developments in the US-Iran conflict, movements in crude oil prices and inflation data for cues on the outlook for interest rates, analysts said.

The focus will be on inflation prints from China, the US, Germany, Japan and India. Investors will also track speeches by Federal Reserve officials and US employment data.

Chinese economic indicators will be important for industrial metals, they added.

Geopolitical developments will remain a key driver after US President Donald Trump confirmed fresh military strikes on Iran, while claiming that Washington had made "a lot of progress" in negotiations with Tehran, adding another layer of uncertainty.

The domestic commodities market will remain closed during the morning session on Tuesday due to Diwali-Balipratipada.

"Gold and silver's momentum remains down as investors will focus on the inflation data from China, the US, Germany, Japan, India, etc. along with some Fed officials' commentary," said Pranav Mer, Senior Vice President, EBG, Commodity & Currency Research, JM Financial Services Ltd.

• BUSINESSES EXPECT HIGHER AI SPENDING

Indian businesses are set to increase their artificial intelligence (AI) investments, with nearly seven in ten planning higher spending over the next year. However, only 30% report broad or strong returns from their AI initiatives, a Dun & Bradstreet survey found.

Data readiness gap

3% of Indian businesses say their enterprise data is fully ready to support AI at scale, compared with 8% globally.

44% describe their enterprise data as partially ready, while 42% say it is mostly ready.

AI investment returns

30% report broad or strong returns on investment from AI.

46% report pockets of returns, while 10% say most pilots have scaled with clear gains.

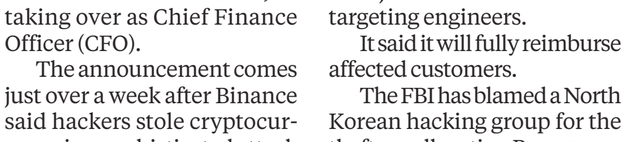
AI moves into production

60%+ of businesses have moved beyond planning and piloting, with 35% scaling pilots into production.

26% report that AI is already embedded across multiple core processes.

INVESTMENT RISING: 7 IN 10 INDIAN BUSINESSES EXPECT HIGHER AI SPENDING IN NEXT 12 MONTHS

How much do you expect AI related spending (R&D, infrastructure, talent) to change in the next 12 months?



69% Businesses that expect to increase AI spending over the next 12 months.

Nearly 70% Businesses that believe AI will contribute towards new products, services, business models or operational improvements in the next quarter.



"India has reached an exciting inflection point in its AI journey. The ambition is clearly visible, and businesses are increasingly seeing tangible returns from their AI investments."

JULIAN PROWER, EXECUTIVE VICE PRESIDENT, GLOBAL BUSINESS OPERATIONS & TRANSFORMATION AND MANAGING DIRECTOR & CEO, INDIA & TAIWAN, DUN & BRADSTREET

SOURCE: DUN & BRADSTREET AI MOMENTUM SURVEY, 2026

Binance CFO Kaiser Ng steps down, Justin Yek named new finance chief

Reuters
Mexico City, November 8

BINANCE'S FINANCE Chief Kaiser Ng is leaving the company to pursue another venture, the world's biggest cryptocurrency exchange said days after hackers stole $6.3 billion from the platform in a record heist.

"Kaiser Ng has decided to pursue a new venture after more than five years at Binance, with a transition plan implemented over the last half year," Binance Co-Chief Executive Officer Yi He said in a statement on Saturday.

Justin Yek, a longtime finance executive who was most recently vice-president of finance at Airwallex, is taking over as Chief Finance Officer (CFO).

The announcement comes just over a week after Binance said hackers stole cryptocurrency in a sophisticated attack that began months earlier with the compromise of several employees' computers. Binance said the breach, which unfolded on October 29, started with malware hidden in software downloads and fake job recruitment efforts targeting engineers.

It said it will fully reimburse affected customers.

The FBI has blamed a North Korean hacking group for the theft, an allegation Pyongyang has denied.

Safe harbour for social media platforms: Why Centre is weighing a legal rethink

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, November 8

SOCIAL MEDIA platforms decide what billions of people see online, amplify some posts over others through their algorithms, and enforce their own rules on what content is permissible. Yet, when it comes to legal responsibility for that content, they are largely treated as passive carriers of information. This distinction, which has helped companies such as Meta, Google and X build vast businesses, is now coming under scrutiny in India.

The Centre has begun preliminary discussions on whether social media companies such as Facebook, Instagram, YouTube and X should continue to enjoy legal protection from liability for content posted by their users, *The Indian Express* has reported. The deliberations, which are still at an exploratory stage, could eventually lead to a rethink of one of the most important legal provisions governing the internet in India.

At issue is the principle of "safe harbour", which has allowed social media companies to host enormous volumes of user-generated content without being treated as the publishers of every post, video or comment appearing on their platforms.

A section of the government has questioned whether companies that use algorithms to determine the visibility and reach of content should continue to receive the same protections as services that merely transmit information. No decision has been taken, and it remains unclear whether these discussions will translate into a formal legislative proposal.



Safe harbour allows social media companies to host user content without being held liable as publishers. REUTERS

On Friday (November 6), IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw did not conclusively confirm or deny whether the government was considering withdrawing safe harbour protections for social media platforms, but stressed that such companies must take greater responsibility for preventing online harms.

"Today, social media platforms must take the responsibility for child safety, for women's safety, for digital arrest, for the harms which come to the citizens... social media platforms must take proactive steps. Unlike the past, they must take proactive steps to make sure that our society is safe," Vaishnaw said.

Why safe harbour matters

Section 79 of the Information Technology (IT) Act, 2000 provides conditional immunity to internet intermediaries from legal liability arising from information published or transmitted by third parties.

Under the provision, an intermediary can claim this protection if it does not initiate a transmission, select its recipient or select or modify the information being transmitted. It must also comply with prescribed due diligence obligations. The protection is not absolute, and intermediaries can lose it in specified circumstances, including involvement in unlawful activity or failure to act on legally valid directions concerning unlawful content.

In its landmark 2015 Shreya Singhal judgment, the Supreme Court clarified that the obligation to remove unlawful content under Section 79(3)(b) must be linked to a court order or appropriate government notification, consistent with constitutional restrictions on free speech.

Safe harbour is arguably among the most consequential legal protections underpinning the modern internet. Without it, platforms could potentially face legal proceedings over millions of posts made by users, even when the companies themselves did not create the content.

For companies such as Meta and Google, this protection has been fundamental to building businesses based on user-generated content at an enormous scale, while avoiding the liability traditionally associated with publishers exercising editorial control over material. The central question emerging within sections of the government is whether today's social media companies can still be described as neutral intermediaries.

Unlike internet service providers or telecom operators, social media platforms use recommendation systems to prioritise content, promote particular posts and determine what individual users encounter. They also enforce their own community standards, which may differ from requirements under Indian law.

One line of thinking being explored is whether safe harbour should be confined to relatively passive services, such as internet and telecom providers or certain peer-to-peer messaging services.

However, this remains a preliminary consideration, and a broad withdrawal of statutory protection from social media platforms would likely require amendments to the IT Act and parliamentary approval.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• FINANCE MINISTER NIRMALA SITHARAMAN INVOKED THE 1957 CASE AFTER RAHUL GANDHI CRITICISED THE CENTRE'S SALE OF A MAJORITY STAKE IN IDBI BANK

1957 Mundhra case: How an LIC deal triggered India's first major financial scandal

George Mathew & Akash Mandal
Mumbai, November 8

LOK SABHA Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi recently criticised the Centre over the sale of a majority stake in IDBI Bank, drawing a response from Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, who evoked India's first major financial scandal: the 1957 Mundhra case.

"We all know how @INCIndia has used Banks and financial institutions as personal entities and pressured bank employees to extend loans at their whim... In 1957, Haridas Mundra got money from LIC due to influence by the Congress leaders," she posted on X on October 30.

The case involved money entrusted by millions of policyholders to the Life Insurance Corporation (LIC) allegedly being turned into a lifeline for a collapsing business empire. When MP Feroze Gandhi, the husband of former Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, blew the lid off the controversial deal in Parliament, the revelations sent shockwaves through the corridors of power.

It triggered a public judicial inquiry and culminated in the resignation of Finance Minister T T Krishnamachari.

The Mundhra scandal became a defining test of public accountability and the government's responsibility to protect policyholders' money.

Who was Haridas Mundhra?

At the centre was Haridas Mundhra, a Kolkata-based businessman and stock market operator who had built an extensive corporate empire through aggressive acquisitions. His expansion, however, depended increasingly on borrowed money and mounting financial obligations.

By 1957, his businesses were under severe financial pressure. A controversial LIC transaction soon raised questions about whether government machinery had been mobilised to protect a private businessman.

As per the records available in *The Indian Express* archives, LIC purchased shares worth Rs 1,26,86,100 in six Mundhra-associated companies: British India Corporation, Jessop and Company, Richardson and Cruddas, Smith Stanistreet and Company, Osler Electric Lamp Manufacturing Company and Angelo Brothers. It was the largest single investment undertaken by the newly established insurance corporation.

The transaction's execution, however, proved controversial. Instead of purchasing shares through normal stock market operations at prevailing prices, LIC concluded the deal hurriedly at prices negotiated directly with Mundhra. LIC's investment committee was not consulted. Established safeguards were bypassed despite government officials being aware of Mundhra's questionable business practices.

The subsequent Chagla Commission found that the investment lacked propriety and violated established business rules. It also endorsed Feroze Gandhi's allegation that some shares transferred by Mundhra were forged.



The case involved money entrusted by policyholders to LIC allegedly being turned into a lifeline for a collapsing business empire. REUTERS

As *The Indian Express* archives show, the central question was why a public institution had undertaken such an extraordinary transaction without following its safeguards.

Feroze Gandhi takes on his own govt

The scandal might have remained buried in official files but for Feroze Gandhi, the Congress MP from Rae Bareli and son-in-law of Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru. On December 16, 1957, Gandhi delivered a forceful intervention in the Lok Sabha, exposing LIC's questionable investments in Mundhra-controlled companies.

His intervention was significant because he was challenging his own party's government, which enjoyed overwhelming political dominance under Nehru. The controversy had surfaced through parliamentary questions in November 1957. The Finance Ministry acknowledged an investment of approximately Rs 1.26 crore in companies in which Mundhra had an interest. Dissatisfied with the response, Gandhi pursued the matter.

His investigation transformed a financial transaction into a major political and institutional crisis. Recognising the seriousness of the allegations, Nehru spoke of the majesty of Parliament and announced a judicial inquiry. The scandal could no longer be brushed aside, archives show.

Chagla Commission tears apart govt defence

The government appointed a commission headed by Justice M C Chagla, then Chief Justice of the Bombay High Court, to investigate the transactions. Its proceedings were conducted publicly. The findings were deeply damaging. Chagla described Mundhra not as an industrialist but as "an adventurer whose passion was to swallow as many firms as possible." His business methods, the commission observed, were dubious, to say the least. The inquiry rejected the argument that LIC's investment was a legitimate attempt to protect the stock market. The shares had been purchased through a hurried, privately negotiated transaction rather than ordinary market operations. The commission found that H M Patel, the Principal Finance Secretary, had instructed LIC Chairman K R Kamath to buy the shares. However, there was conflicting evidence over whether Patel had acted independently or with the approval of FM T T Krishnamachari. Patel maintained that the minister had approved the proposal, while Krishnamachari said he had merely asked the secretary to examine it.

Chagla held that the minister could not escape moral and constitutional responsibility by relying on this distinction, even if subordinate officials had executed the transaction.

The commission's examination of the government's parliamentary responses added another dimension to the scandal. After a newspaper reported that LIC had purchased questionable shares in private companies, the Finance Ministry issued a technically correct but misleading response to a parliamentary question.

The ministry's original draft contained details of investments in British India Corporation and other Mundhra-controlled companies.

Krishnamachari crossed out the relevant portion and substituted an answer that dismissed the report. The issue had now extended beyond an irregular investment to whether Parliament had been deliberately misled about public funds.

The episode was particularly embarrassing for a government that claimed to uphold parliamentary accountability, according to reports in *The Indian Express* archives.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

NEW ZEALAND VS INDIA ODI SERIES

Pace, bounce Brar's X-factors but he needs better control

26-year-old watched Steyn videos, learned from Morkel; consistently bowls at 140kmph

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, November 8



Gurnoor Brar had figures of 4/30 in the second ODI. CREIMAS

IT TOOK Shubman Gill one session with Gurnoor Brar to pick up the phone and get the pacer into an Under-23 squad. Gill had seen him bowl in Katoch Shield matches, in his own India Under-19 days, and helped him into the Mohali district team before the Punjab call came.

Almost a year before Brar reached the international circuit, with a dozen first-class games to his name, India head coach Gautam Gambhir was keeping an eye on him. The previous selection panel under Ajit Agarkar felt the same and fast-tracked him into the pool of pacers at the Centre of Excellence. The staff there believe India have found a true fast bowler, one with red-ball DNA in him.

The hype did not come from the IPL, where he has played one match, in 2023. It came from 22 first-class games and the grind that goes with them. Those who have worked with him describe a bowler built for the red ball, who understands what it takes to be a Test cricketer. Even before he broke into the India white-ball set-up, he had the work ethic of a fast bowler.

His father thought his height would help him in sport and steered him towards basketball. Brar's love was always cricket, and fast bowling in particular. He took the game seriously only in his late teens.

Steyn influence

He watched endless videos of Dale Steyn. Beyond the aggression and the lengths, he seems to have understood that it was with the red ball that Steyn became a lethal pacer for years. Somewhere along the way Steyn's line, "take the conditions out of equations when you are searching for wickets," got him thinking.

So Brar got down to hitting a length where the batsman invariably has to play. If they did, it gave him two ways in: the top of off-stump, or the edge in the cordon.

"Obviously Morne Morkel teaches us a lot. How to use my height. He too had a similar style of bowling. So he keeps telling me a lot. Which length will suit us more on which wicket," Brar said.

Those who admire him agree on his strength: pace and bounce. It is what the 26-year-old has shown through his brief international career.

At Wellington, on a spicy deck, he took 4/30, his career best and first four-wicket haul in ODIs, to help bowl New Zealand out for 134, and he showed maturity too.

On a pitch with tennis-ball bounce, he could have bowled too short and threatened nobody. He did not. By the time he struck, Auqib Nabi and Anshul Kamboj had taken three wickets. Daryl Mitchell, who spent 104 balls on the way to a fighting 55, looked more watchful against Kamboj's movement than Brar's pace. He and Mitchell Santner added 59 to take New Zealand past 100.

Then Brar broke the innings. He was patient with his length, and the batsmen struggled. Then his bounce took over, and Tom Latham and Glenn Phillips fell in the same over. New Zealand were 53/5, and lost their last five wickets for 22 runs. Brar also removed Nathan Smith in the 40th over.

"Every day I learn what I could have done better. So that is what I learn from every match. And I try to adapt the good things in my memories. And you said that the short ball wickets are good. But before that, whatever spell I had put, I was trying to go full. That I should keep the batsman a little ahead. And with that patience, if I hit the bouncer, I know that my bouncer is effective. But it will be a little wrong to overuse it," Brar said after India won the rain-curtailed game by four runs on DLS to go 2-0 up in the five-match series.

Several pacers are auditioning for the ODI XI, and Brar is among those giving India's think-tank most encouragement. The team is still working out who fits its pace attack, and whether it can find a seamer who takes wickets in the middle overs.

Brar will eventually compete with Prasidh Krishna, another quick. Unlike Prasidh, he consistently clocks 140kmph and above, and has one repeatable action. What he still has to find is control over his line and length. Once that is in place, Brar can be the fast bowler he wants to be: one who takes the conditions out of the equation.

Defence over attack: Indian juniors find their template

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, November 8



Jagsher Singh Khangurra (L) and Dev Ruparelia. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

THIS IS a generation that grew up watching Japanese automaton Kento Momota dominate 2018 and 2019. So when Jagsher Singh Khangurra, India's World Junior Championships bronze medallist, and Dev Ruparelia, bound for the Youth Olympics, both thick friends incidentally, talk of basing their game on a sturdy defence, they are describing how their early coaches saw the Momota way: an organic path to develop their wards slowly.

A lack of strength in the formative years makes the defensive detour a safe choice when you don't have the horsepower to hit the road hard on a straight attacking freeway. "You can frustrate the opponent by retrieving, knowing he will get restless if he can't finish the shuttle," explains Ruparelia, a top junior from Nala Sopara-Virar in Mumbai, who is headed for the Youth Olympics in Dakar.

He has the overhead crosscourt hit and a body smash, but those are infrequently summoned. Plan A is to strike a good length and wear out the opponent's patience.

"I know I can switch to attack if needed," he says, though the switch is a slow conversion from defence to offence, not a flick of a button, and needs a few more strokes, for which they train. The Ayush Shetty path is not open to them because they are not 6ft 4in. "But Jagsher will eventually have to build a good hit, which will come with strength. Even Kodai Naraoka has started attacking," his coach Sagar Chopda reminds.

Ruparelia did not grow up watching badminton. His divinities were "Sachin bhagwaan and Kohli", like his father's. He lived and loved carrom in the far-flung northern suburbs of Mumbai's Western line, where his father is a businessman.

He entered a local tournament, lost pitifully and went home sobbing, whereupon his dad extracted a promise that he would learn badminton instead, and took him to Club One. He met Jagsher in 2021, coming out of the lockdown, and paired with him at one point, both sharing a defensive-tinted style of play.

Momota's reign was over by then, but the defensive path endured in pockets from Nabha in Punjab to Nala Sopara in Maharashtra. Ruparelia picked up good results during a month-long tournament circuit in Europe: four weeks, two titles, one quarter-final. His coach had prepared him for the pushes, lifts and half smashes.

"By defence I don't mean I run around aimlessly," he is at pains to clarify. "I can attack later," he says, after winning the trials for the Youth Games. "India has medals there but never a gold," he says, backing himself to the hilt, even if the World Juniors did not go to plan.

15-point game format

He digs the games of Lee Chong Wei and Shi Yuqi too, hoping to riff off their attacking kills. There is a school of thought that ultra-defensive players, such as former World Junior silver medallist Sankar Muthusamy Subramanian and the new brat pack, might benefit from the 15-point game that arrives in January, by staying sturdy and piling pressure on attackers in a hurry to make mistakes.

They tend to be feisty and defiant about their style too, a quality coaches appreciate, even as they insist the players need that one big finishing kill, because nobody can retrieve endlessly. The junior crop is not exactly taking after Ayush Shetty, barring Rounak Chouhan, who has a naturally attacking game.

Kodai made the World Championships final this year after injecting a stinging hit into his game, but it took him two years. Simply put, it is easier said than done.

India A take 428-run lead

Press Trust of India
Lincoln, November 8

DHRUV JUREL, Tilak Varma and Washington Sundar struck half-centuries before Prasidh Krishna claimed two wickets as India A took a lead of 428 runs against New Zealand A to dominate the second day of the third unofficial Test here on Sunday.

Resuming at 227 for two, India A rode on fifties by skipper Jurel (71), Tilak (81 not out) and Washington (50 not out) to post 464 for five before the hosts declared their first innings after 146 overs.

Returning to the side after recovering from a left hamstring injury, fast bowler Prasidh struck twice to remove New Zealand A openers Rhys Mariu and Curtis Heaphy, leaving the visitors struggling at 36 for 2 at stumps.

At the end of play, Dean Foxcroft (10) and Zak Gibson (1) were at the crease with NZ A.

Earlier, Jurel, who was on 12 on Saturday, added 31 with Tilak Varma en route to a 71 off 95 balls. He reached his fifty off 75 balls before being dismissed by Cameron Paul.

Tilak, who is playing as the back-up due to Rishabh Pant's unavailability, added 44 with Ravindra Jadeja (25) before forging an unfinished 114 with Washington.

After Jadeja was dismissed by Gibson, who claimed his second wicket of the day, with Matthew Boyle taking the catch, Tilak and Washington batted with purpose to take India A past the 400-run mark in 130.5 overs.

BRIEF SCORES: India A 464/5dcld (Yashasvi Jaiswal 102, Sai Sudharsan 88, Tilak Varma 81, Dhruv Jurel 71; Zak Gibson 2/73) vs New Zealand A 36/2 (Prasidh Krishna 2/12)



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